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a laugh-out-loud then tingle-all-over rollercoaster."
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NOT YOU AGAIN

ERIN LA ROSA

NOT YOU AGAIN



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CANARY STREET PRESS

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Dedication

*For anyone who wants to be stuck in a horny time loop,
this one's for you.*

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Contents

Cover

Title Page

Dedication

Chapter 1

Chapter 2

Chapter 3

Chapter 4

Chapter 5

Chapter 6

Chapter 7

Chapter 8

Chapter 9

Chapter 10

Chapter 11

Chapter 12

Chapter 13

Chapter 14

Chapter 15

Chapter 16

Chapter 17

Chapter 18

Chapter 19

Chapter 20

Chapter 21

Chapter 22

Chapter 23
Chapter 24
Chapter 25
Chapter 26
Chapter 27
Chapter 28
Chapter 29
Chapter 30
Chapter 31
Chapter 32
Epilogue

Acknowledgments

About the Author

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Also by Erin La Rosa

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About the Publisher

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Chapter 1

Carly

Day 1

Carly Hart was what one former friend had called “an emotional basket case.” She cried openly, in public, with very little concern for who saw. And it wasn’t just big moments that caused her to tear up—a breakup, losing out on a job, having to fly out from LAX—but the little things, too. Like when she tripped on a sidewalk crack and accidentally squished a caterpillar, or the time she went to take a shower after a workout and the water came out cold instead of hot. Carly felt deeply without much effort. Crying was cathartic, natural and part of her way of life.

But it had been a week since her dad died and still, not a single tear. She’d imagined his funeral would be the thing that finally broke her. Yet, here she was, sitting in front of his casket, and . . . nothing. Flower arrangements lined the walls, white folding chairs were arranged in neat rows and a blown-up photo of her dad from thirty years ago with a film camera on one shoulder and a four-year-old Carly on the other was placed in front of the coffin. The evidence of her dad’s departure was all around, but still, none of this felt real.

Cry, she told herself, *just like you’d write into a movie*. Yes, if this were a scene she were drafting, the heroine would emit deep, guttural sobs, the camera would pan out and the screen would fade to black.

But this wasn't one of her screenplays. There would be no swell of orchestral music, and no comforting hugs from a secondary character, apparently. Because no one else was there—the room was empty, except for her. Was she actually going to be the lone attendee at her dad's service? Was this how Bruce Hart would be remembered?

A floorboard creaked and Carly stood, hopeful that a friend of her father's had arrived, but it was just the funeral director.

"Sorry to interrupt," he said.

Adam. His name was Adam. Now she remembered. He was probably in his thirties, tall and lanky in a fitted blue shirt with a blazer and loose tie. His floppy red hair fell just above the sharp lines of his jaw.

"It's fine," she said, but her voice was much softer than she'd ever heard it. She cleared her throat and tried again. "Fine."

"Can I get you anything?" he asked.

"No, thank you," she managed to respond.

"We'll move outside in about twenty minutes, if that's okay with you." He clasped his hands, and she registered how his brown eyes had flecks of honey in them.

Carly blinked. *Outside*, as in the burial. She gave a quick glance at the coffin, then studied her shoes. "Sure," she said. Though there was no way she'd be able to watch her dad get lowered into the ground. She just couldn't.

Her eyes began to mist. Was this the moment she'd finally cry?

But then Carly's knees buckled just enough for her to sway. In a flash, Adam was next to her with his arm wrapped around her waist. "I've got you." His tone was as firm as his grasp at her side.

He maneuvered her into a chair, and she was suddenly overwhelmed by the nearness of him. Who even was this guy? Why was he here, at her side, instead of anyone else in her life? She didn't want to be in this room, let alone be taken care of by someone who was about to bury her dad. She had a hard time getting the words, "I'm fine," out, but she'd done it.

Instead of taking the hint and leaving, Adam opened a bottle of water that had been strategically tucked under a seat and handed it to her. "Here."

Her hands were shaky, though, and the water dropped and began to spill all over the floor. He deftly picked up the bottle and found a cloth to place over the spill.

Carly should've apologized, offered to get towels, or anything other than what she did next. "Please just leave," her lips trembled over the words.

He stopped cleaning, looked up. "Of course." He stood, and his expression turned firm. "Just don't step in the water. I don't want you to fall ____"

"I don't need you to save me." Her eyes narrowed at him. Carly understood that she was lashing out at Adam because of her grief, and the fact that she forgot to eat that morning probably didn't help either. But she also didn't care. This was her dad's funeral. No one else had shown up. And she didn't want to be comforted by this man she barely knew. She didn't want his hand at her waist, or the water, or him. She wanted to get the hell away from this room.

His firm expression softened, but then a door down the hall opened, followed by footsteps.

"Excuse me." Adam walked away from her all too quickly and approached the hallway. Carly's heart anxiously beat again—finally, maybe this was someone to see her dad?

But no.

"Shireen?" Adam's voice was surprised.

"Can we talk?" The woman attached to the voice appeared—also tall, but curvy, with the most gorgeous dark curls Carly had ever seen. Her expression, though, was concerned.

"I'm working." He tilted his head toward the room where Carly sat. His work was the business of burying her dad.

"It's important," Shireen said quietly.

Adam gave Carly a genuinely apologetic look, then left.

She swallowed down a lump that had lodged in her throat. She knew she'd been unfair to Adam and later she'd regret her words, but she was also relieved by his departure. Carly approached the coffin and placed her palm on the closed lid. In there, Bruce wore the navy-blue suit and tie she'd picked out. Pinned on his jacket lapel was the *Star Wars* enamel pin she'd gotten him for his sixtieth birthday. He'd forever be sixty-four.

Carly studied her fingers instead of imagining him inside the box. She wasn't ready to say goodbye, she realized. She wanted to explain that this was all just too much for her—too intense, and awful. Maybe she could come back tomorrow and visit the grave, when she was ready? But that was when she heard them fighting.

“What do you want me to say, Adam? I fucked up! I slept with him. I’m sorry,” Shireen shouted.

“Keep your voice down!” Adam’s own raw with emotion.

Carly frowned. What was she overhearing?

“I don’t know what else to say!” the woman exclaimed. “I just need to know if you’ll forgive me.”

There was a long stretch of silence. Carly realized that this was a private moment between two people, and she had no business listening in. She should definitely cover her ears or something.

Problem was, Carly was nosy.

“What did you expect me to do? You haven’t paid attention to me in years! We’re basically coworkers.”

“Coworkers don’t have sex, Shireen.”

“And neither do we!”

Carly slapped a hand across her mouth to keep in whatever noise was about to tumble out. Instead of sobs, she choked back incredulous giggles. How was it that on the worst day of her life, she was overhearing some of the best dialogue? Her eyes went wide as she focused on the coffin. “What do you think, Dad? Movie-worthy?”

But she was met with silence, because of course she was. For a moment, she’d been able to pretend like her dad was still there. Like they were having one of their old brainstorming sessions, where she’d rattle off a half-baked idea that he’d punch up. Who was she going to spitball with now?

She uncovered her mouth. “I miss you.”

The words came out easily because they were pure truth. She missed him. And in that moment, she knew where she finally needed to go.

The Last Showing movie theater was located off Main Street in the small, sleepy town of Julian, California. When she’d taken the key from her dress pocket and opened the doors, Carly wasn’t sure what to expect. Her dad had sent photos of the renovations he’d done, but to see the theater in real life was . . . surreal.

The place had been closed for a week, but the red-and-gold-flecked carpet was spotless. The warm white walls held framed posters of upcoming and past film releases. Neon stars dangled from wires on the ceiling. The food counter had been wiped clean, and the glass cases that held rows and

rows of candy were stacked and ready to sell. If she'd wanted, Carly could throw open the doors, turn on the overhead marquee and wait to see if anyone came in. That was probably what Bruce did every day. *Used* to do.

Instead, she went behind the snack counter, tore open a package of Milk Duds and dumped the chewy morsels into an empty popcorn bucket. Then she ripped open a pack of gummy worms and let them fall in. She added Skittles, Swedish Fish, Twizzlers, M&Ms, Reese's Pieces and mini Butterfinger Bites until the bucket was nearly full. Her dad called this a candy salad, their favorite treat.

Bruce also liked to add hot, buttery popcorn on top so everything melted together. He wasn't there to tell her that, though.

He. Wasn't. There.

Carly looked up from her tub of sugar. A "questionable" pot of joy any other day, but the thing felt as heavy as a brick in her hands. Her dad's whole world had been movies. He'd gotten his first job as a PA on the set of a low-budget indie horror film when he was eighteen. But after forty-some-odd years of working his way up to cinematographer, he'd wanted a change of pace. He could've taken a cushy role as an adjunct professor at USC's film school—a job he'd been offered. Instead, he'd done the least sensible thing imaginable: taken his savings, uprooted his Los Angeles life and bought a decrepit movie theater in a small town three hours away.

"I want to build something special—something of my own," he'd excitedly told Carly over a greasy pancake brunch at the Tallyrand diner in Burbank, just a few blocks from his house and her apartment. He'd already begun renovations on the theater. "You'll see, Carly girl!"

But she didn't see, and neither did anyone in Julian. Because as Carly recently discovered, Bruce was in massive piles of debt. He'd taken out more loans than movie tickets sold. An exaggeration, but still . . . his gamble hadn't paid off.

A few weeks ago, her dad had asked that she come visit so they could make his famous candy salad and watch the total solar eclipse together. He'd lived full-time in Julian for a year, and she hadn't taken the three-hour drive down to see him. But Carly had no intention of coming to watch the eclipse—even if it was "rare and cinematic," as her dad said. Because if she traveled to Julian, then she'd know for certain that he was never returning to Los Angeles. So she'd declined the invite, hoping he'd finally understand that his leaving had been the wrong decision.

Of course, neither of them knew that seeing her would be his dying wish.

Carly thought putting together her dad's favorite movie snack would ease her pain. She thought that by coming to the theater she'd get some kind of closure. But as she looked around the empty lobby, she couldn't help but feel complete and utter rage.

If he hadn't moved to this cookie-cutter small town to pursue his half-baked dream, Bruce would still be alive. If he and her mother hadn't had their first date in a movie theater, maybe none of this would've happened in the first place. Why were both of her parents gone from this world when so many other people got to keep theirs for longer?

The bucket shook in Carly's unsteady hands. Being here without him was too excruciating. For the first time since arriving in Julian, she finally understood her dad was really gone. Her throat burned. She couldn't breathe. The hot, bubbling sorrow that had built inside her blow by blow finally tumbled out as a scream. She clenched her jaw, hurled the bucket of candy as hard as she could and it exploded against a framed poster.

Carly let out a loud sob. The flood of tears was so intense that the tightness in her throat couldn't compete with the force of her own pain. Her body swayed from the grief, and she collapsed to the floor. Her dad, that clever, sweet bear of a man, was gone.

After what felt like hours but was probably more like minutes, Carly had no more tears left. So when the front door squeaked open and she spied Hank—the janitor her dad had told her about—she couldn't so much as fake a hello. Hank looked at her, then at the trail of spilled candy.

"I'll clean this up." Her hands instinctively went to the floor.

"Let me," Hank said as he approached. Why hadn't Hank come to her dad's funeral? Was Julian just filled with soulless, rude people?

But then Adam popped into her head. He hadn't been rude. He'd tried to help. So, naturally, she'd gone and chased him off.

"You go outside," Hank added. "Get some fresh air. See the eclipse. Your dad would've wanted that."

The eclipse. Yes, Carly had forgotten about the total eclipse that was happening because, well, her dad. She wordlessly agreed to let Hank do his job, and then numbly moved toward the exit.

Outside the theater doors, the sun was low in the sky and filled Main Street with warm light. A preschooler rode a scooter down the sidewalk as her mother chased along behind. The child's delighted squeals blended with

Carly's own sniffing. A chunk of her life had ceased to exist, but somehow everyone else carried on like that didn't matter. As she glanced down the street, there were a handful of people in eclipse glasses, and kids lying on their backs with their faces toward the sky, delighting in the novelty. The whole scene would be quaint if she weren't in mourning.

The truth that Carly didn't belong in Julian hit her like a punch. She belonged in Burbank, where she'd grown up and had a studio apartment waiting for her. The sooner she could wrap up her dad's affairs, the sooner she could get back home and leave behind the reminders that he was gone.

Home. The thought made Carly slip her phone out of the pocket of her black midi dress. There was a text from Daniel, her closest friend. She didn't have a ton of those.

DANIEL: Call me, okay?

She would call him, eventually.

Then she clicked into her email. Being a screenwriter was a mostly solitary endeavor. So when she saw the new email with the simple subject line of "script," she felt compelled to open it.

FROM: therealmarilyn@wahoo.com
TO: CarlyHartWrites@tmail.com
SUBJECT LINE: Script

Carly, I read your script. I think it has potential. Let's set time to discuss. xx

She read it again. Then again. Carly had recently sent a script to Marilyn Montgomery—one of *the* most successful screenwriters in the business—after her dad had called in a favor. But she never expected a reply; favors were called in all the time in Hollywood, and often nothing came of them. But Marilyn *had* read her script. She said there was *potential*. She . . . wanted to discuss it?

Normally, knowing that an Academy Award-winning screenwriter thought her script could *be* something would elicit the kind of manic excitement that might frighten the nearby children. But in this moment, where Carly could barely stand from grief, all she could do was smile. A genuine smile, because she knew her dad would be so proud.

Her life was about to change. She couldn't call Marilyn, not when she might start crying if another human so much as spoke to her, so she typed a quick response back. Thank you for reading! I will send availabilities shortly! Thank you,

again! She hit Send before she added another superfluous thank-you or exclamation point, and immediately got a failure-to-send notification. Carly frowned, and out of sheer desperation, placed a call to Daniel. Only, the voice that greeted her was an automated recording. *The number you're trying to call is not reachable.*

Before she could overthink it, voices rose around her and the people nearby pointed toward the sky.

Maybe the service was glitching because everyone was outside on their phones and livestreaming the eclipse. She'd try emailing again as soon as it was over. What the hell; she might as well see the eclipse. Her dad had been eager to watch, and if she couldn't be with him physically, maybe this was a different way to honor his memory. Carly took a deep breath, shaded her eyes with her hand and looked up.

This, however, was absolutely a mistake. Her retinas instantly burned. She blinked back the sting and tried to open them again, but her lids felt stuck together. All she saw was black. Had she just blinded herself on top of everything?

There was a flicker of an image—white folding chairs and her dad's coffin—followed by his voice—*Come find me, Carly girl*—so clear and loud her breath caught.

Then, as quickly as it had all come on, her eyes opened. “Dad?” Carly said.

Main Street came back into focus—the kids lying on top of towels, strangers pointing toward the sky. Of course he wasn't there. She must've heard his voice in her fog of grief. *Come find me, Carly girl* echoed like a drum in her head, though. Logically, she knew that her heart wasn't actually breaking, but how else to explain the sharp and sudden pain in her chest? She placed a hand to her forehead, let out a shuddering breath and wished the day would just end already.

Chapter 2

Adam

Adam was a logical person. He worked in facts, not emotions. Which was part of what made him great at his job, really—while clients fell apart with grief, he was the dependable shoulder they could lean on.

Still, if ever there was a time for him to *feel* something, standing in the bedroom he'd shared with Shireen was probably it. Instead, the facts just danced in a steady rotation.

Shireen cheated on me.

My marriage is over.

My best friend slept with my wife.

A grease-stained paper bag rattled in front of Adam's face. The typeface across the front—*Moms Apple Pie*—snapped him out of his haze.

"Let's take a break," his dad, Bill, said, and clapped a heavy hand on his shoulder.

Adam pinched the bridge of his nose as Bill led them out of the bedroom and onto the back porch. The fresh air outside the two-bed, one-bath cabin that he and Shireen had been renting for the past few years was just the same as always. Except, as Adam took in a breath, he didn't feel the usual peace.

No, a deep exhaustion hummed through him. He'd spent most of the afternoon folding clothes, toiletries and a few personal items—his laptop, chargers, journal—into a hard-shell suitcase. He'd expected Shireen to

show up at some point and beg him to stay, but she hadn't. Instead, his dad had come over with apple fritters.

After Adam oversaw the burial of Bruce Hart, whose daughter had inexplicably vanished—what kind of a person leaves in the middle of their own father's funeral?—he'd called his mom. Sheila was one of those practical people who always had a solution, and hers was to have Adam come home while he sorted things out. And he'd easily agreed, because he didn't want to sleep in the house where his wife had decided to have an affair with his best friend.

His dad pulled out a plastic chair and took a seat at the small, round table that overlooked the woods behind the cabin. Adam did the same. Bill pushed the bag across the table and Adam pulled out an apple fritter, coated in a thick layer of flaky sugar that melted into doughy perfection as he took a bite.

The thing was so good, he almost forgot that Shireen had imploded their marriage a few hours earlier. Almost.

Adam swallowed down the dough, which was suddenly a brick in his throat. Shireen had cheated on him. She was sleeping with his best friend. How had he been oblivious to all of it until she was tearfully confessing in his office?

"Your mom is getting your old room ready," Bill said. "You can stay as long as you like, of course."

"Thanks." Adam numbly took another bite of the fritter. He was devastated about Shireen, but also? He was humiliated to be having this conversation with his dad—a man who'd been married for over forty years. Adam imagined both of his parents were embarrassed. His routine life had somehow become a soap opera, and their town was small enough that everyone would know Adam's marriage was over (along with the reason) soon enough.

The reason, according to Shireen, was that Adam had taken her for granted. She'd told him that he was "emotionally unavailable." He'd gotten so wrapped up in making a secure future for them that he'd forgotten to check in on their present. While he'd found the prospect of forever with Shireen a comfort, she'd needed him to focus on the day-to-day.

"Do you want to talk about . . . anything?" Bill asked.

Adam side-eyed him. Their family didn't talk about feelings. His parents loved him—said the words *love you* with regularity. But still, they didn't

have long, deep conversations about the state of their mental health. Their small and mighty unit of three spoke sarcasm fluently. They skimmed past subjects like politics in favor of the weather. The only time he'd ever seen his father cry was the day Adam got married, and those were joyful tears.

So the idea of telling his dad that Shireen had slept with his best friend was, well, not something he was about to do. Before he had to answer, the alarm on his phone pinged.

"Five minutes until the eclipse." Adam's mouth twitched at the words. This wasn't how he'd pictured the day going. The eclipse was something he'd been looking forward to for months. While Adam's job was a funeral director, he'd always been a bit of an amateur astronomer. And this was going to be one of those moments where Adam could let his astronomy flag fly. He'd packed a picnic and gotten Shireen purple eclipse sunglasses—her favorite color. All morning he'd been excited to wrap up work so they could experience this extraordinary thing together—a chance to reconnect.

But now, instead of rattling off eclipse facts to his wife, Adam and Bill would watch the sun get swallowed by the moon and burn a dark black hole in the sky. And maybe that was fitting. The eclipse could torch through the memory of the day and help him forget the whole damn mess that was his life.

Adam leaned sideways to pull out two pairs of eclipse glasses from his jeans, handing the purple frames to his dad.

"Funky," Bill said as he slung them on. "I feel like Elton John."

"I'll call you Rocket Man from here on out," Adam replied. They were back to their easy rhythm of sarcasm, right where Adam wanted them to be.

"So, you're still into that astrology business, huh?" Bill asked.

"Astronomy," Adam corrected him.

"That's what I said," Bill joked. "I didn't realize you were keeping up with this stuff."

Adam's stomach clenched. This astronomy *stuff* had become a point of contention for his family. As a kid, Adam had loved dreaming of what it would be like to discover something new in the sky above him. But the older he'd gotten, the more his passion was dismissed as a childhood whim. His dad had him working summers at the funeral home to learn the family business: Rhodes Funeral Home. The place was started by Adam's grandpa, taken over by Bill and had the expectation that Adam would eventually

inherit the hearse. So, Adam had put aside his telescope and accepted the future he'd been handed in an ornate silver urn.

His dad wanted to retire and travel through Italy with Adam's mom—*the undertaker wants to be under the Tuscan sun*, his dad had joked. Which meant Rhodes Funeral Home would be Adam's sole responsibility.

And Adam was comfortable with that. He'd found the woman he was going to spend the rest of his life with. Having a steady job meant that they could save for a house. With any luck, their marriage would be as happy as his own parents'. Only, Shireen had betrayed him.

"I wouldn't say I've been keeping up with astronomy," Adam lied. He *did* keep tabs on big scientific news through various Substack newsletters. "But total solar eclipses are rare. Special."

Adam could've told Bill that the moon had to line up perfectly between the earth and sun, and even when that did happen, the eclipse wasn't usually visible. But those little fun facts might show his hand.

Instead, he tried to focus on the eclipse as the sun turned into a crescent, then a sliver and eventually vanished under the dark shadow of the moon. His dad had commentary, of course.

"Glad it's just the eclipse and not an apoc-eclipse—get it, like apocalypse?"

Adam forced out a laugh of acknowledgment. And then the silence stretched, the bitter reality of his life wrapping around him like an unwelcome blanket. Where the only comfort his dad could offer was his presence, and the only thing Adam could do was try not to break down in front of him.

When the eclipse ended, Bill quickly said, "Should we head out?"

"I'll just take another minute," Adam replied. So Bill stood up, gave Adam a pat on the back and walked into the house.

Adam needed to process whether this was all some kind of bad dream, or a very sick joke. Because how in the fucking world was he living through *this*? His wife. With his best friend. Their marriage . . . He'd avoided the word *divorce* at all costs, but where else could this be going?

Divorce. A word Adam's parents had never had to use for their own marriage, but now he—at thirty-two—would be using frequently.

Out of habit, Adam looked up toward the sky that was endless with potential—that was how he'd naively imagined his marriage would be. He

quickly wiggled his wedding ring off his finger and launched it into the woods.

He rubbed the spot where it had been, already regretting the choice. He loved Shireen. Even after what she'd told him, Adam still loved her. And then he realized that while Shireen had, for some time, slowly removed herself from their life—planting seeds wholly separate from his—there was something he could do to make himself feel better, too. He could bury this whole experience. Adam didn't want to process what had happened, and maybe he didn't have to.

The sun burned as bright as he'd ever seen and, as he watched from behind the safety of his eclipse glasses, Adam felt the sharp flicker of hope in his chest. Maybe he could come through this stronger. While he was suffering unspeakable pain now, perhaps in the near future he'd truly forgive and forget, like people always said happened.

Then that flicker turned warm, a heat that radiated across his shoulders and down his arms. His vision blurred. Was he crying? No, but something was making it impossible for him to so much as open his eyes. Maybe staring at the sun, even safely, hadn't been wise.

Then his eyes suddenly snapped open. No more blurry vision. Instead of the warmth he'd felt, Adam was downright sweating. And instead of being surrounded by the woods, he was standing in the office at the funeral home.

The overhead lighting illuminated Shireen, right in front of him and wearing the same clothes from earlier that day. Had he fallen asleep, somehow? He took a step back from the moment he never wanted to relive again, but his leg hit the side of the desk. Sharp pain raced across his skin and he gripped the spot. He looked to Shireen, and the anguish on her face was just as he'd remembered. He instinctively reached out to comfort her.

There, on his ring finger, was the wedding band he'd tossed into the woods.

Chapter 3

Carly

Day 238

Carly shivered as a blast of intense air-conditioning came through the vent above her head. Goose bumps trailed her arms and she rubbed her hands up and down her skin to warm herself. “Hey, Dad,” she said and fell back into the seat with a thud.

By her count, this was the two hundred thirty-eighth time she’d attended her dad’s funeral. Not in a metaphorical, dream, or fantastical sense—in a very real, butt-in-a-hard-white-chair-facing-her-father’s-coffin kind of way. Being stuck in a time loop had not been on her bingo card, and if she’d known such a thing was even possible, she’d have opted for a more comfortable bra.

But as it stood, Carly couldn’t change anything about how she started the loop. It was always 10 a.m. on April twenty-third. Her dad was permanently in the casket. She was forever in a black dress with combat boots, a box of tissues in her lap and her hair parted in the middle.

Even after 238 times, seeing her dad here was never easy. A constant reminder that she’d never be able to take back the last thing she’d said to him. Just the memory of those words made her shoulders hunch.

In order to avoid becoming a human snowman of negativity, she found the best approach was to avoid thinking about her problems altogether.

Carly approached the closed casket and drummed her bitten fingernails across its sleek top. “Morning,” she said. “Want to hear a story?”

Carly understood her father was dead, but she still spoke to him. If for no other reason than to try to be a good daughter. Something she hadn’t been able to do when he was alive.

“I met this guy.” She leaned an elbow on the lid and crossed one combat boot over the other. “Early thirties, like me. He’d driven to Julian on a whim and got stuck in the loop. He was apparently about to graduate from med school. Anyways, I helped him open a bottle of wine. He couldn’t find a corkscrew, and I remembered that elbow trick you taught me.”

She waited for an acknowledgment of her good deed, but of course none came. So she pursed her lips and patted herself on the back. Carly had accepted that this loop was her life—maybe it was even karmic retribution for being a terrible daughter. So as a way to repent, she’d decided to do one nice thing for someone else every time she looped. It helped pass the hours, and doing something considerate distracted her, albeit momentarily, from the fact that she was undeniably the worst.

A nearby door banged open. “That’ll be the love birds,” she joked to her dad.

The other super-fun, not-at-all-alarming thing about the loop was that everyone in Julian was stuck—not just Carly. Their days all restarted at 10 a.m. on April twenty-third, just as hers did. And like Carly, they’d had to relive the same day over and over. Adam and Shireen, however, hadn’t been coping well.

The slap of flip-flops down the hall made Carly turn just in time to spot the wife—or *ex-wife*—Shireen. Carly didn’t personally know Shireen, but she knew *of* her. In the sense that she’d overheard her conversations with Adam 238 times, and therefore understood the bulk of their relationship history: met in high school, together soon after, both happy until Adam took over the family business and Shireen started to feel neglected, Adam didn’t notice her new haircut, there were no more big or small romantic gestures, Shireen ran into Adam’s best friend, Dean, during a particularly low point and next thing you know . . .

Carly usually waited for them to leave before making her own exit. Not only because the situation was awkward—funeral and breakup colliding—but because Adam was . . . how to say this politely . . .

Ah, yes, a vindictive prick.

It wasn't that Carly thought Adam should necessarily take Shireen back, but she'd watched him go from heartbroken to heart of stone in a matter of loops. Maybe she'd been right in telling him to leave her alone the day of her dad's first funeral because, as it turned out, Adam wasn't a particularly nice guy. While his ex had tried to find some kind of reconciliation—first with their marriage, and then a possible friendship—Adam shut her down repeatedly. And 238 times later, he still didn't seem to have shifted whatsoever on his point of view that Shireen was someone he couldn't so much as exchange a pleasantry with.

Not to mention the handful of opportunities where Carly had seen him in the loop, the man either ignored her or went out of his way to pretend she wasn't there. It was as if the polite, water bottle pushing guy she'd initially met had been replaced with a grumpy one. He never gave a friendly smile or waved hello. He just acted like she didn't exist.

So she very much understood why Shireen might be unhappy in their marriage. Carly would be, too, if she were married to Adam Rhodes, Director of Rhodes Funeral Home and purveyor of effortless frowns.

Once they were both gone, Carly would leave, too. She was a guest in the funeral home, after all, and she figured it was best to let them have their moment. It was also the only guaranteed way to avoid them.

"Shireen," Adam called out. Carly couldn't quite imagine the person who'd once pretended to inspect the leaves of a fiddleleaf fig to avoid talking to her would ever want human connection. Either way, his plea caused the flip-flops to stop before they made an exit.

Carly held her breath, like a kid overhearing a fight between their parents. She didn't want to be caught, because she was desperate to hear the details of something she just barely understood. This is what also made Carly a terrible human: her love of gossip.

"Yes?" Shireen asked, maybe a tinge of hope lacing through her words.

Which is why Carly knew with unfortunate clarity that Adam would take the opportunity to knock her down.

"Say hi to Dean for me!" Adam said.

Carly could almost feel a fake smile plastered across his face.

To her delight, Shireen simply said, "Fuck off, Adam."

"Yeah, good for you," Carly said. Out loud. *Whoops.*

She held her breath. Maybe they didn't hear?

There was a pause—too long of a pause—and then Shireen said, “I knew I liked that girl.”

Carly’s eyes went wide. Was *she* that girl? She slumped down into the plastic seat and wondered if she had the ability to melt into the floor. They were in a time loop, after all; stranger things had happened.

There were footsteps, a door opening and closing and finally, the silence that told Carly she was alone. She let out a very relieved breath. “See you tomorrow,” she told her dad.

As with every loop, leaving this room was Carly’s main goal. As long as she could spend the next thirteen hours and change doing everything *not* to think of Bruce, she might be able to forget how she’d treated him at the end.

Carly came to the hallway, a nondescript, low-lit area straight from the pages of Anywhere Bland USA Magazine. As Carly headed toward the exit, she paused. Was there an acorn painted on the wall? Had that always been there? She approached and, sure enough, there it was. She traced the outline of the acorn with her finger. *Who the hell would paint an optical illusion acorn onto a funeral home hallway?*

“Can I help you?” a sharp voice asked.

Carly pulled her finger away, as if his words had burned her. Adam stood at the opposite end of the narrow hall, with his fiery mop of hair and strong jawline. She’d often wondered if she could hang off the tops of those cheekbones and swing, as if from a monkey bar. But judging by the daggers Adam shot from his dark brown eyes, this was neither the time nor the place to get distracted by bone structure.

She swallowed. “No, sorry, I . . .” What had she been doing? “There are acorns in the walls.”

“Acorns in the walls?” He somehow made every word a question.

“*On* the walls, like painted on them? Haven’t you noticed?” She was suddenly very warm, an ant under a magnifying glass.

Adam’s eyes flicked to the wall, then back to her.

“Never mind.” She tugged on the hem of her dress. His eyes followed her hands, and then he cleared his throat. That pointed sound almost seemed to ask what the hell she was still doing there. She should just go, really. So she turned toward the door to do exactly that.

Only, much like the optical illusion acorns, there seemed to be something hiding *in* his hooded eyes. Carly had a lot of big feelings. She sort of gravitated toward them, actually. If she saw someone else crying, she cried.

If she heard laughter, she was more prone to it, too. She was a feelings sponge, and at that moment her pores were soaking up some serious vibes that Adam was searching for a friend. Maybe Adam was so rude all the time because he needed to talk. After all, he'd attempted kindness with her once before, so didn't she owe him? Helping Adam could be her good deed for the day! A way to make amends!

Without being able to stop herself, she turned back and locked eyes with him. She faltered only for a moment because, well, staring at him was like looking at the sun—an otherworldly thing with that flaming red hair. But she managed to ask, “Are you okay?”

Adam glared at her, as if she'd just suggested riding a bicycle over his pretty leather loafers. Maybe she should first apologize.

“Sorry that I chimed in earlier . . .” she started. “With Shireen.”

Adam crossed his arms and his lean biceps strained against the blazer. He didn't say a fucking word, but he almost didn't have to. Carly intuited that he was pissed off from his tight posture and those pointy cheekbones threatening to cut her if she took a step closer.

“Well, it's sort of hard *not* to listen, you know?” She talked a lot when she was nervous, and in general. “And you were both in the hall. The walls aren't exactly soundproof.”

“Just filled with acorns,” he said.

She couldn't tell if he was joking, but then he clarified things.

“I know we're stuck here together, but next time, stay out of our business, please,” Adam added.

“No problem,” Carly quickly said. She'd reached her threshold of Adam for the day, anyway.

Even Adam's nod of acknowledgment was somehow condescending. But before she could say as much, he slammed the office door shut and robbed her of the honor.

“Asshole,” she muttered to herself.

Carly's boots crunched along the gravel driveway as she headed to the road that would lead her to town. There were so many things Carly wished she could change about the loop. One, that past her had thought to wear sneakers instead of heavy boots with thick socks. Two, that she'd driven herself to the funeral instead of relying on a car service, which now meant she was stranded every day. And three, Carly wished she'd eaten anything

the morning of the funeral so that she didn't always restart hungry and thirsty.

As it was, Carly had no choice but to walk the mile into town the same way she always did to find sustenance. Main Street and the small stretch of stores connected by cutesy brick facades came into view a half hour later. Carly stepped onto the sidewalk, then nodded at a twenty-something cruising past on a skateboard. She barely registered the Spider-Man costume, but when he ripped the character mask off, held up a pillowcase overflowing with money, and shouted, "I just robbed the bank!" that gave her some pause.

Carly had helped this guy change his bike tire once upon a loop. He'd mentioned that he'd been a librarian. Now he was a librarian-turned-bank robber. That was the thing about a time loop—it changed who you were. Carly, for example, used to write every day. She'd been an aspiring screenwriter, but hadn't written a single word since the loop began. She wondered how many more loops until *she* tried to rob a bank.

Before she could think too much of it, the clopping of hooves signaled the approach of Lollipop, a very majestic and enormous Clydesdale. Lollipop's blond mane was braided, care of her owner, Goldie, who rode bareback. If Carly felt a breeze in her dress, then Goldie must've been freezing in her polka-dot bikini. The only warm thing on her was her long gray hair, which cascaded across her shoulders and gave her the aura of an aging Lady Godiva.

"Thirteen-hour warning," Goldie called out. "Get your kicks in while you can, people!" Then softer, and into Lollipop's ear, "Not you, girl." She patted Lollipop's long neck.

Carly wasn't the only person who kept track of the passing time. Goldie's hourly warnings had become a staple in the town, especially since no one's phones worked anymore. And while they were only an hour into the loop, people had already started to indulge their colorful whims: Spider-Man in his costume and Goldie in her bikini.

The sun was bright and unobscured as Carly shielded her eyes with the palm of her hand. In the middle of the road were mattresses stacked up like pancakes, and one by one, people climbed to the top of a ladder and took turns jumping onto a waiting mattress. A drum circle played a vaguely familiar song and passed around a bong that had to be at least three feet tall. Which fed into a crowd of many bodies writhing to the music. It was

honestly hard to see through them, which is why Carly nearly missed the golf cart outfitted with holiday lights that zipped so close she had to take a step back.

Every time the loop restarted, the town—and everyone in it—went back to the exact way it was at 10 a.m. on April twenty-third. The mattresses piled in the street would vanish, the golf cart and its holiday lights would be gone and Goldie would restart in what Carly had to assume wasn't a bikini. But because it all reset, there were no real consequences. With no consequences, the town had become . . . chaotic.

While most people had found groups that helped make sense of each day, Carly hadn't. She'd been stuck like everyone else, but she still had no one to really cling to. While she had surface-level conversations with plenty of people, care of her one good deed a day vow, she wasn't from Julian. She didn't have the privilege of childhood friends to reconnect with. When she'd come to her dad's funeral, he'd been the only person she'd known. She was an accidental loner in this place, like her dad had been.

Another thirteen hours to go before they reset. Carly's hands met her hips, and she took in the street, waiting for some kind of sign. Her gaze landed on the literal sign for Moms Pie House. The diner had a faux log cabin exterior and practically glistened like an oasis in the desert of Carly's thoughts.

Apple pie. That was the town's shtick. Rows and rows of apple orchards brought in tourists who came for the apple picking season and the homemade apple pies and apple donuts and cider. Carly could eat apple pie. Again. For the two hundred thirty-eighth time.

The screen door wheezed behind Carly as she walked in. Empty pie tins and discarded tubs of ice cream already littered the floor. Each booth was occupied and the social chatter was only topped by frenetic opera music that blared from the speakers. As the singer reached an ear-splitting crescendo, an elderly man pushed himself up from a booth with the help of his walker. He grabbed a canister from the center of the table, pressed down on the top and sent a spray shooting across the room. "Whipped cream fight!" he excitedly hollered.

A kid who couldn't have been more than twelve grabbed a different can and fired a shot back at the old man.

Carly ducked down to avoid a direct hit. As she did, she spied a litter of puppies in the corner of the restaurant, maybe six of them, excitedly

yipping around a small girl. A woman, whom Carly assumed was the girl's mom, lovingly watched the puppy pile.

"She said she wanted to cuddle all the puppies," the mom said with a shrug, perhaps feeling Carly's gaze. "So we are."

Carly gave her a faint smile. She was hungry, sure, but who was she to just walk past a moving blanket of fur and wagging tails?

"May I?" Carly asked.

The mom waved a hand, as if in blessing. Carly approached the pile and scooped up a little white-and-brown-spotted thing with furry ears. The pup squeaked as Carly held it to her chest. She buried her nose and breathed in the smell of wood chips and kibble. Maybe her bad start to the day with Adam was a blip. Sure, she was still stuck, but she had a warm puppy and a warmer slice of pie on the way. The future was bright—as bright as it could be for the next thirteen hours, anyway.

Then, just as quickly, she smelled urine and felt a wet mark bloom across her front.

Well.

Carly gently dabbed at the wet spot with a clump of napkins, which the puppy then tried to eat. She stroked its soft fur as she made her way to the counter. No one officially worked at Moms Pie House anymore, except for Mom, who never abandoned her pie ship. What was the point in going to work if everything you did erased a few hours later?

But Moms was one of the few places where you could still get service, as if they all weren't stuck here indefinitely. Mom looked up and spotted Carly, then brushed her weathered hands across the front of her apron. "What can I get you?" She smiled like she was genuinely happy to see her. So many people in town had lost that spark, but not Mom.

"I'll take your very best slice of pie." She hiked the puppy higher and onto her shoulder. "And I think this little guy could use an apple."

"You like your pie with cheese, right?"

"Oh yes," Carly said. In fact, she judged people who didn't cover their pie with cheddar cheese.

"You got it." Mom gave the puppy a scratch behind its ears.

The booths were all taken, but there was a table with a few open seats. "Mind if we join?" Carly asked, sitting down before the mayor could answer. She put the puppy on the seat next to her.

“Fluffy fluff face!” Mayor Franco cooed to the dog as an answer. She wasn’t Carly’s friend, exactly, but the mayor was everyone’s friend in the sense that she was a people-pleasing politician. She wore a kilt, a Shania Twain concert shirt and topped off the outfit with a raspberry beret. A far cry from the campaign posters Carly had spied around town where she was tucked into a pantsuit with a blowout and a smile.

Mom came over with a large portion of pie that went all the way to the edges of its clean white plate. Cheddar cheese melted in a happy layer on top and a big silver fork stuck out from the center. She set the plate in front of Carly and a slice of green apple on the seat next to the puppy.

“Who are you targeting for a good deed today?” The mayor dipped the tip of her index finger into Carly’s melting cheese and took a lick. “Have you met Rick Gaines? He’s part of the group trying to stop the loop. He seems like a guy in need of a friend, or something fluffy.” She winked at the puppy.

Carly broke off a corner of the pie with her fork and brought the enormous bite to her mouth. The cinnamon sugar, baked apples and buttery crust melted as she chewed.

“Saving the dog from the toddler is my good deed,” she said. She looked down at her lap, where the puppy had curled up. She scratched a spot behind its ear. Apple. She would call the little guy Apple.

The door squealed open and Shireen came into the restaurant, hand in hand with the infamous Dean. The fact that their names rhymed was completely absurd. Also absurd was Dean’s styled mullet. She watched as Dean pulled Shireen into him, placed a kiss on her head and held her there.

They looked like they were in love, and Carly felt a twinge of empathy for Adam. This was his ex and his best friend. Despite the fact that Adam was an asshat, this situation had to suck.

Carly shoved another bite of pie into her mouth and chewed. No, she wasn’t going to spend her day feeling sorry for Adam. She was going to try to forget that she’d even seen Shireen outside the funeral home walls, or that she’d talked to Adam in the first place. Her day in Julian would be as feeling-free as she could possibly muster. So long as she could convince herself that Adam didn’t deserve her feelings.

Chapter 4

Adam

Adam sat at the desk in his childhood bedroom and stared at a blank piece of paper. He liked to start his afternoons with a to-do list. The list gave him a sense of routine, and his tasks ranged from the mundane—like make himself lunch—to the extremely unique. More specifically, Adam wanted to solve a scientific phenomenon that only occurred during a total solar eclipse. Because if anyone was going to crack the mystery surrounding the eclipse, it would be the guy who got to watch it every day.

But at that moment, he couldn't focus on the to-do list because something about the morning irked him. Not only had he been passive-aggressive with Shireen, but there was the interaction with Carly as well.

He didn't know her. They'd be strangers, if not for the fact that he'd orchestrated her dad's funeral. But she'd called him an asshole under her breath. And, well, it hurt his feelings. He wasn't oblivious to the fact that he could be blunt and that could rub people the wrong way, but an asshole?

Was he? He knew he could've been kinder to Shireen. Okay, fine, he'd been a bit of a dick to Shireen. But the truth was he'd been on edge because Shireen was now officially dating Dean, an unfortunate fact that his mom discovered when she'd gone into town to grab a bottle of wine. Apparently, she'd seen them holding hands and felt obligated to tell Adam because, he suspected, she wanted him to move on, too.

Which was why his cool, let's-never-talk-about-the-past demeanor had cracked. He'd sounded pathetic, really. Adam didn't blame Shireen for her

dismissive reaction. But he couldn't help himself. Here he was, banging his head against the wall to uncover scientific mysteries, and Shireen was dating Dean?

Adam glanced at the blank piece of paper. *Write something*, he commanded himself. But as he held the pen in his hand and waited for letters to appear, none came. He sat back in his chair with a huff. Okay, fine, he was having a block. An extremely unusual occurrence, but nothing he couldn't fix with some strong coffee. As he pushed himself up and headed for the door, the concert poster for the Yeah Yeah Yeahs caught his eye. He'd always had a bit of a *thing* for the lead singer, Karen O. And Carly, he only now realized, had the same dark hair. God, what an unfortunate connection to make—his high school celebrity crush and the woman who spent her time analyzing wallpaper. He shuddered as the thought slipped through him.

"Mom?" he called out as he walked into the hall. His parents didn't often just hang around the house, and it was likely they'd already left for a hike, or to feed the squirrels.

"Offspring?" his mom's singsong voice called out. As he came into the kitchen, Adam spied her at the breakfast nook with his dad, who was painting green-and-white squares onto a board. While Adam had a passion for astronomy, Bill's hobbies were more artistic.

"I sanded the board this morning, and your father is making it chess-worthy." Sheila sipped from the mug of green tea in her hands. "We should be able to play a game this evening, if you'd like a little friendly competition?"

"It's no competition," Bill said. "You always win."

Sheila gave his arm a there-there pat. "Can't help that I'm smart. The same way you can't help that you're handsome."

Bill gave her a quick wink of acknowledgment, then went back to painting. Adam took in a deep breath. His parents could be *a lot*.

Adam turned away from them and toward the coffeemaker.

"Oh, let me make a fresh pot." Sheila pushed herself up from the table.

Maybe it was the fact that he was in his childhood home, or that his mom wore the *Math is Radical* sweatshirt from her high school teaching days, but Adam suddenly felt like he was sixteen again.

"Thanks, Mom." He moved aside and watched as she grabbed a filter and scooped in grounds.

Sheila tucked a strand of hair back up into her loose bun, a style she'd worn since Adam could remember. The only change had been her blond hair going gray, now that she was in her sixties. She put the kettle on to boil as she asked, "Any plans today?"

"Just . . . working." He shrugged.

Sheila shot a glance to Bill, and his dad's jaw tightened.

"You're not going to say anything, Bill?" Sheila asked.

"What . . ." Adam started, but his dad cut him off.

"We'd really like you to try and get out of the house today, honey," Bill said.

Adam frowned. What was happening now? "I'm sorry?"

Sheila looked up with a crease between her brows. "We're worried about you. You're spending so much time by yourself. And you haven't really accepted . . ."

That we're all stuck here, Adam filled in the rest of his mom's sentence in his head. He leaned a palm into the countertop as he soaked in the fact that his parents had staged a kind of intervention.

Sheila wrapped her arms around Adam and pulled him to her shoulder. She gently stroked his hair, and his eyes instinctively closed. "I don't know if you're depressed, or just lonely, but Dad found a therapist who's willing to work with you . . ."

Depressed? He knew he was sad, angry, hurt but . . . depressed?

"I'm not depressed." He pulled away from his mom and met her gaze. Depressed people didn't make to-do lists. Depressed people weren't trying to solve complex physics equations. Depressed people sat in bed, in the dark, unable to move. And yet, here was Adam, standing in a brightly lit kitchen squarely *not* depressed. "I promise," he tried again.

"How about we just try to get out of our routines today?" his mom asked. She'd sound patronizing if she weren't so very clearly pleading with him. And, to be fair, Adam realized that he couldn't really remember the last loop when he'd done that.

"I'll try." He swallowed and deeply wished he had that coffee to burn the shame rising in his throat.

"We can all go do something fun," Bill offered. "The Stardust Bowling Alley is still open. Your mother will beat us both at chess, but we all know I'm the kingpin."

"Kingpin of gutter balls," Sheila quipped back.

Adam surprised himself by chuckling. He couldn't bowl, though; he had work to do. Not that he would tell them that. "I'll find something on my own."

Sheila planted a kiss on his head. "Love you."

"Love you, too," Adam said.

"What about me? Doesn't anyone love me?" Bill put on an expression of hurt.

"Sometimes," Sheila said as she grabbed Bill's hand. His parents were always touching if they were in a room together. Adam had observed their love growing up and assumed his and Shireen's would be the same. But they hadn't been the same, had they? As Shireen liked to remind Adam, they stopped being connected that way a long time ago.

Adam forced himself to smile as he poured a cup of coffee. "Thanks." He raised the mug to his mom, and she nodded.

He walked out of the kitchen, back down the hall to his room and then he was alone. The smile faded, but the sick feeling in his stomach grew more intense. He got on his bed and wrapped his arms around his middle to stop the dull ache . . . Depressed. *Depressed*. Did Shireen think that, too?

While his ex had clearly moved on, he spent every loop at his parents' place with his to-do list. He didn't always *stay* in the house. He went for drives. He occasionally visited the observatory. But maybe they were right about the fact that he was in a bit of a rut.

Adam could have fun. He could pretend like he hadn't started his day looking into the eyes of a person who'd betrayed him. Adam would prove how *not* depressed he was. He pushed himself up and swung open the bedroom door. He walked down the hall and managed to avoid his parents, who were putting on their walking boots. He went out the sliding doors that led to a long stretch of back patio that overlooked the dense forest. His childhood home was tucked into the woods, a farm-style, single-story ranch house with a sleet-gray exterior and massive outdoor deck to watch the sunsets.

Which was convenient, seeing as sunsets were all they had now. The night ended at 11:59 p.m., and the loop restarted at 10 a.m. A whole ten hours of each day just missing. If they ever got out of this, he'd stay up all night just to see a sunrise again.

The place that held some of the happiest memories for Adam was the childhood tree house that was tucked into the woods. Would a depressed

person actively seek out wholesome nostalgia? He thought not!

Adam hadn't stepped foot in this space in . . . maybe a decade. But when he did, he saw a ceiling covered in glow-in-the-dark stars, a torn poster of the constellations, solar-powered string lights, a telescope in a metal carrying case he'd gotten for his ninth birthday, binoculars and hand-held star charts. Neil DeGrasse Tyson's *Death by Black Hole* was worn and dog-eared on the round rug. Judging by the look of things, critters were frequent guests—so there was some maintenance to take care of.

Adam took a striped towel, stiff from being left in the sun, and wiped down the makeshift desk. He coughed at the eruption of dust and brushed a spider off his arm. Glamorous the tree house was not, but he was grateful his parents had the sense to put a roof on, if for no other reason than his notebooks, pens and telescope had all managed to stay protected from the elements.

He rolled up his sleeves to the elbow and grunted with the exertion of cleaning the dirt from the surfaces around him. By the time he was done, his face was slick with sweat, pieces of hair stuck to his forehead and his shirt clung to him. He wiped the back of his hand across his mouth and tasted salt.

He was sore from the hour of rage cleaning, but the space was as he remembered. So the hard work had paid off. He cringed as he thought of that word: *work*. His parents had asked him to get out of his routine, but did cleaning really count?

He was a thirty-two-year-old man and his idea of fun was spending the day tidying up his childhood tree house. Maybe he was depressed. Maybe they were right to be concerned. But also, maybe he didn't know what to do about those things.

Adam had a people-pleaser problem that he was keenly aware of. He'd lived his life the way his parents wanted him to. That was why he'd trusted his dad's advice to stay in the family business—it was a sure thing, guaranteed to give him stability. There'd been some discussion of pursuing astronomy—Caltech and the Jet Propulsion Lab were both a few hours' drive away; he wouldn't have to leave the state to pursue his degree and eventual job.

But what kind of job would he be able to get after college? his parents had asked. While stargazing was a nice hobby, it wasn't a career. When Adam realized his work was in the ground instead of the sky, everything

had clicked into place. Bill added Adam's name to the masthead, got him business cards and made Adam the face of the place.

And Adam had been fine with that—until his marriage imploded. Now he had the occasional rogue thought of *What will I do when the loop ends?* For now, he had to focus on getting through the loop and *then* he'd figure out life on the outside.

The thing that got him through were his daily observations about the loop. The total solar eclipse happened every day at 5:07 p.m. Sunset at 7:29 p.m. The stars were visible by 8:20 p.m. If he could focus on those reliable things, the thoughts of Shireen would blur into the background, even if just for a few fleeting moments.

So even though he'd promised to get out of his routine, he couldn't help himself. When the time came, Adam opened the telescope case, assembled the parts, wiped the lens and settled himself behind it. He took out his notebook and pen, opened to a clean page and waited. His notes would vanish when the eclipse reset but writing them down helped him commit the thoughts to memory—which was all he really had. Then he saw the rippling shadows on the ground and wrote *Shadow bands appear, normal size and frequency*.

Shadow bands were a phenomenon that only occurred during total solar eclipses. There were theories, but no one really knew what caused them to form on the ground right before and after an eclipse. Adam spent a good chunk of each loop trying to solve where they came from. Most scientists only got to witness them a handful of times, after all, but he got to see them every day.

Adam put on his eclipse glasses as the sun became a black hole rimmed with hot fire—the dilated pupil watching the world. He started to time the eclipse on his watch and waited.

As always, the world went quiet—birds and creatures convinced that night had fallen—and the usual calm of being focused washed over him. Studying the eclipse was within his control. Making observations gave him a sense of purpose. He may not know exactly how to pull himself out of this bad place, but he did know what was above him. He waited. Almost four minutes had passed, which signaled it was nearly time to hit Stop. At the moment when the sun came back to full view, he glanced at his watch. Four minutes and thirty-two seconds, like usual.

Adam exhaled. It would be another two hours until night covered the world in a dark blanket. He had more time to kill. And Adam figured a shower would be nice. He started back to the house, and through the floor-to-ceiling windows he could make out his mom pouring two glasses of red wine. Bill was at the stove, stirring something in a pot. Sheila laughed, sipped her wine, then held out a glass for him to take a sip, but he kissed her instead. Adam glanced away, realizing he was intruding on a private moment. Adam's parents had let him stay at their house each and every loop without question. But today they were worried about him.

Instead of going through the back doors, he walked around the house to the driveway. His car was parked there, keys in the cupholder. He'd leave the house. He'd get out. And he'd do this for Bill and Sheila. Adam started the car, pulled out of the driveway and headed into town.

Adam drove down the dirt road, past apple orchards, fences that corralled horses and sheep and cows, and eventually made it to the asphalt, which signaled he was closing in. Even though their town was a smaller one, Main Street never failed to be crowded. As he pulled up to the top of the intersection, he was unable to continue because enormous sectional sofas had been lined up in the crosswalk. Children bounced across them like trampolines. There were cars parked outside the couch blockade—a makeshift parking lot—so Adam pulled into an open spot and killed the engine.

As a general rule, Adam avoided going into town. He'd once witnessed his former pediatrician doing a shirtless keg stand, and decided he didn't want his entire childhood destroyed. But if ever there was a place to fade into the background, it was here. When he got out of the car a thunderous boom sounded, and he ducked down. The sky lit up in streaks of red and gold as a firework exploded over his head. He glanced around to see if anyone else had the same reaction, but the couch kids only pointed with glee.

Goldie and her Clydesdale clip-clopped past as she spoke into a megaphone. "Six-hour warning!"

Six hours on Main Street was a lot. He didn't have to stay the whole time. He could go for a stroll and—his thoughts stalled as a sled crossed the road in front of him.

“Mush!” a petite woman shouted as she slapped the reins against at least six grown men running at top speed to carry her across the asphalt.

Yes, he would be going home now.

Adam turned to open the car door, but then a puppy ran between his legs, yipping and nipping at his ankle. The thing latched on to his pantleg and shook the fabric violently with its teeth, like the pants had offended him.

“Excuse me,” Adam said as he tried to unlatch the dog. “You’re far too tiny to be this strong.” The dog was on the verge of making Adam topple over.

“Apple!” The voice was familiar, and when Adam looked up there was a woman with jet-black hair, massive glasses and a black dress walking toward them—the emo grim reaper. “Oh,” Carly said, and wiped a tear from her eye.

Had she been crying? A flush crept through her cheeks. Maybe she was just embarrassed? He wasn’t sure. But he bent down and picked up the puppy and held it out to her. “Is this . . . an apple?”

She took the puppy. “This is a dog,” she said with absolutely no humor in her voice. “I named him Apple.”

They stared at each other. He was honestly quite impressed that no matter what, they seemed to always be miscommunicating. Any comment he made was instantly considered offensive. That much had been apparent from the first day of the loop, when he’d seemingly provoked her by offering help. Some people just couldn’t get along, or even make small talk, apparently. Carly and Adam were those people.

“I was making a joke,” he clarified.

“But jokes should be funny.” She gave him a look, as if to say she pitied him.

But Adam had enough of being pitied for the day—first Carly, then his parents and now Carly *again*.

“Have you been crying?” he asked. Why the hell did he even care? Whether or not she’d been crying wasn’t any of his business.

“I cry easily,” she said by way of answer. “Apple got upset about the fireworks and was shaking. I held him to my chest and just—” Her voice cut off and she wiped at her eye again.

Despite his line of work, Adam wasn’t all that comfortable with raw emotion, so he filled the silence. “Should you be out here on your own? It’s

not safe this late in the day.” What was he, the curfew police? He sounded like a disgruntled old man shaking his fist from the safety of his porch.

“Didn’t you tell me to stay out of your business just a few hours ago?” Carly bitterly laughed, her pity turning into disbelief, which hadn’t been his intention. But what *had* he thought he’d accomplish with a line like that? That she would just agree and go back to wherever she called home? That she’d thank him for the reminder?

No, she did none of those things; instead, she put the puppy back on the ground and said, “Get him!” with way too much glee. The puppy obediently returned to Adam’s pantleg and began to maul it with all the ferocity a four-pound creature could muster. Carly crossed her arms and watched the dog with a grin. “Consider those little nips retribution for being rude to me and Shireen today.”

Adam felt momentarily dumbfounded by her comment. Was she really suggesting he deserved to be attacked by a dog because he’d been *rude*? This day had taken another unexpected turn he wasn’t at all happy with.

He was, however, happy to end his night on this note, as it was a reminder that he should be home instead of trying to socialize. What good did that ever do? He reached down, picked up the puppy and placed it in the belly of a rogue shopping cart. Carly rushed over to grab her dog and cuddled it close to her chest. She’d look nurturing, if she didn’t then lock eyes with Adam and sneer. Adam straightened, got in the car, slammed the door shut and turned the engine over.

A gentle knock on the window caused him to look up and see Carly’s face so close to the glass that he noticed a birthmark just underneath her left eyebrow. A round black dot, like the darkest planet in the solar system of her face.

He rolled down the window enough to let her speak.

“Someone blocked you in.” The puppy, now nestled in the crook of her arm, let out a belly growl. Carly pointed and the rearview mirror revealed an enormous red minivan that prevented Adam from leaving.

When he turned back, she let out a bright huff of air, then added cheerfully, “Have a great night!”

He didn’t even have time to fully process what she’d said until she was walking out of sight. He thumped back into the driver’s seat. If he never had to see Carly again, it would be the best-case scenario for everyone involved.

Chapter 5

Carly

Day 239

Carly sat in the white folding chair facing her father's coffin. She was back at the funeral home. 239 days of this.

She approached the closed casket and drummed her fingers across the sleek top of it. "Good morning," she said. "Quick story is that I rescued a puppy. Named it Apple. You'd like him."

The office door swung open and thwacked the wall, which meant Shireen was on the move. Usually, Carly spent a little more time with her dad, but if she waited too long, she might accidentally see Adam again. Now was her chance. "See you next loop." She gave two taps to the top of the coffin, then shot down the aisle.

Carly came to the hallway and followed Shireen closely. As Shireen swung open the front door to the funeral home, Carly snuck through and walked out onto the gravel driveway. Her clunky Doc Marten boots scattered the rocks as she headed toward the road. She'd done it. She managed to avoid Adam.

"What are you doing?"

Or had she? She instinctively looked back to where Adam stood, glaring like an angry gargoyle from the door. Maybe he was still mad about last night. Admittedly, Carly had felt a twinge of shame for gloating over his misfortune.

Now, though? She was focused on getting to town so she could go about her day. Being the mature adult she was, Carly did the only thing she could think of to get him to leave her alone forever. She stuck out her tongue. The look on his face—shock and horror—made her day.

“Hey!” Adam shouted back.

But Carly rolled her eyes and refocused on getting out of the parking lot. She’d only taken a couple of steps when something hit her from behind. She fell to the ground with an *oomph* and realized that she was being flattened. Being run over by a car did not feel the way she would’ve imagined. Less instantaneous, more lingering. Rocks from the gravel driveway pierced her arms and she shrank against the sharpness of them.

“What the fuck?” Shireen’s voice called out.

Carly opened one eye, then both, and that was when she realized the pressure on top of her wasn’t a car, but Adam. From the corner of her vision, she spied his blue button-down, the skin of his neck and a sliver of his chin. She wriggled against him to try to get up, but was seized with pain.

“Adam?” Shireen’s stern tone made Carly freeze. “Do you want me to accidentally kill you? My car has backup cameras. And you’d reset anyway.”

“Carly tried to throw herself behind your car.” His words came out ragged as he pushed himself off.

Ohhhhhh. Wait. Was *that* what Adam had yelled at her about? Wouldn’t, “You’re about to be run over by a car!” have been the better option?

“I didn’t—” Carly started to say, but then more searing pain flashed across her back.

“And you thought you’d what? Save her?” Shireen planted her hands on her hips.

Carly understood on a very hidden level that what he’d done was a misguided selfless act, but judging by the look on Shireen’s face, she wasn’t impressed.

“Didn’t seem right to watch her off herself,” he said.

Shireen finally spoke to Carly. “Are you going to just lie there until I actually run you over?”

Carly tried to move, but the moment she did her body seized. “Ow, ow.” The words barely came out and her eyes filled with tears.

“I think you threw your back out,” Adam gently said.

“Because you tackled me,” Carly hissed.

“To save you,” Adam quickly clarified.

Shireen muttered, “That’s just fucking great.”

Carly’s dad had thrown his back out on occasion—years as a camera operator had worked their magic. Each of those times involved her dad lying on the floor and unable to move. But Carly was face down in a gravel parking lot . . . How was this going to work?

“Stay still,” Adam said. “I have some pain relievers in the office.”

Carly should’ve been surprised by the earnest tone, but she was in too much pain to react. She pursed her lips as a way of saying, *Okay*, and Adam quickly headed for the funeral home.

With only the sound of Shireen’s shoes kicking pebbles, Carly added, “Sorry. I didn’t notice your car backing up. I was just trying to get away from him.”

“You and me both.” Shireen scratched a spot on her forehead.

Carly almost felt sorry for Adam, but she felt worse for Shireen, who was now spending additional time with the ex who sometimes went out of his way to make digs at her expense. “You don’t have to stay,” Carly offered.

And while she’d sort of meant those words, she was a little surprised when Shireen quickly answered, “Okay.”

And even more dumbfounded when Shireen got in the car and pulled it forward over the bumper and across the grass, like Carly was on fire and she had to escape.

Which is how Carly found herself alone in the parking lot of a funeral home, as unable to move as everyone else in the nearby cemetery. Which made her think of her dad, something she absolutely didn’t want to do.

Things couldn’t get worse.

Except, apparently, they could. Adam’s footsteps crunched toward her. She pinched her eyes closed. Now she was stranded in a parking lot, in pain, and the only person who could help was this guy.

“Shireen left?” he asked.

“You can go, too. I’m fine,” she said. “In a few hours, I’ll reset and the loop will fix everything.”

She hoped he would speed off, but then his steps closed in. She supposed this six-foot-whatever person should be intimidating, but as Adam crouched down his expression was confusingly kind.

“Despite what you might think of me, which I’m coming to realize isn’t much, I’m not the type to just leave someone who is clearly hurt.” His fingertips tenderly brushed a small rock from her cheek. “Even if that someone sicked a dog on me only hours ago.”

Carly glanced down then, sure her cheeks had flooded pink from embarrassment. Unlike Adam, she didn’t relish being rude. He just happened to bring that side out of her.

“I’m going to turn you onto your side and lift your head.” He carefully slipped his palm under Carly’s head and gently lifted her. As he eased her shoulder up, she turned so that she was on her side. He handed her two pills and a cup of water, and she swallowed them down.

“Thank you,” Carly said. “What are they?”

“Vicodin. My dad has a bad back. He always keeps these in his desk.”

A long section of Adam’s blazing red hair fell across his face, and Carly itched to tuck it behind his ear.

As if reading her thoughts, he swiped the hair back and revealed the line of his cheekbone. “Were you . . . I mean, was that on purpose? Were you trying to hurt yourself?”

“No,” she said, maybe sounding a touch defensive.

“Okay.” It was clear Adam didn’t believe her. “Well, you know you *can’t* kill yourself, right? Because everyone has tried at some point already.”

“I don’t need you to mansplain how the loop works. I know I’d just reset.” No one died in the loop. If they tried to disappear, they just reappeared in the next one. Still, out of all the ways Carly attempted to escape, death hadn’t been one of them.

Adam sat cross-legged next to her. “Okay then, if you could *not* run behind Shireen’s car again, I’d appreciate it.”

“Reminder that *you* were the one who tackled me to the ground and screwed up my back. So now I’m in massive pain and stuck here. But now that I know it’s a big problem for *you* . . .” Carly let out a breath. She wasn’t sure if she was at fault for inconveniencing him, or if he was for every word coming out of his mouth.

The next words out of Adam, though, were unexpected. “What happens if you need to pee?”

“Excuse me?” She squinted at him.

“We can’t stay here all day. Eventually, we’ll need food and water and . . .”

“To pee,” she added quickly, because she sensed he was easily embarrassed. Sure enough, a flush crept up those dangerous cheekbones of his.

“Yes, that.” Adam looked away.

She put her free hand on her hip, as if to emphasize she was capable of moving. “Eventually, the painkillers will do their thing, and I’ll get up to . . . pee, etcetera.”

“And I’ll just wait until you can do that.”

“These rocks are surprisingly comfortable,” Carly said. “I could take an all-day nap right here.”

“I bet. The one digging into the side of your eyebrow looks particularly soft.”

She didn’t care for his smile. It was unnerving, like seeing a dog walk on its hind legs—unnatural and forced.

“You’re not going to stay with me,” Carly replied.

Adam raised a brow. “Oh, I absolutely am, if only because I can tell that *really* annoys you.”

Her mouth fell open. “I don’t want you here.”

“I don’t want you to be pecked to death by hungry buzzards, so we’re at an impasse.” He stood with the kind of ease she could only dream of in that moment. “Be back.”

Carly gripped a handful of stones in her fists and squeezed. Hard. Maybe the loop wasn’t a state of limbo, but actual hell.

As if sensing her need for a release, the pain meds kicked in and she felt altogether light and woozy. When Adam returned, he pushed a navy wheelchair.

“This feels a lot like a horror film,” she said. Though, perhaps *because* of the medication, she wasn’t as frightened as one should be when their enemy was wheeling a chair toward them.

“I know what you mean. Hearing you complain all day already feels like knives in my ears.” He came to a stop next to her and brightly said, “I’m going to lift you onto this.”

Adam was proud of his little idea, that much was clear, but Carly wasn’t going to give him a win so easily. In order to get into the chair, she’d have to move. “Do funeral directors have the upper body strength to lift thirty-something-year-old women?” She eyed his button-down shirt as if to say, *I don’t see anything impressive hiding under there.*

“I go to the gym every morning before work. Or, I used to.” The bastard’s smile widened. Then he added, “Lifting you will be nothing.”

She swallowed. “If you hurt me, then I get to do something in retaliation. Like, hand you over to the Swifties so they can use your limbs as friendship bracelet holders.”

“Weirdo.” His face was genuinely disgusted, which made her happy.

If she was in pain, he should be, too. Without much warning, he hooked his hands under her arms and bent down low and close. Unlike his sour demeanor, he smelled buttery and sweet. That was also unfortunate, seeing as butter reminded her of happier, yummiier times. And this was absolutely not one of them.

“On the count of three. Here we go. One, two . . .” He grunted on the three as he lifted her up. His arm deftly wrapped around her legs, but his other hand had accidentally landed on her boob.

“Umm,” she said at the same time he said, “Oh, God.”

His hand hurriedly moved to her shoulder, but he couldn’t meet her eyes. “So sorry,” he said as he turned toward the wheelchair.

And now she had some ammunition. She thanked whatever sick fuck of a god had trapped them in this loop, then said, “I can’t wait to tell everyone that we hooked up.”

“That’s . . .” Adam bitterly chuckled. “Please don’t do that.”

She sensed his discomfort and launched in again, “We’ll see how the day goes, funeral boy.”

His jaw clenched and she noticed the hint of auburn stubble around his face. “I’m going to gently put you in this chair now,” he said. “Tell me if anything hurts.”

He started to lower her, so she said, “It hurts!”

“Where?” Adam stopped while holding her midair.

“My boob,” she said with great relish. “She’s in pain! A ginger grabbed her!”

He pinched his lips together and then, not as gently, put Carly in the chair. Admittedly, being able to sit on something cushioned rather than on pointy rocks was much better, in general.

Carly waited for pain, but didn’t feel the stinging surges she’d been having. Sure, her back was stiff and her neck ached. If she tried to twist in any way her body screamed that it was a bad idea . . . but this sure beat the ground.

“This is great,” she lied. “I can wheel myself around.” Carly tried to move the wheelchair, but the wheels sputtered through the gravel and refused to budge.

She could almost feel the smugness in his voice as he said, “I could, ya know, get you into the funeral home—”

“No.” She wasn’t going to spend the day in there.

“Okay,” he tried again. “We could get you to my car and I’ll drive you somewhere?”

“I can’t handle two boob grabs in one day.” She hadn’t meant that joke to be as biting, but his cheeks flushed all the same.

“What if I walked you to the main road where the surface is flat? Easier to maneuver.” Adam finally looked at her.

“Okay,” Carly acquiesced. What other choice did she have?

He pushed her over the gravel and each jostle and bump caused her to tighten with pain. Eventually, they landed on the dirt road that led to town.

“I’m all set.” She gave him an exaggerated thumbs-up. Then placed her hands on the wheels, pushed them forward, and— “Fuck.”

Her back seized up all over again, and even the Vicodin haze couldn’t stop the way it tore across her muscles like a hot poker.

“Woah.” Adam was next to her, one firm hand on her shoulder.

She gritted her teeth. “Just leave me alone.”

“It’s at least a mile into town. If you try to push yourself there, you’ll mess up your back even more.”

Carly had agreed to let him get the chair onto the road, but Adam taking her the whole way wasn’t going to happen. Still, he began to push.

“But . . .” She tried to come up with some perfect excuse to get out of this, though none came.

“Insanity is doing the same thing over and over and expecting a different result. Just let me help you. We don’t have to talk,” he said.

“Good.” She exhaled and turned her focus to the wooden fences that ran parallel and sectioned off the farmland they walked past. Thick oak trees with overflowing fat branches of green leaves shaded a pasture. She was working out whether it was best to hurl herself out of the chair or stage a silent protest, when a tan cow sauntered toward the fence. Carly had never left the funeral home and seen a cow on her walk. The thing must have arrived because it was later in the day.

Had she known there would be cows—creepy giants with enormous eyes and gooey mouths—she would’ve vetoed the endeavor entirely.

“Are cows aggressive?” Carly gave the cow some serious side-eye.

“What?”

“They can’t jump the fence, though,” she told herself for reassurance.

“Right?”

“No, they can’t jump the fence. And no, they aren’t aggressive,” Adam said.

The cow mooed at no one in particular.

Carly shivered. “Terrifying.”

Adam waited a beat. “I don’t even know how to respond to that.”

“You can add my fear of cows to the list of reasons why you hate me,” she said.

He cocked an eyebrow. “*Hate* is a very strong word.”

“So you just mildly dislike me, then?”

“I don’t dislike you,” he said. “Why would you say that?”

“So, you don’t hate or mildly dislike me.” Carly didn’t wait for him to respond. “You’re just deeply unfriendly?”

“Something like that.” He smiled.

And then, instead of going back to perfectly acceptable silence, she began to make small talk. She’d never been great with the quiet. “Where do you go during the day? The last loop was the first time I’ve seen you in town.”

“I go to my parents’ house,” Adam said. “They have a big piece of land. I can be there on my own.”

Carly often daydreamed about the place she used to love being on her own—her studio apartment in Burbank, where she could eat boxed macaroni and cheese straight from the pan while editing a screenplay on the couch.

“Where do you go?” he asked. “To your dad’s?”

Her dad had an apartment close to town, but she didn’t like to spend time there. The air still smelled like his Head & Shoulders shampoo and the Old Spice deodorant he favored. The handful of times she’d opened the door and walked in, she’d become so overwhelmed by the feel of him there that she’d had to run outside and take big gulps of fresh air.

“I go all over. Into town. Anywhere that isn’t a cow pasture.” Ahead of them, the dirt turned into concrete, which signaled they were getting closer.

“I’m not all that good on my own, as it turns out. I’m not used to just floating. I like having something to do, thanks to my ADHD.”

She’d accidentally revealed that detail; it was something she didn’t really want Adam to know. Intellectually, she knew that there was nothing to be ashamed of, but she was also deeply aware of the stigmas that often surrounded her diagnosis. She cleared her throat of the self-conscious feeling that had knotted there.

Adam didn’t seem to notice, though, as he popped up the front wheels of the chair so they could land safely on the sidewalk.

They were at the top of Main Street. Carly wasn’t sure how she’d fill the time until the loop reset, but at least she’d have a lot of people-watching readily available.

She had to give Adam some credit for helping. He certainly didn’t owe her anything. “Thanks for the help,” she hesitantly said.

“Sorry I tackled you,” he said. “I imagined we would kind of fall away from the car safely, versus me just pinning you to the ground.”

And then the memory of him on top of her, of his weight over every inch of her . . . She unexpectedly tightened her knees together. She was horrified. Downright baffled by her body’s betrayal. Had her hormones no shame?

All right, fine . . . Adam was attractive. In a hot alien kind of way, with the shock of hair, and the glowing vampire skin, and the pointy cheekbones and the full lips, and the height and the surprise biceps. But he was still *Adam the Asshole*, despite helping her up and getting her medicine and making sure buzzards didn’t peck her to an impermanent death.

So the sooner she got away from him, the better.

“Guess I’ll see you tomorrow,” she said. But would she? Hadn’t her whole purpose this morning been to avoid him? So she added, “I mean, if this is *hell* then I will see you tomorrow.”

His lips tightened into a familiar line. “Right. Bye, then.”

As he turned to leave, the sound of shattering glass pierced through the air. The last thing Carly clocked was Adam ducking down next to the wheelchair. And then the world went dark.

Chapter 6

Adam

A loud pop rang in Adam's ears as he crouched next to Carly and covered her head with his hands. The sound was quick, over almost as soon as it happened, but he brought her into him to protect her from whatever the noise was.

He noticed the closeness. She noticed the closeness. It was way too much, and Adam pulled back. When he glanced up, there was a store window that had been destroyed, and a few feet in front of it was a group of people carrying large rocks.

"The Chaos Club," Carly said softly. "Total adrenaline junkies. One time I saw them walk into the Candy Depot and eat until each person vomited."

"Gross," Adam said.

"To be fair, I was one of the people in the store bingeing candy, but I stopped before the vomiting."

"Did you?" he asked.

"Yeah . . ." Her voice trailed off.

He squinted skeptically at her, and she quickly changed the subject. "Don't worry about them. They're angry and have endless time. Nothing good comes of that."

"I'm angry, too, but I'm not breaking windows." Adam cracked his knuckles, as if he was about to *do* something.

"Before you Hulk out, can you just focus on wheeling me to Moms?" Carly's question snapped his thoughts back to the present. He looked at her,

sitting in the wheelchair with her hands folded in her lap. She was so calm about this whole thing. Clearly, she'd grown numb to the madhouse of the loop and lost any sense of real danger.

"I can't just take you into one of these storefronts they're hurling rocks at." Adam fisted a handful of his hair, frustrated with Carly's blasé attitude. "What if you get hit?"

"They usually only target places without people in them."

"Usually?"

She rolled her eyes, like he was being unreasonable. He didn't care. He'd gotten her this far, and he wasn't about to let her get hurt now. "Let me just bring you somewhere else. To your dad's?"

Carly flinched. It was a barely perceptible movement, but he'd noticed it all the same. Maybe she didn't want the reminder of Bruce Hart. She hadn't even attended the burial, so perhaps they weren't close. Adam hadn't lost either of his parents. Shireen, in a sense, but he still saw her every day. He couldn't imagine what Carly was going through, and he wasn't sure if her mom was still in her life.

"Or, to the library down the street?" he offered. "It's safe there."

"I'm more of an audiobook gal, but okay." Carly's voice was resigned.

As Adam pushed her down the sidewalk they moved in amicable silence. He worried that by bringing up her dad, he'd somehow offended her. Maybe he should apologize, or check in? But then he was stopped in his tracks, because on the opposite sidewalk there was Shireen holding hands with Dean. They carefully walked over the broken glass. Dean shoved shards aside with his wingtip boots so Shireen would have an easier path. Shireen cringed as she nearly stepped on a bigger piece, then looked to Dean, who pulled her in close like he was some big, chivalrous hero. Shireen cuddled in tight to him, playing a damsel in distress.

Adam had never seen them together as a couple. He'd fantasized plenty of times about a moment where he'd see them, and how he'd be much taller than Dean, and have on something other than his standard work suit. As he was now—sweating, uncombed hair, hunched over a wheelchair—*this* wasn't his time to come face-to-face with ShirDean or Direen or whatever reprehensible couple name they'd created.

"Adam?"

Carly's voice broke through his thoughts, which is when he realized that they'd stopped moving altogether. She followed his line of sight. "Oh shit,

are they seriously nuzzling noses?”

Adam gave a slow nod. He couldn't look away. The nuzzling was sort of grotesquely hypnotic. He didn't say anything, but stayed locked in on the undeniable proof that he'd been left behind.

Carly let out a big whoosh of air. “I see why you don't come into town. I wouldn't want to see my ex, either. And their names *rhyme*. How do they live with themselves?”

Adam touched his wedding ring absentmindedly, and wondered if Shireen wore hers during the day or took it off after she left the funeral home. “How do you know about them?”

She squinted. “I mean, whenever you two talk you tend to share, like, a lot of very specific details. Pretty memorable moments for me.”

His jaw tightened again, but she carried on talking.

“I've been cheated on, too. Freshman year of college, I walked into my dorm room to find my then-girlfriend making out with my roommate. They asked if I wanted to join, like it was a book club.” Carly took in a deep breath. “It's awful.”

She talked a lot—too much, really. Nevertheless, he acknowledged her rambling with, “Yes, it is.”

“And the worst part is how pathetic you feel, you know? Like, was I really so bad that you had to hook up with my roommate under her *Breaking Dawn: Part 2* poster?”

Carly looked to him for validation, as if he knew what any of those words meant.

“Come on, *Breaking Dawn: Part 2*. The *Twilight* franchise. The movie where they name a baby Renesmee.” She glanced at Adam for acknowledgment, and he was relieved that he had none for her. “Anyway, the point is moments like that can make you feel terrible, almost worse than the cheating itself.”

Adam wasn't entirely sure that was true. But then it happened: Shireen and Dean turned and clocked that Adam was there. And his response was to curl in on himself, as if sucker punched.

Wasn't that what this was? The whole loop was just one big punch to the gut over and over again. Adam wanted to scream. He wanted to grab a rock, just as the Chaos Club had, and hurl it so that something other than himself was broken.

Just as quickly, though, Carly reached for his hand and intertwined her fingers with his.

He looked down at their joined hands. "What are you doing?"

"Take a deep breath," she said. "You look like you're about to fall over, and you're way too big for me to catch even when I'm standing."

Adam stared into her eyes, took a deep breath and let it out.

"Good," Carly said. "Again."

They both inhaled, then exhaled. Inhaled and exhaled.

Adam's eyes burned with the sting of tears. It was one thing to have the idea of Shireen and Dean, but seeing them together was a new kind of horror. "I don't usually . . ." He could barely get the words he wanted to say out. *I don't usually cry.*

He could still see the shape of her and Dean through his blurred vision. They'd been holding each other, touching, very much together. Like she'd really moved on from their marriage.

"I'm sorry, Adam." Carly squeezed his hand tighter. "What they're doing is total bullshit."

He didn't want to pass out or weep, or both. So he simply pinched his eyes closed and breathed out again.

"I have an idea," Carly said. "Do you want to do something that will make you feel better?"

He'd cut off his own leg if it guaranteed him relief from the white-hot burn of shame filling his throat. Adam nodded.

Carly's cool palm squeezed his again. She glanced down at their joined hands, then looked back up at him. He couldn't help noticing how plump that bottom lip of hers was.

Her tongue licked the bottom lip he'd admired, as if in acknowledgment. "You saved me from a car today, and now it's my turn to repay the favor. My good deed for the day."

"Good deed? I'm not your charity case. I don't need—" He honestly didn't even know what he was protesting, but without much warning Carly pushed herself up from the chair and leaned into his arms. Adam hurried to hold her up, and as he did she reached behind his neck, pulled him down and kissed him. A kiss so surprising that Adam nearly tripped backward, but instead just fell closer toward her.

Well, she didn't *actually* kiss him. She kissed her own thumb, which was placed strategically over his lips. When she pulled away, Adam felt dizzy

from all the things going on in that moment.

Shireen's nose nuzzling up to Dean's.

Carly's thumb and lips on his mouth.

Her breath that smelled like the free peppermints they had in the lobby of the funeral home. He loved those.

"Okay, my back," Carly's voice was pained, and Adam lowered her into the chair. She let out a shuddering breath as she relaxed into the seat. Then she looked up, and he could just make out the line of sweat along her hairline. She looked . . . exhausted. Like what she'd just done had taken every single drop of energy.

But what *had* she done? Why had she gone and kissed him?

"What the hell was that?" he eventually asked.

"Look," she said softly, almost imperceptibly signaling to where Shireen was. He glanced over and, to his surprise, Shireen locked eyes with Adam, as if trying to silently ask, *What the fuck?*

"It worked, right?" Carly whispered.

"I . . ." he started to say. "I don't understand. What worked?"

She released her grip on the arm of the chair and took hold of his hand again. "Every day I do something nice for someone else."

"Nice?" Now he was even more confused. Did she really think that was *nice*? And why was he so lightheaded?

"Pretending to kiss you was my nice thing! No chance she'll be thinking about Dean for the next—"

As if on cue, Goldie's booming voice came through a megaphone with, "Ten hours remaining, people!"

"She gets it." Carly hooked a thumb in the direction of the voice. "Now, wheel me off into the sunset and don't look back."

Adam did as he was told, mainly because he worried that if he didn't, Carly might try to kiss him again. The woman was unpredictable. He guided the chair down the sidewalk. Still, he couldn't stop smelling the peppermint of Carly's mouth. And the weight of her on him was . . .

Shock. He was clearly in total shock, because Adam hadn't kissed another person in a decade. Shireen hadn't been his first kiss, but she had been his first in almost all the other ways. The first person he'd fallen in love with, had sex with, gotten married to.

But when his mouth was a breath from Carly's, his thoughts ceased and all he could hear was his own heart loudly pulsing in his ears.

He snuck a glance back at Shireen, but she wasn't looking at him anymore. She was focused on Dean, and they appeared to be in the middle of a heated discussion. No more nuzzled noses.

Well, that was *interesting*.

"How did you learn to do that?" he asked. "Kissing without . . . the kissing."

"My dad worked in film when he lived in LA," Carly explained as they arrived at the other end of Main Street. "It's called a stage kiss. All the actors do it."

"Your dad was an actor?" Adam carefully set the wheels off the lip of the curb and onto the road. The library was two more blocks down.

"He was a cameraman, but he brought me to set a lot. In between takes, he'd talk to me about what was happening in each scene. He was . . ."

She drifted off. Adam waited to see if she'd continue, but when she didn't, he asked, "Is that what you do in LA, too?"

She cleared her throat. "No, no, you saw how my back reacted to that fall. I'm a screenwriter. Or, well, trying to be one. I haven't sold anything yet, but I'm getting close. I bartend to pay the rent."

Carly stopped Adam by holding up a hand, allowing a man covered head to toe in rainbow balloons to walk past. How the guy was able to see where he was going was a true mystery.

"Never met a screenwriter," Adam said. "That's really cool." Had he just given Carly a compliment on top of having kissed her? He frowned at the state of their current relationship.

Or, rather, whatever this was. Definitely *not* a relationship.

Carly blew air through her lips. "I get it. You think I should be doing something practical with my life."

He frowned again. "I just told you that I think screenwriting is cool."

"Everything that comes out of your mouth is sarcasm." And then she scrunched up her face and said, "*Acorns in the walls?*"

If he didn't know any better, he'd say she was putting on some kind of accent to impersonate his voice. "I do not sound like a congested gremlin."

She raised her eyebrows and said, "Sure you don't."

And suddenly, he remembered why he'd wanted to get this over with as quickly as possible in the first place. He was still so dazed from their time together—the evil cows, the stage kiss—that he'd forgotten how unpleasant Carly was.

“Luckily for both of us, we’re at the library.” He stopped the wheelchair at the entrance, then hit the big blue button that swung the doors open.

“Finally,” she said.

And something about that twisted a knot in his stomach. Was he really a person others wanted to run from? First Shireen, and now Carly? And why did he care about what Carly thought at all?

Because no one will ever love you, the annoying voice in his head chimed. The same voice he’d had since Shireen left him.

Carly turned to him. “You’re welcome for the Shireen thing back there, by the way.”

He didn’t even know what to say to that. He hadn’t asked Carly for help. So why should he thank her?

Carly began to wheel herself in through the open doors, which is when he thought to say, “And *you* are welcome for the two-mile push to safety!” Even though he’d shouted that last bit, the doors had closed behind her and Adam wasn’t entirely sure she’d even heard him.

By the time Adam walked back to his car at the funeral home, it was late in the afternoon. He hadn’t seen his parents in almost a full loop. He wondered if they were anxious or just thrilled that he’d taken their advice to heart. And he wasn’t ready to go home yet, because he was a terrible liar and wouldn’t even know where to begin with explaining his morning.

So instead, he drove out to his favorite flower farm in Julian. In the fall, the farm opened its gates to tourists and locals for a harvest of pumpkins, apple cider and bouquets. But with the loop, there were few places people didn’t let themselves into. He opened the fence, drove through and parked in the middle of a field.

Jasmine bloomed along the wooden fence and filled the air with the thick and heady scent. The air hummed with crickets and the faint caw of a crow. He didn’t need Goldie to tell him that it was almost time for the eclipse, as a quick glance upward revealed the moon approaching the sun.

Adam slipped on his protective glasses, leaned against the hood of the car and crossed his arms. He didn’t have his usual set of tools, but he had his watch to keep the time. He scanned the ground for the flits of shadow bands, but didn’t see any from his vantage point. No bother, he could still time the eclipse. The moon’s cavernous mouth gobbled up the sun, and the

caw of the crow and the hum of the crickets vanished. Adam marked the time on his watch.

In that moment, a gnat flew across his face. He waved the thing away, and Carly popped into his head. Of course she appeared at the presence of something annoying. He sighed, because more irritating was the reminder of their last interaction and how she assumed he was making fun of her career choices. He didn't think she was silly. Quite the opposite, he was jealous of the kind of confidence it would take to do something as scary as write a movie. What if people hated it? What if she never got a movie made? What would she do for money?

Jesus, he was starting to sound like his dad. Sometimes people pursued their dreams and actually got them. What would Carly think about the fact that unlike her, his passion for astronomy wasn't one he'd been brave enough to go after?

The realization of that made his stomach clench. Adam clung to what he'd known, and Carly raced toward something she had no control over. Her success wasn't guaranteed, and she didn't at all seem bothered by that. While Adam . . .

He took in a deep breath and let it out. He'd already had one crisis today, and he certainly didn't need another. He glanced at his watch, then up to the sky. The eclipse would end soon. He waited for the moment when the moon began to cough the sun back out. But as the sliver of light surfaced and Adam looked down at the watch, he froze.

He double-checked the time. Then triple-checked. He ran through the eclipse, when he'd started the timer and when he'd ended it. Had there been any deviation? No. He'd done this experiment the same exact way for as long as he could remember.

Four minutes and twenty-two seconds.

How was the eclipse ten seconds shorter?

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Chapter 7

Carly

Day 240

Carly sharply exhaled as she appeared in the funeral service room. She stared at her dad's coffin. Her back was healed and now she could go about her day—this time blissfully Adam-free. She clasped her hands and silently thanked the loop gods, whoever they were.

"So you're dating that girl now?" Shireen's muffled voice floated through the air like a piece of bait on the line.

Well, *that girl* had to be Carly. The last time Shireen had addressed her, she said she'd liked Carly. Now, though? Her tone suggested the opposite. Carly instinctively slid down in her chair. What *had* she been thinking by kissing Adam? Er, *stage* kissing him. She could definitely be impulsive, something she got from her dad—he bought old movie theaters; she tried to rescue men she barely knew . . .

She was only trying to do the guy a favor while simultaneously fulfilling her good deed quotient for the day. She'd helped him. She was the Good Samaritan of smooching. She hadn't meant to hurt Shireen, though. Adam's ex had clearly moved on with Dean, right?

"You gave me *such* a hard time for the whole Dean thing, but all it takes is one suicidal leap and you're *with* her?" Shireen tried again. "Why aren't you saying anything?"

"The eclipse was shorter," Adam said. "Ten seconds shorter."

Carly rolled her eyes. Adam was odd. He was a funeral director, overly tall and obsessed with the eclipse, apparently. The only thing stranger was how soft his hair had felt between her fingers. She unexpectedly got goose bumps and rubbed her hands over her arms. Was she so desperate for human touch that she was now getting excited by someone's hair?

Shireen let out a disbelieving, "Okay, whatever." Then, as was always the case, the office door slammed open and her footsteps filled the hall. Carly was tempted to turn in her chair to watch Shireen leave, but had learned her lesson about interfering with these two. When the space went quiet, Carly stood. She came to the hallway and froze as she saw Adam.

He leaned against the office door frame and gnawed on his bottom lip, lost in thought.

She should leave. She should run, actually. Carly was going to be Adam-free today, meaning she shouldn't interact with him. So she put one foot in front of the other and started toward the exit.

Ten seconds shorter. Adam's words echoed in her head. What had he meant by that? Was he saying something in the loop had changed?

The alarm bells blared inside Carly's mind as she turned back, took a breath and said, "You okay?"

Of course he was not okay. This was a man who was perpetually sullen. And hadn't she asked a similar question during the other loop and been met with nothing but a withering glare?

Carly shook her head. "Never mind," she muttered, turning to leave.

"Your back is fixed," Adam said.

She stopped walking. She'd opened the door, and he'd come through it. What else had she expected to happen? She turned to Adam. "What were you telling Shireen just now? I heard you mention the eclipse."

Adam's expression changed into something more genuine. "I study the eclipse." His gaze met hers. "Or, it's kind of like a hobby. Just something to pass the time, like your good deed thing."

Passing time was everyone's prime motivation, as far as she could tell. Apparently, he spent his days fixated on the eclipse. "So you . . ." She wasn't even sure what to ask. "Something happened?"

"I time every eclipse, and without fail it always lasts four minutes and thirty-two seconds, but yesterday it changed."

"Ten seconds?"

"Yes, it was ten seconds shorter," Adam confirmed.

It was disturbing but true that Carly thought his eyes had softened and that they looked . . . nice.

“If it had been a smaller number, I’d chalk it up to an error,” he continued. “But I’ve been doing this for so long . . . I didn’t make a mistake.”

No, Carly could tell by his manicured fingernails that he wasn’t the messy type. He was probably one of those people who had a closet full of crisp, ironed shirts and alphabetized his books.

And then the briefest image of Adam, with his button-down untucked, his hair mussed and those intense eyes directed at her flashed through.

“Carly?” His concerned tone cut in.

She shook her head and the thought of him away. Clearly, she was unwell. “Sorry, you were saying?”

“This is the first time I’ve noticed anything change in the Julian sky since the loop started. I can count on the sunset occurring at seven twenty-nine, a shooting star at eleven twenty-three and the eclipse lasting for four minutes and thirty-two seconds.” He ran a hand through his hair as he paced the room. “So if the eclipse is shorter, that means that something about the loop is changing, too.”

“That’s not possible, is it?” Carly eventually asked.

“It is, apparently.” He tilted his head, and a hopeful expression crossed his face.

“What do you think this means?” Carly could think of a million things it could mean. If the eclipse was shorter, maybe the loop was getting shorter, too. Maybe shorter meant that it would eventually just disappear. “Like, the loop might stop? We could get out of here?” She thought of Burbank and her apartment. Waking up early to work on a new screenplay and going for a self-congratulatory bear claw at The Donut Hut. Somewhere out there, Marilyn Montgomery was waiting for Carly to reply to her email . . .

“The loop might stop, yes,” Adam said.

He was a man of few words, she realized, but Carly always had plenty of those. Because now that she’d heard this thing about the eclipse, there was no unhearing it. She wouldn’t be able to just go about her loop like everything was normal.

“This is amazing,” she said. “What should we—should we *do* something? Should we start telling people? I mean, this is *huge*. This is the

most exciting thing to happen since that time the mayor got everyone to fill a swimming pool with Skittles.”

When there was no response, just Adam’s trademark judgmental scowl, Carly added, “Do you have any idea how many Skittles it takes to fill an entire pool? This was an all-day team effort that ended in everyone getting to belly flop into the pool. I got to taste the rainbow face-first, Adam.”

And to her shock, he laughed. A small hiccup of a thing that he quickly suppressed, but still . . . a laugh. He screwed his expression back to grumpy as he said, “I shouldn’t have told you anything.”

“Why?” Carly was suddenly self-conscious. Sure, she’d just regaled him with a story about jumping into a pool of candy-coated snacks, but was that reason enough not to tell her about the eclipse? She could be a serious person. She was deeply serious about getting the fuck out of this loop, for one. “You know what, don’t answer that. It’s too late. You already told me. I know about the eclipse changing. And now, whether you like it or not, I’m going to help you. Consider me your partner in breaking the loop.”

That made him snap out of it. “Hold on, we can’t control the loop.”

And *this* was where Carly saw her opportunity. “I don’t think the time just randomly changed. Something probably happened to cause the change, and we need to figure out what it was.”

“You have a point. I see that,” he started to say. “I just don’t totally understand how my observations and your . . . What is it that you’re adding to this endeavor?”

“My people skills, you unfeeling robot.” Carly accidentally leaned toward him, despite her words. She made an effort to pull back.

“Ah, yes, your ability to charm,” Adam joked.

“So, we have a deal?” she pressed again. “We’ll work together so we can both stop the loop and never have to see each other again.”

Adam swallowed, then extended his hand to hers and said, “To never seeing each other again.”

As he took her palm, Carly was surprised by how the warmth of his hand traveled through her. And when she pulled away, her whole body tingled from it.

Maybe he’d felt it, too, because he’d gone quiet. But then he started to worry his lip, like he was holding information back. The man was infuriating.

“Is there something you’re not telling me?” Carly asked. “Something that, I don’t know, is causing you to nearly eat your own lip off?”

“I’m thinking,” he quickly said. “Not all of us just open our mouths and let whatever is in our heads pour out.”

“Uh, rude.” She crossed her arms to reinforce her stance.

“Look, I don’t know what to do here.” Adam finally met her gaze. “This is . . . It’s significant, for sure.”

“Yes, significant!” she said, because this was the closest thing to enthusiasm she’d get from him. And she’d promised to come up with ideas, so she spit out the first one that popped into her head. “What if we check in with the people still working to break the loop? Like Rick Gaines?”

The mayor had mentioned Rick was in need of a good deed. Rick, who was part of the small contingent still trying to find a way out of Julian. They’d certainly want to know if there were changes with the eclipse.

Adam stopped the chewing. “Rick is . . . I don’t want to say, *strange*, because that doesn’t seem fair, but he’s the kind of guy who has a bunker filled with doomsday supplies.”

“Well, we’re the ones stuck in a time loop. Maybe the bunker wasn’t such a bad idea.”

Adam cracked his neck as if winding up. “He once ran for mayor, and his platform was that he’d been abducted by aliens who instructed him to run for public office because, if he didn’t, they’d come back to abduct him again.”

Carly didn’t say anything. She dug the toe of her boot into the floor. “Again, we are stuck in a time loop. Maybe the aliens are real.”

“They very much are real,” Adam said. “I’m just not wholly convinced of why they’d need Rick to be mayor.”

Carly’s initial instinct was to argue. She wasn’t normally the type, but there was just something about his know-it-all face and his innate ability to put her in a bad mood that made her want to throw verbal punches. But was she really about to argue that maybe Rick—whom she’d never met—had something the aliens wanted? Was that an argument she’d win? A hill she wanted to crawl up and die on?

No, as it turned out, it wasn’t. But Carly had a hunch about Rick, and roughly a bottomless pit of motivation she’d inherited from her dad. Bruce had blind faith in moving his entire life to Julian, and Carly had blind faith

in going to see Rick. Maybe this fact about the eclipse shortening, coupled with a theory of Rick's, could give them a way out.

For the first time in a very long time, Carly saw a light at the end of this infinite tunnel. Her whole body was awake, like when the hot summer weather finally shifted into fall and the cool air pricked her skin back to life. Wouldn't it be nice to experience a new season? All she had to do was convince Adam that this was a good idea.

"When I've stopped the loop, you'll look back on this moment and thank me." She gestured for Adam to follow her. "Come on, let's go see Rick. What could the harm be?"

The harm was that Rick's "house," as it turned out, was an airstream parked in the middle of the forest with over a hundred plastic pink flamingos in the makeshift yard.

"Oh," Carly said, but thought, *maybe Adam was right*.

Adam leaned across her and pointed out the passenger-side window. "Looks like he got a new bird feeder."

"The *bird* feeder?" she asked. "You're focused on the very ordinary, very small, bird feeder and *not* the flock of pink flamingos?"

"Look at that, a little bluejay." Adam smiled at the bird feeder and completely, maybe intentionally, ignored Carly's comment. "Like I said, Rick's a bit eccentric."

"Yeah," she said. "He's like John Waters on steroids."

"Who?" Adam asked.

"Just one of the most important filmmakers of all time." She rubbed a spot on her forehead where a headache now bloomed. "What *do* they teach you in funeral school, if not the classics?"

Much to her surprise, Adam looked amused. And Carly was rather pleased about that.

Bizarre, she thought, and got out of the car to avoid Adam's wry expression. Carly started for Rick's door, but about halfway there, a voice from a loudspeaker blared.

"What do you want?"

Maybe she'd tripped some alarm system. Carly was surprised a net hadn't swept her off the ground and left her dangling upside down under the flamingos' watchful eyes.

Carly looked to Adam. What did one do in a situation like this? The only weapon she had was her combat boots—could she throw one at the airstream and run?

Adam stepped out of the car and yelled, “Rick, it’s Adam Rhodes! I’m here with a friend. She just wants to meet you.”

They both waited.

“Adam?” the voice sounded.

“Adam Rhodes, yes.” He shut the car door and came to stand next to Carly, and she was suddenly glad Adam was so very tall.

A series of metal locks erupted near the door and it swung open. There was Rick—a breadbox of a man, with a cropped haircut, trim beard and goggles so thick it was hard to see his eyes behind them. He held on to the frame to show how he absolutely didn’t want them in his space.

But it was hard to ignore the power ballad blaring through his airstream, Bette Midler’s “The Wind Beneath My Wings.”

Carly was nosy and couldn’t help but comment. “Great song.”

To her shock, Rick’s chin began to wobble. “It really is,” he said. “I apologize. Every time I reset, I’m in the middle of watching *Beaches*.”

“*Beaches*?” Adam asked.

In her head, Carly also thought, *Beaches? As in, the classic friendship movie? This man with the bunker and the aliens coming after him was watching . . . Beaches?* She didn’t say any of that, though, because now she sensed a way in.

“It’s my go-to when I need a good cry,” Carly said, adding to the camaraderie. Maybe if *she* could be his friend, Rick would be willing to talk to them.

“Me, too,” Rick said. “I just wish every day didn’t start like this.” He reached out a hand, and Carly immediately took it with a supportive squeeze. *Bingo*.

“I know what you mean,” Carly said, and she really did. “What if I told you there might be a way out of the loop?”

Rick narrowed his eyes at them. “I’m listening.”

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Chapter 8

Adam

Adam knew he wasn't a scientist. In fact, he'd never told anyone he was. Carly and Rick, however, seemed to believe otherwise, as evidenced by their barrage of questions.

Have there been other changes in the sky?

What happened to make the eclipse shorter?

Has the loop shortened, too?

Adam's answer to all of these was a simple, "I don't know." He'd found it best in situations where he felt uncertain of the stakes to think before he spoke.

Carly, on the other hand, seemed to have the opposite approach. "What if the eclipse losing time means we're finally out of the loop? What if there's a way to speed that process up? Wouldn't that be amazing?" She asked rapid-fire without waiting for answers.

"And what if this is all happening because I'm getting closer to the *Truman Show* door the government doesn't want us to find?" Rick's eyes bugged out behind his goggles.

Adam couldn't bring himself to look at Carly, just in case she didn't find any of this alarming. Instead, he focused on a singular flamingo nearby. The paint around its plastic eye had worn off, giving it a deranged expression, which was reflective of how Adam felt.

The thing about being a people pleaser to his core was that Adam was easily swayed. That was why he'd agreed to Carly's suggestion of telling

Rick in the first place. In hindsight, there were other options Adam could've suggested instead. After all, there was a whole Dark Sky Community run by those who loved the stars just as much as he did. And early on in the loop, he'd even met a Caltech professor who'd come to Julian specifically to study the eclipse.

Sure, odds were those people had succumbed to the insanity that was a time loop, but maybe hearing about a change would kickstart something inside them.

Instead, Adam was sandwiched between a professional conspiracy theorist and a cute screenwriter.

Cute? How had that word slipped into the equation?

Adam finally glanced at Carly, wondering if she could hear his thoughts. And maybe she had, because she pressed a palm against the side of the trailer above her head and stretched herself out like a cat. She wasn't a tall person, but the line of her made his chest warm.

Hot. There was a new word.

"You're still testing the perimeter?" Carly asked and, much to Adam's disappointment, she dropped her hand and returned to a normal position. She did readjust her glasses though, which he realized were a thick, dark purple frame. He rather liked those, too.

"I won't stop until I get to the end of it." Rick pulled a worn map from the back pocket of his jeans. When he unfolded it, there was a curved line drawn in thick black ink around the top half of Julian. There were small X marks around a quarter of the circle, ticked off like the seconds on a clock. "The map doesn't stay, obviously. I have to redo this each morning. But I keep track as best I can."

Adam had seen the map before. When the loop began and the initial shock of repeating every day wore off, the town had come together each reset to strategize ways out. Adam had attended those town meetings. He'd even seen Carly there, not that they were speaking or anything, but she sort of stood out with her Wednesday Addams clothes and her nonstop need to talk, like a goth prom queen.

From the beginning, Rick had pulled out his map and come up with a theory about how to escape. The "Pop the Bubble" theory, as it became known, was this: The town was surrounded by some kind of bubble that kept them all trapped together. They knew this because when people in town tried to simply drive away, while they might be in the car one minute,

once they hit the theorized invisible barrier, they restarted the next loop with everyone else. To physically leave Julian wasn't possible—not so far—and any attempts at doing so just reset that person. So according to Rick, to get out of the loop they needed to find a spot in the perimeter with an exit door. If there wasn't one, then maybe going through a spot over and over again could cause the perimeter to weaken, create a hole and pop the bubble.

So far, though, Rick was still here. They all were, of course.

"You've been doing this by yourself?" Carly asked.

"Well, no. The town helped me work on this initially, but then people got discouraged and stopped trying." Rick folded the map up and put it back into his pocket. "There's still a few of us working to find a way out. I'd say we're about a quarter through the map."

The town was only eight square miles, and that was exactly what their world was, too. Eight miles would be the only thing Adam would ever know for the rest of his life if he didn't find a way out. Adam hadn't allowed himself to feel hopeful about ending the loop in a very long time. Hope could be a dangerous thing—he knew that firsthand when it came to Shireen. But there was something about this conversation that lit an ember in his chest. What if they *could* stop this? What if he didn't have to restart every day in the middle of an argument?

"Remember when someone suggested a town witch had cast a spell to trap us all?" Carly looked nervously into the woods. "What if the witch is listening?"

"Tell you what. If I'd been mayor instead of Franco, the aliens would've come to take us out of this by now," Rick said with total and utter conviction.

Adam pinched his eyes closed. What he wouldn't give for the aliens to appear at that very moment to carry him away from this conversation.

"Have you noticed anything unusual in the past few loops?" Carly asked.

"I haven't." Rick puffed out his chest. "And to be honest, should we even be getting worked up about this yet? The timing could easily be user error."

Adam was reminded that he'd never liked group projects. Why try to be nice to people you barely knew? Why work the hardest and then have to share the credit?

He should be home. He should be getting ready to observe the shadow bands and time the eclipse. He should be back to the life he was

comfortable with instead of having to defend his own findings. If they didn't want to believe that Adam had witnessed a deviation, then they didn't have to. He could continue to watch the eclipse as he always had and always did.

"I better head out." Adam massaged his temples. "Just got a splitting headache."

Rick's expression was all sympathetic concern, exactly what Adam wanted. But Carly watched him with beady certainty. While Rick had bought the bullshit, it was clear that Carly wasn't going to.

Adam didn't want to stick around, though. If he did, Carly would call him out. They'd have another argument. And he wasn't in the mood to fight when they'd just gotten to a place where he made her laugh and she gave him knowing looks.

So he pivoted on his heel and tore off toward the hearse. The thunder of boots behind him was alarming, but he refused to turn around.

"A headache? Really?" Carly's voice was low, so only he'd hear. "You've apparently been timing the eclipse every loop like a mad scientist, but a doomsdayer pokes and you go running?"

Carly made a valid point, but Adam wasn't always as delicate as the day she'd taken pity on him. He could bark back, too.

"This is the one thing in my life that I really like doing. I don't have a lot of options, but the eclipse, and the stars? Those are *my* things. And I don't have to explain those to anyone, especially not people who want to believe in witches causing a time loop." He finally stopped walking and faced her.

Instead of Carly rolling up her sleeves to deliver the next wallop, she said, "For the record, I brought up the witches thing because I sensed Rick would feel some camaraderie. It's called *reading the room*, and you should try it sometime."

"Something tells me that's a theory you bought, though," Adam sniped back.

"You know what? I don't want to fight. Show me, Rhodes. I said we're in this together, so show me what you're seeing. Maybe Rick doesn't want to believe, but I want to believe."

"Is that an *X-Files* reference?" He was annoyed by how hopeful his voice was.

But then, to his additional surprise, she said, "I'm learning how to speak Adam."

Adam could've brought Carly to a field or the center of town to watch the eclipse, but the day had been unpredictable, and Adam didn't want any more surprises.

Carly shoved her hands in her pockets and spun in a slow circle as she took in the tree house. "This place is . . ."

Horrendous. Grimy. Creepy. He waited for whichever word she planned to choose, but then she filled in the blank with, "Way more spacious than I anticipated. It's basically the size of my living room back home."

Her expression was something close to awe. "I always wanted a tree house. We didn't have a huge backyard, though." She picked up the binoculars and looked through them and directly at him. "So you were always a nerd, huh?"

"I . . ." Was he flustered? *This* was why Adam didn't bring other people into his space.

"Chill out, I was a nerd, too." She put the binoculars down. "Just a film nerd instead of Bill Nye." She leaned a palm against his desk, and he really did have to acknowledge the curve of her hips as her dress clung from the gravitational pull. He wondered what it might be like to use his fingers to trace a line from her hip all the way up to her— *Stop*, he told himself.

And then he forced himself to say something. "What does a movie nerd do, just watch movies?" Adam crossed his arms and tried to imagine baby Carly during a movie marathon. Her big glasses, boots and a bag of popcorn.

"Excuse me, we call them *films*," she corrected. "I went to film festivals. Worked on student films. I made a list of every one I saw and wrote reviews. I had a blog."

And Adam thought that was rather endearing, though he wouldn't dare tell her that. So instead he said, "But did you have a movie tree house?"

"No." Her eyes flitted down the length of him, then back up, before she said, "More like a *film* couch."

Something about the way she'd just looked at him, and the word *couch* sent a jolt right to his dick. He readjusted his pants as her eyes blessedly caught on something other than him. Then she reached for his open high school notebook and just as quickly as he'd gotten a hard-on, he hurriedly closed the cover. He didn't know why—it was just random observations he'd made about the Orion constellation—but these were his private

thoughts. She couldn't just come barging in and peel those things open like he was a banana.

He wasn't her banana.

"Well, if you were trying to prove that you aren't a serial killer, this would be evidence against you." She crossed her arms.

"It's just . . . my notebook," he said lamely. "Of things."

She raised an eyebrow.

"My high school notebook," he tried again.

"Ah," she said knowingly. "Phallic drawings of space shuttles? Notes about how weirdly hot Leela from *Futurama* is? Perhaps an erotic story about the earth fucking the moon?"

"The earth cannot fuck the moon, Carly," he said, fake outraged.

"You're clearly lacking some imagination there." She gave him a little grin, and he tried to hide the smile threatening to break across his face, too.

"You are impossible," he said, but thought, *You are not what I expected.*

Then there was a stretch of silence, where neither of them knew exactly what to say. Not uncomfortable, just there. He'd always liked getting to the point in a friendship when not every moment had to be filled with words. And counter to everything he knew about her, Carly didn't attempt to speak, either.

Adam looked out the window and toward the sky. "It's about that time," he said. He grabbed the eclipse glasses from his pocket and handed them to Carly.

He pointed to the shadow bands, which had begun in the clearing below them. "See those? There's this true mystery in science that only occurs during a solar eclipse—it's called shadow bands." He flared out his hands as if presenting the prize on a game show.

She said a very unconvincing, "Okay."

But he wanted her to get excited about this because it was undeniably cool. "Shadow bands are these gray ripples that flit over the ground. At first, they're barely visible, like seeing a glitch in your own shadow. But once the moon fully covers the sun, the lines become clear, impossible to ignore. And then when the sun begins to reemerge, the pattern the shadows make reverses, then grows fainter and fainter."

"Huh. Never noticed them before. What causes them?" Carly asked.

"No one really knows, but no other astronomer in history has had the opportunity to study a total solar eclipse the number of times I have. Not

that I'm an astronomer, but you know what I mean." Adam felt self-conscious as he adjusted the telescope lens. He *wasn't* an astronomer, not even close, so why did he think he had the right to play at being one? There wasn't much time to analyze, though. Adam gestured for Carly to look. "Let me know as soon as the sun is fully covered."

Carly lined her eye up with the telescope and watched the sky. Adam's gaze stayed fixed on his watch. He already knew that she'd tell him to start in three, two—

"Now," she said.

Adam let out a breath and leaned back into the chair. They had a few minutes left. He wasn't used to being around another person during this part. Should he . . . say something?

In very Carly fashion, she went ahead for him. "So, is this where you were when you saw the eclipse the first time?"

"No, I was at my house, with my dad. We watched it on the back porch." Adam swallowed down the recollection of packing up his suitcase, which had dulled but still hurt. "Where were you?"

Carly was unusually still and stared at a spot just beyond his shoulder. Eventually, she wiped at her cheek, and he realized she'd started to cry. "Ugh, sorry, it's so dusty up here."

She turned away, took off the eclipse glasses and handed them back. Then she wiped the lenses of her eyeglasses with a cloth she pulled from the pocket of her dress. A sniffle, and then she said, "I should go. My allergies are acting up. Are you okay without me?"

When she looked back at him—shoulders stiff and nose twitching another sniffle away—he wondered why that question, of all questions, had made her cry. But he didn't want to prod. The eclipse had happened after her father's funeral. Maybe the memory was still too raw. He understood that she needed space to process everything, and he'd give her that.

"Yeah, I'll be okay." He put the glasses on, and by the time he checked the sky and looked back, Carly was already making her way down the steps of the tree house.

Adam focused on the moon and the sun, his thoughts spinning around what had set Carly off, but also needing to know the time of the eclipse. He waited, and then the moment came when the moon moved. When he looked down at his watch, he saw the time.

He shot up and moved to the door of the tree house. Carly walked up the hill to where the road was, but he called out to her, “Carly!”

She turned, and he shouted, “Twenty seconds shorter! Four minutes and twelve seconds.”

Carly didn’t react the way he’d expected. Instead, she gave him a simple thumbs-up, then kept walking until he could no longer see her.

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Chapter 9

Carly

Carly rubbed her hands together as she made the walk back to town. The air had cooled, just as it did every loop around sunset. She usually prepared for this moment with a jacket, but she hadn't anticipated fleeing on foot from Adam.

Crying was Carly's *thing*, but even she'd been surprised by how easily it'd happened at the mention of the first loop. She supposed she hadn't expected the question to trigger the image of hurling a popcorn bucket across the movie theater lobby.

Carly skidded on a rogue pebble in the road and momentarily struggled to regain her balance. She took a sharp breath in, then released it as she steadied herself.

She was at the top of Main Street and considered doing what she did every night—which was making the most of the last few hours. She might tag along in the nightly conga line, or find the mom with the litter of puppies so she could cuddle with Apple, or hop onto the naked karaoke bus, strip down and belt out whatever was on tap.

Tonight, though, Carly didn't want to be around other people. Maybe Adam was rubbing off on her. She wished she had a tree house to escape to. Admittedly, when he'd first brought her inside that thing, she was 50/50 on the possibility that he might try to unalive her. She listened to podcasts and understood good things didn't come from following a man to a secluded location. But then she'd looked around and, well, the place was sort of

sweet, in a time capsule of a teenage nerd kind of way. Just by walking in, she'd almost immediately gotten a sense of who Adam had been growing up. In his own little world, chasing the stars.

She hadn't been like him, exactly, but Carly did get lost in stories. She'd spend hours on movie marathons of her favorite filmmakers: the Wachowskis, Nora Ephron and Karen McCullah/Kirsten Smith. And then there were the characters and situations that came to her—movie scenes she'd flesh out and ask her dad to read.

Nerd recognizes nerd. She'd seen a sliver of herself in that tree house. She'd also witnessed how embarrassed Adam was to have her in his space, the blush that spread across his cheeks as he looked everywhere but at her. She barely recognized the aloof jerk she'd painted him as a few loops prior. Suddenly, he'd become a self-conscious human, just like she could be.

So much had changed in a very little amount of time. Not only the relationship between her and Adam, but the loop itself.

Is it somehow connected? The thought flicked into her like a lit match, a flame that danced across her mind, but then quickly extinguished as another cool breeze blew through.

There was an abandoned pickup truck, which wasn't a tree house, but would have to do. Carly walked over and found a blanket in the bed of it. She stepped onto the large tire and hoisted herself in, bringing the blanket up and around her shoulders. She leaned back in the cab and stared at the sky.

She'd told Adam something had happened to change the loop—but what? Twenty seconds shorter. She snuggled deeper into the blanket and retraced the steps she and Adam had taken the day the loop changed. His fall on her, her busted back, being wheeled into town, the terrifying cows, the fake kiss . . .

She had to be logical. She had to channel Adam so that she could get out of Julian and respond to Marilyn fucking Montgomery's email. Carly was going to be a screenwriter one way or another.

So what would Adam do? He'd focus on what was in front of him. In Carly's case, the loop happened to change on the days when she'd spent time with Adam. And her good deed both of those days had been tied to him . . . Were her good deeds finally making a difference? Maybe Adam was like Ebenezer Scrooge, and her kindness melted his heart so much that the world around them was shifting as well?

If Carly was really going to help them get out of this loop, then maybe it was time for her to test a theory of her own. After all, she and Adam were a team, and she had to contribute something to their pursuit of getting the hell out of Julian. If she tried to tell Adam about her idea in advance, he'd just tell her she was being ridiculous.

So the next loop, she'd avoid Adam. If the eclipse time didn't change, then she could present her findings. *She* was a scientist, too, as it turned out.

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Chapter 10

Adam

Day 241

The loop restarted, which meant Adam's hands were on Shireen's shoulders. He used to love looking at the beauty mark on her nose, those thick lashes and the gold highlighter she'd brush across her forehead during her morning routine. But now being in the same room as her made his stomach twist in knots.

Instead of dramatically jerking out of Adam's reach and away from him—as she did in each reset—this time, she simply looked up, and her eye contact was so jarring that Adam took a step back.

He searched for hidden meaning and, to his surprise, Shireen said, "I'm sorry I reacted so harshly the last loop. I was just surprised. You know I don't do well with those."

Adam didn't do well with surprises, either. Like the surprise of her and Dean, for example, but he kept that thought to himself. "Okay," he opted for instead. "Thanks."

What else was he supposed to say? Still, this was maybe the nicest reset they'd had in a long time. Usually, she made quick work of leaving, but now Shireen was talking to him, like they'd been married for a decade and . . . she respected him.

"Adam, I . . ."

His heart began to race. What was she about to say? Was she going to tell him she'd made a mistake in running to Dean? Was Carly right? Had their fake kiss actually worked so well that Shireen wanted to have another chance?

Not that he'd take her back or anything, but still . . . he was anxious. Shireen's lips parted, which is exactly when a door slammed shut so loudly that they both looked toward the entrance.

"Carly?" he called out, but there was no response. Adam wordlessly moved around Shireen and approached the funeral service room, but when he stuck his head in, Carly wasn't in her usual chair.

"Did you do something to piss her off?" Shireen asked.

"No?" His statement came out as an anxious question, because he couldn't help but remember the tears at the tree house. His heart began to thump loudly in his ears. *Had* he done something? He'd asked her about the last day of the reset. Maybe his tone had been misunderstood?

"Good luck with that." Shireen raised her brows in a way he didn't altogether appreciate, like she was in on a joke at his expense. With a shrug, Shireen was out the door.

Adam stood alone in the hall. Carly had said they were in this together. She'd said they were partners. Maybe she'd just left on a quick snack run and would return with food . . .

He waited an hour. But Carly didn't return, send word via carrier pigeon, or so much as leave a note (he'd checked). She wasn't coming back, apparently. He'd obviously done something to offend her, as Shireen had said. And now Carly had changed her mind about working with him, so much so that she couldn't even stand to tell him to his face.

Adam's feet dragged as he walked to the hearse. Even though the loop had restarted as usual, everything felt just a bit more stagnant. He was absolutely thrown by the abrupt about-face Carly had pulled but, then again, what did he really know about her? She'd disappeared the day of her father's funeral, so why wouldn't she disappear any other time too?

Focus, he told himself. Just because Carly had bailed didn't mean his work was done. The eclipse had shortened twenty seconds. If the eclipse shortened by ten seconds every following loop, then they'd have about twenty-seven loops left.

Which meant there were only twenty-seven more opportunities to study the shadow bands. He still wasn't any closer to discovering *why* they

occurred in the first place. And what if they held the key to breaking the loop?

Rick and Carly weren't the only ones with ideas. Adam could have ideas, too, dammit. And maybe that was the thing—maybe, after the “show me, I want to believe,” spiel, she'd changed her mind. Maybe Carly simply didn't like what Adam was offering.

And, to be fair, he'd brought her to a tree house. They'd timed the eclipse. All things she could do by herself. The shadow bands, though; those were Adam's *thing*. And if Carly had decided to pursue theories on her own, or with Rick . . . Adam could do the same. He didn't *need* Carly to help with shadow bands.

He might need an actual scientist, though.

Adam found his scientist at the local playground. While there wasn't a child in sight, there was a Caltech-branded van in the parking lot. When Adam parked the hearse next to it, he looked out into the park to see the merry-go-round spinning, and a woman lying flat on her back as the world moved around her.

“Dr. Song?” Adam called out so as not to surprise her. He was completely aware that he was a tall guy and that women, in general, had been through enough.

She shot up, clocked him and said, “Hello?”

“I'm Adam. I'm . . . an amateur astronomer. Saw your Caltech van in the lot.” Indeed, he'd seen the van in previous loops. He'd also met Dr. Heather Song, Director of Astronomy at Caltech, in a prior loop, but he was certain she wouldn't remember him.

“Oh great, here we go,” she said, as if to prove his worst fears. She lay back down on the merry-go-round. “I don't respond well to pickup lines involving astronomy, for the record. Well, there was one time, in a moment of weakness, but that's not happening again.”

“I'm not going to hit on you.” He shoved his hands into his pockets, trying to appear as nonthreatening as possible.

“Excellent news.” Dr. Song gave him a tight look.

“I'm here to ask some questions about shadow bands.” He cringed as the words left his mouth because, really, would she even take him seriously?

She sat up on her elbows and considered this. “Shadow bands?”

Talking to Dr. Song was a longshot, he understood—she may have something, nothing, or everything to fill in the blanks for him. But he could take a page from Carly and see if this risk paid off. “Yeah, the library doesn’t have much research on them. And I read the theories online before the loop, but they’re kind of foggy to me. I saw the Caltech sticker, so I assume you were here to see the eclipse.”

“My students and I were, yes,” Dr. Song sighed. “I told them we should go to Arizona, but here we are. In hell.”

“I’m trying to figure out what causes the shadow bands,” he said.

“No one knows what causes them,” she said.

“Right.” Adam paused to take a breath, because this next part was the real leap of faith. “But since we’re stuck here, maybe we can try to figure it out?”

“Most people have given up trying to do . . . anything.” She squinted at him. “What got you into this?”

“I’ve always been into this,” he said. “I wanted to go to Caltech.”

“Ah, didn’t get in?” Dr. Song gave him a pitying look.

He felt a bit ridiculous when he responded with, “My parents didn’t want me to apply.”

“Like, a tuition thing?”

“They thought I wouldn’t be able to do much with an astronomy degree.” Adam’s face burned hot. He didn’t realize how childish this all sounded until he was in front of someone who’d dedicated their life to doing exactly what he’d dreamed of.

“I mean, I can think of worse career choices, but to each their own.” She shook her head in disbelief. “What do you do now?”

He hesitated, then cleared his throat. “I’m a funeral director.”

She let that sit for a beat, then asked, “Okay, amateur-astronomer-slash-undertaker, what do you think is causing the shadow bands?”

“Me?” Adam knew the question was for him, but hadn’t he come to her for the answers?

“I’m not talking to the swings.” She smiled away her irritation.

Unfortunately, he’d just lowered himself onto a swing and felt quite juvenile. Still, he had to soldier on. “Well, we know that they occur just before and after totality. They’ve been recorded at a few seconds, up to forty. Each loop they’ve been lasting thirty-seven seconds, before and after.”

“I hear you reciting the facts,” she said. “But how do those tie to the cause?”

“I think the theory that they’re caused by atmospheric turbulence is compelling, but it doesn’t totally account for why they move the way they do,” he hedged.

“An old colleague of mind called them *shadow snakes*.”

“I’ve seen that term, too.” Adam clasped onto the metal chains of the swing. “Only, sometimes the shadows do undulate like snakes, but other times they’re just a straight line.”

“And here?”

He moved his hand in a pattern as he said, “More like a shimmering wave. There’s a thin sliver of light the total eclipse gives us, where the moon doesn’t completely reach the top of the sun. The shadow bands, if you ask me, are coming from that light source.”

“I agree. Go on.” She crossed her arms and he was renewed.

“The theories state that in order to have a total solar eclipse, all of the conditions have to line up perfectly. The same goes with shadow bands—to have them, the conditions need to be just so. But what if, during the eclipse, something was slightly off? Something that created a bend in time itself?” He wondered if this was what going to Caltech would’ve been like—discussing ideas and getting feedback.

But here was where Adam lost her, apparently, because she cocked her head and asked, “You think the eclipse caused the loop?”

He was anxious now as he answered. “What if the shadow bands caused a perfect ripple in time that we’re now trapped in?”

“Sounds like a cool sci-fi book.”

The small ember of hope he’d had in his theory extinguished. He was grasping at straws by believing that in solving a scientific mystery, he could get them out of the loop. But she was right; this wasn’t a novel, this was the real world. And in the real world, he wasn’t an astronomer. He was the guy taking over his father’s business.

“Of course,” he said. “I just got excited because of the eclipse shortening.”

“Shortening?”

He swallowed down his apprehension. “I time the eclipse every day. For the past two days, it’s been ten seconds shorter, a full twenty seconds shorter now.”

“What did you say your name was?”

“Adam, Adam Rhodes.” He sounded way too eager, but he couldn’t help it. He’d given information that she seemed interested in. Maybe there was something to his theory after all.

“Amateur astronomer,” she said, then added, “I’m Heather, but call me Dr. Song.”

“Dr. Song,” he repeated.

“Let me know if you see more changes, all right?”

“I will,” he promised. And then he walked away, not feeling quite as dejected as he had a few moments earlier. Maybe he wasn’t such an amateur after all.

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Chapter 11

Carly

Day 242

When Carly restarted the loop and found herself in the funeral home, along with her normal reset feelings of numb acceptance, there was also excitement because, as she'd discovered, there had been no change in the eclipse. It had remained only twenty seconds shorter.

Which meant that maybe her absurd theory—that her good deeds for Adam were somehow causing the shift—was the right one. When she stood from her chair she had a little bounce to her step. She couldn't wait to reveal that *she* not *he* had figured out how to keep making the loop shorter. She was a bit manic about the whole thing, really.

"Oh, Adam," Carly singsonged as Shireen zipped past the funeral service room on her way to the exit.

Carly could feel the smug expression on her lips—and honestly, she'd earned it. She wasn't just an aspiring screenwriter stuck in this cow-filled abyss. She was an aspiring screenwriter who was going to break them out of the loop so she could finally hit Reply on the email from Marilyn Montgomery.

She practically skipped down the aisle of chairs, because she would finally be able to prove to Adam that she could bring just as much to the table.

Carly faltered a bit when she saw him, though. So tall. Such pointy cheekbones. Hair the color of fire. Her breath caught when he looked up and his brown eyes widened at the sight of her. “Hello,” she forced herself to say.

“Hello,” he replied, then cleared his throat. “Nice to, um, see you.”

She raised an eyebrow. “Oh . . .” She realized what was happening. “Yeah, sorry I didn’t say anything yesterday, but I had to test a theory, which was correct.”

“What theory?” He leveled her with a doubtful expression. “Ah, let me guess. You formed a covenant?”

Her mouth opened in surprise. Was Adam . . . mocking her? “Um, excuse me, if I could form a covenant I absolutely would. But that’s not what I was going to say, you coldhearted cow lover.”

“Can one be both coldhearted and a lover of cows? I think you’ve made a moooo-t point.” Adam bit his lip, as if suppressing a laugh.

To her amazement, she found his little pun charming. She eyed him, and he eyed her. Were they bantering with each other? What was . . . happening here?

When she didn’t immediately respond—too alarmed by Adam’s ability to crack jokes at her expense—he began to roll up the sleeves of his button-down shirt, and that was when she clocked the muscled forearm.

“So you didn’t start casting spells, then what’s this theory?” He interrupted her staring.

A little shiver coursed through and she worked fast to shake it off. “I realized that the eclipse had changed on the days when I did good deeds for you.”

He narrowed his eyes, and her body quickly cooled.

She tried again. “This last loop, I decided to test that by avoiding you all day. And as you probably noticed, the eclipse didn’t shorten. It stayed twenty seconds shorter.”

“Uh-huh,” he eventually said. “So you think we are closing the loop?”

“I think it’s more tied to my good deeds. I always had this hope that if I did enough of them, I’d get out of here. But on the days when I did nice things for *you*, all of a sudden the eclipse shortened. Maybe that’s because you’re, like, usually so rude, so it gives my good deeds *extra* powers? So, yes, there’s something going on here.” She gestured to the space between them, and while she hadn’t meant to suggest that there was something

between them in the relationship sense, she realized she may have misspoken. “Do you have a better idea?”

A smirk ghosted across his lips. “Yes, I think I do. If we want to speed up the process, we need to look more closely at the shadow bands.”

She crossed her arms. “You know, I read that Peter Pan’s shadow is a metaphor for the part of himself that he’s lost. Are you feeling lost, Adam?”

Carly enjoyed the exasperated look Adam gave her.

“It’s not as weird as you’re making it sound,” he said. “I just think it’s interesting that this wildly unique scientific phenomenon happens at the same time we find ourselves in a time loop. It’s either connected, or the strangest coincidence I’ve ever heard of.”

But then Carly’s stomach loudly grumbled. She picked up a mint from the tin in the lobby, unwrapped it and popped it into her mouth. “Sorry, I always reset on the hungry side. This girl needs cheese. Mind if we go eat?”

Carly eagerly dipped her chicken tinga taco into a cup of queso as she handed a tinfoil-wrapped beef taco to Adam. She was grateful that Julian had a well-stocked taqueria that was on par with the delicious ones she’d grown up with in LA. But Adam stared at his like she’d just handed him a bomb and he had no idea how to defuse it. Everything Adam did seemed to involve hesitation—following Carly, eating his food.

But if Adam didn’t like tacos—unfathomable, except that Adam was not like most people—then he didn’t have to eat them. He could walk across the street to Moms and get pie, and maybe snag one with cheese on top for her.

“I realize we have competing theories, but the same goal of getting out,” Adam said as he gently unwrapped his lunch. “As long as we’re willing to help each other, it still makes sense to work as a team.”

“Absolutely.” Carly wiped her mouth with a napkin.

Then Adam pulled a plain flour tortilla out of the to-go bag, wrapped it *around* the taco, and created a taco-burrito monstrosity, which he then took a bite of.

“Oh my God, what are you doing?” she practically yelled at him.

“I don’t like it when fillings spill out of the sides. This keeps them nice and neat.” He took another bite and her mouth fell open in shock.

She couldn’t tell if his move was genius or unholy, but then Adam cleared his throat. The guttural, animalistic noise had the most bizarre effect

on her—goose bumps. *Seriously?* Goose bumps because the man cleared his throat?

Adam glared in response. To her delight, he had a bit of guacamole on his chin, which erased all those goose bumps. She could either let him go about the day looking like a human tortilla chip, or she could help him out. Without much thought, she picked the glob of guacamole off with her fingers. A blush spread across his cheeks, which she rather enjoyed.

“My good deed for the day, making sure you don’t humiliate yourself,” Carly said. “And now we’ll see if that eclipse shortens again.”

“Thanks,” Adam grudgingly replied. “What you’re proposing is . . . it’s not based in science.”

“But not everything can be explained by science, like the shadow bands,” Carly pointed out.

“They *will* be explained by science once I collect more evidence.” Adam gathered up their trash into the paper bag.

“Science is real,” Carly clarified, not wanting him to think she was being dismissive. “But life has plenty of magical moments, too, and that doesn’t make them any less real. My dad always said that coyotes reminded him of my mom. Whenever he saw one, he felt like it was a sign from her. And on my birthday every year we always saw one, without fail, in our front yard.”

Adam nodded, and she worried she’d revealed too much. What if he asked more about her mom? Carly didn’t want to start the day with tears, so she sputtered out, “As an optimist, I choose to believe that the eclipse shortening is a good thing, and that my good deeds have something to do with that.” She took a tortilla chip from the bag and filled the silence with her loud crunching.

“And as someone who believes in facts over nonsense, I’ll be cautiously optimistic but also agnostic until we have more data.” He crumpled her discarded wrapper into a ball.

The clip-clop of horse hooves caught Carly’s attention, and she saw Goldie in a red string bikini coming down the street. “Ten hours, people!”

“Ten hours left,” Adam said. “So three more until the eclipse and the shadow bands.”

“We could make a list of more theories as to why we’re still in the time loop. Like, maybe we’re all being punished for something.” Carly had held this fear for a long time. Maybe she was stuck here for being such a shitty daughter.

“I find it hard to believe that every single person in Julian is so evil that they’re now trapped.” He gave her one of those withering looks he was so damn good at, but she was part of this team, and she wasn’t about to let him shut her down.

“Look, it took two hundred forty loops for the eclipse to shorten, and this last loop it didn’t change at all. I don’t know about you, but I don’t want to have to wait another two hundred forty times to see change again.” Carly stood as she spoke, not making eye contact with Adam in case he melted her resolve. “I want us to do everything we can to end this thing.”

Adam seemed to actually consider this—a win, if Carly ever saw one—when a man with thick, dark hair, and the kind of shoulders you could melt into called out, “Join us, sister.” He wore a white linen shirt and a long beaded necklace that swayed as he walked over and handed her a heavy rock before turning back to his group.

“Ugh, the Chaos Club. Again. Better I have this than them,” Carly said and held the rock to her chest. Something about this Julian clique made her particularly uneasy. How many times could you smash windows and still go back for more? Carly glanced to where the Jesus-esque leader had gone and saw a teenager approaching her dad’s movie theater. The theater was a place she always tried to avoid, but there he was—heading straight for it.

“My turn!” he shouted.

She noticed the heavy gray rock in his fist.

Without thinking, Carly started to run toward the teenager. She knew what this kid’s plans were, and the idea of him actively firing a rock at the thing her dad had worked so hard to build was impossible. “Stop!” she shouted.

But it was too late. The boy’s hand had catapulted the rock, and it sailed through the air toward the glass doors. As it did, Carly screamed out “No!” so loudly that she barely heard the glass shatter.

She stopped moving and stood in front of the open-mouthed hole that revealed the theater lobby. She didn’t know she was shaking until Adam’s steady hand landed on her shoulder and he draped his jacket around her. Her ears buzzed with a kind of white noise from the shock of what had just happened. Even the world seemed to dim.

“Adam . . .” she said through a shaky breath.

“Let me get you out of here. Where’s your dad’s place?”

He meant her dad's apartment, but her gaze instinctively went to the front of the theater. *This* was her dad's place, and someone had just smashed in one of the glass doors. Anyone could walk in and completely destroy it. She couldn't let that happen.

Carly reached into the pocket of her dress and felt the brass top of the key. She knew that in a few hours the world would reset. The door would be back as it always was—closed and protecting the theater. But right now, she wanted to do the thing she hadn't been able to when her dad was alive: stand by what he'd built.

She moved toward the entrance, carefully sidestepped the broken glass and slipped inside the theater. She hadn't returned to this space with the maroon carpet and hanging stars since the day the loop started. Instead of the grief she'd felt the first time she'd come, there was a kind of release of tension from her shoulders. She could watch over the theater, and if her dad was somewhere, he'd know that she cared enough to do this for him.

The crunch of glass caused her to turn as Adam pushed the door open and cautiously came in. His brows creased at the mess before he looked up at her.

She didn't know Adam well but understood by his expression that he wanted to leave. She, however, had a mission. So she stalked off to the snack counter, where a metal chair with an upholstered seat waited. She picked the chair up and brought it directly in front of the door. Then she sat and crossed her arms. She could feel Adam watching, but she was too afraid to meet his gaze.

"Carly . . ." he started to say. "What are we doing?"

"We are not doing anything, but *I* am going to keep watch, in case they come back," she huffed out. "If they do, I'll barricade the door so they can't come in."

"Barricade?" he asked. "With what? I doubt your arm span would even reach both ends of the door frame."

For some reason, Adam noticing her body made her cheeks burn.

"This will all reset in the morning," he added.

But this didn't concern Adam. This was between her and Bruce. She'd let him down once, and she'd never make that mistake again. "I can't let them ruin my dad's place," she simply said.

She waited for Adam to leave and retreat to his tree house. Instead, Adam found a metal chair and dragged it next to hers.

They sat in silence. Carly kept her eyes trained on the door and watched as bonfires burned in the middle of the street, and a stereo blasted music so loudly that the walls shook.

"I think that's your car on fire." She pointed out the window toward the hearse, now engulfed in flames.

"Huh." He cocked his head. "There is something kind of mesmerizing about fire."

"Look at you, a little pyro." She gave him a side smile, and he easily smiled back.

An alarm on Adam's watch sounded and he pressed a button to silence it. "The eclipse," he said. Then he reached out and wrapped his hand around hers. He was warm, and the gentle pressure of his fingers made Carly's breath catch. She stared at their hands and, as she did, a little flutter erupted across her chest.

Oh, God fucking dammit, she was attracted to Adam.

"Will you be okay if I go time it?" He swallowed, and she was suddenly very attracted to throats. His throat, to be specific.

Carly nodded, more at his throat than at him. He took his hand from hers, and as he stood, she reached for him, just enough to make it all a bit pathetic.

He stepped through the broken door and walked into the street. She watched from the safety of her chair. He checked his watch, and she found that was a very cute thing to do. He slipped on his eclipse glasses and looked up towards the sky, and she couldn't help noticing how tall and broad he was. She should've stood next to him, but she was really and truly dumbfounded by this new feeling of attraction. How had her body decided *this* was the guy?

She distinctly remembered one loop where he'd sneezed so loud as she was leaving that she'd stubbed her toe. That wasn't attractive. Adam *wasn't* attractive. And yet, he absolutely fucking was, and she'd do anything to feel the long firm length of his body pressed up to hers.

When he came back in, he rubbed the spot on the bridge of his nose where the eclipse glasses had left an indent. And then he cleared his throat in the weird growly way that gave Carly goose bumps. Ugh, even his attractiveness was infuriating.

"Aren't you going to ask if it shortened?" he asked.

And the truth was she couldn't take one more thing. She was drained. She was sort of turned on. The idea of hearing her theory was *wrong* wasn't something she was ready to face.

"Tell me later." She angled herself just slightly away in an effort to avoid her feelings.

Adam sat next to her again, put his elbows on his knees and leaned toward her. His warm and buttery scent hit her as he said, "You know, I haven't seen a movie in a long time. I could really use a break from all this." He gestured his hand around, and she felt that sentiment very deeply. She hadn't been to a movie in almost a year. Wouldn't it be nice to sit in the leather seats with junk food and just distract herself for a bit? A dark theater would mean she wouldn't have to look at Adam, either, which, in light of her new preposterous feelings, might be a good thing.

"Do you think we could watch one?" he asked.

Carly knew her way around a projector. In high school, she'd worked weekends at the Burbank 16. So when she walked into the back storage room, she quickly found alphabetized and labeled film canisters stacked on neat shelves. Bruce's handwriting was uneven and hurried, but she could read the words.

She wanted something fun to take them out of the loop, if only for two hours. But Adam said, "I found this in a box labeled 'Carly's movies.'" He held the can up.

The Shield Force was a buddy cop film set in Chicago and starring her ultimate Hollywood heartthrob.

"Oh my God." The space was small, and Carly had to press herself against Adam's back to reach the box he'd found. She was momentarily stunned by his unexpectedly broad shoulders, which caused her to rapidly blink. She bit her lip in an attempt to refocus, then pulled the box off the shelf. Inside were at least a dozen of some of Carly's favorite films—the ones that had made her want to be a screenwriter. "Almost all of these star the greatest actor of all time, Rhys Montrose," Carly said with a toothy grin. "But in *The Shield Force* he takes his shirt off in one very pivotal helicopter sequence."

Adam let out a little huff of acknowledgment. "Here I thought you cared about films with a capital *F*."

Is Adam . . . jealous? No, that was a silly thought. He was just being his usual Adam self and found a new way to insult her.

Carly could insult right back, though. “The human body *is* cinema, Adam. Maybe you’re just too uncomfortable in your own masculinity to acknowledge the majesty of the male form.”

“Not that it’s any of your business, but I’m bisexual. I’ve been with men. Rhys wouldn’t be my celebrity crush, though.”

“You’ve . . .” It’s not that Carly was shocked that Adam was bisexual, necessarily, but hadn’t he been with Shireen forever? “When?”

“High school. Junior Year. Casey Todaro. He was a nice guy.”

“Oh.” Carly tried to hide her shock.

“But maybe *The Shield Force* will prove me wrong about Rhys,” Adam said.

As they returned to the snack counter in search of gummy bears and popcorn, the whole situation felt wildly normal, as opposed to the terrifying reality of every loop. They were just talking about pop culture, grabbing food and getting ready to relax with a movie.

Why hadn’t Carly thought to come here sooner? The change of pace was a balm.

In the theater, they sat in the middle row, and Adam’s elbow landed on the armrest between them. Their bodies touched, but he didn’t pull away, and she didn’t, either. They were both comfortable, so what was the harm? Other than the fact that she could feel the heat of his skin through his shirt.

“Okay, let’s say your theory is correct,” Adam said as the title cards rolled onscreen. “That a person has created some change in our universe. And we are somehow those people.”

“Thank you, yes.” Carly shoved a handful of popcorn into her mouth.

“So if we stopped spending time together, no further changes would occur. Correct?” He grabbed the gummy bears and tore the package open.

“Yes,” she answered hesitantly. “That’s what I tested the last loop.”

“Let’s run a more proper control experiment, then.”

She didn’t love his expression, which looked like he was about to say *checkmate*. “So what are you . . . What are you saying?” she asked.

“Let’s isolate for two additional days.” Adam leaned a bit closer and she was distracted by a vein in his forearm, but tried to listen as he said, “No talking. Just go back to how we were before. We’ll study the eclipse independently and if it keeps decreasing, then your theory is incorrect.”

“But if it doesn’t decrease, then I get a Pulitzer?” She smiled.

“We’ll see.” He tossed a gummy bear into his mouth and chewed. “Do you want to know if the eclipse was shorter today?”

“No.” Carly just wasn’t ready for the bubble of this moment to pop yet. “So, when do we isolate?”

“Tomorrow.”

“Okay.” She could avoid Adam, she thought as she chewed her popcorn. She’d done it over two hundred times before. Her leg began to bounce in her seat, and she smoothed her hand over her thigh to still herself. She wished she had her fidget cube, or her stress ball to squeeze. Instead, she squeezed the top of her knee.

Her leg stilled. She was ready to be absorbed by the film, just as her dad would’ve wanted. That brief thought of Bruce triggered the realization that she was finally getting to watch a movie in her dad’s theater, but he wasn’t there. He never would be again. Carly’s cheeks were wet with tears before she realized what was happening. Adam’s arm coiled around her shoulder and he brought her into his chest. He smoothed his palm down her back in slow, gentle swipes until her body calmed.

At some point, Carly’s thoughts strayed from her dad to Adam, who wasn’t as terrible of a person as she’d thought. Here he was, comforting her, when he really didn’t need to. He wasn’t asking *why* she was crying. He wasn’t trying to force her to talk about her feelings. He was just letting her completely soak his shirt with tears.

She was suddenly very tired. When she blinked, her lids nearly refused to open, and it was with some effort that she fluttered them. Maybe she’d fall asleep in this chair. Her dad had picked comfy ones, hadn’t he? Her dad. Her dad . . . She buried her face into Adam’s shirt. He smoothed his palm down her back again. And eventually, she drifted off.

Chapter 12

Adam

Day 243

Adam restarted the loop in his office, the same as he always did. Shireen was inches from him, but all he could think about was Carly.

She'd fallen asleep pressed up against him, and he'd been too scared to wake her. So he just held her through the action movie and the gratuitous shirtless scene. (He had to admit she was right; Rhys was handsome.) Adam felt her chest rise and fall in slow, easy breaths, and as the credits rolled, he stayed as still as possible so as not to disturb her.

He found he didn't mind, because she'd been so upset that she'd cried herself to sleep, something she obviously needed. But the other part was that peppermint smell. He *liked* breathing it in, soothed by the scent.

He checked his watch before closing his eyes and, seeing as they only had a few minutes left, decided to tell Carly something. "The eclipse was another ten seconds shorter," he spoke in a whisper, so as not to wake her. "Don't gloat about it too much, though." She stirred at the last part, then tucked herself in closer to him. His fingertips instinctively squeezed her in tight to his chest. He gazed down at her in his arms and took in a sharp breath as he realized he *like*-liked Carly. More than as friends, or whatever they were purporting to be. Eventually, his eyes closed, and the last image he saw was her pressed safely into him.

Then he found himself reset, as was always the case.

“Say hello to your girlfriend for me.” Shireen’s voice was tinged with a bitterness Adam was all too familiar with—she was jealous.

Shireen waited for Adam to respond, but he couldn’t. His thoughts were still tied to Carly and the feel of her pressed against him. Shireen turned and walked out the office door in a huff. Adam almost called out, *She’s not my girlfriend*, but what was the point? He didn’t have to comfort Shireen. She had Dean for that.

Adam rubbed a hand across his forehead and was suddenly aware of his wedding band. He wiggled it off and held it in his palm. He was truly very tired of having versions of the same conversations with Shireen. Wouldn’t it be nice to start a day in a mood that wasn’t despair?

For a brief moment, he *had* started this loop with hope, and all from his night with Carly.

Carly. He wouldn’t be able to see her for the next two days. They’d actively avoid each other, per his mandate. His feelings for her had shifted, though, so he wasn’t even looking forward to the alone time. No, he was bummed out. He wanted to walk into the hall and crack a joke about how she’d fallen asleep before Rhys had so much as taken his shirt off. Maybe they didn’t need to start the isolation today.

Adam placed the wedding ring on his desk, dashed into the hall and headed for the funeral service room. But when he looked in, Carly was already gone. She must’ve snuck out before Shireen, as he hadn’t so much as heard the thud of her combat boots. He leaned against the door frame and let out a breath.

Okay. This was happening. He had to spend two loops without her, and then they’d see if the experiment paid off. A few loops ago, the idea of a break from Carly would be welcomed, but Adam didn’t feel relief. He felt a bit lost, really.

Adam’s shoulders sagged as he parked the car in front of his parents’ house and walked up the path to the front door. What was Carly getting up to without him?

The door opened before Adam had time to knock.

“Honey, he’s home!” Bill called out as he waved Adam inside. “I told you he’d be back.” Then to Adam, “Your mother thought we’d chased you off by telling you to get a life. She wanted to call the police, but I reminded

her there are no police, and I didn't want to spend the day scouring the town for you, no offense."

"Some taken." Adam made an effort to straighten his shoulders as he stepped through the door. His parents had already been worried about him, and he didn't want to give them more reasons to ask questions.

When Sheila spied Adam, she immediately met him with a tight hug. "Where were you the last few loops?"

"With a friend," he quickly said, only realizing his fatal error when his mom froze.

"A friend?" She looked at his dad. "Which friend?"

Ugh, she was going to make this a whole *thing*. "You don't know her."

Adam pinched his eyes closed. Why'd he say *her* on top of *friend*? When he opened his eyes, Sheila tried to hide the O shape her mouth had formed. His dad, on the other hand, tightened his lips and gave Adam a *You've really done it this time*, kind of look.

"What's *her* name?" Sheila grabbed his elbow and guided him toward the kitchen.

Adam busied himself by opening the fridge and taking out the half-eaten coffee cake that was always waiting. Stress eating; he could do that just as much as anyone. "Carly," he eventually said.

Sheila once again turned to Bill, who only offered a shrug. Sheila rolled her eyes and refocused on Adam. "She sounds nice."

Adam squinted at her. "I haven't told you anything about her. For all you know, she's a terrible person. Why is she *nice*?"

"If she puts up with your bad attitude, she's nice," his dad joked.

"It must be genetic," Adam joked back. He cut into the cake and heaved a slice onto a plate, then grabbed a fork from the drawer.

"Are you taking that to meet—what's her name again?" Sheila asked.

There was hope in her eyes. The same hope he'd had the past few loops—the kind of expression that only came from being excited about change. Much of his life, he'd tried to earn a proud look from his parents. He just hadn't expected to see one because he'd met someone new.

Adam reluctantly replied, "I'm not seeing her today."

"Oh." Sheila gave Bill a disappointed look, and Adam's jaw tensed.

"I wanted to come here and check in with you two," he fired off. He stuck his fork into the edge of the cake and through a mouthful said, "I'll see her again soon. Maybe I can bring her here."

Well, that was absolutely something he didn't have to do. If he was going to keep on this people-pleasing train, why not just offer to marry her in the backyard if that would make them happy?

His mom visibly brightened. "We should celebrate you being home, then. Bill, you make some homemade pasta, and Adam, we can do a bonfire with s'mores?"

Adam didn't consider himself an outdoorsy type necessarily, but he knew how to build a fire. His mother had taught him the basics. She'd also built the tree house, taught him how to change a flat tire and taken him camping in Yellowstone for his twelfth birthday. So when he looked at her, he could only say, "Sure, I'll get it set up."

The eclipse wasn't for a few hours, so Adam collected sticks, big branches and dry leaves that would provide kindling. He'd started the pile about two hundred feet from the back door of his parents' house, past the patio and in a clearing where the smoke would have room to billow up and not touch nearby trees. When the pile reached up to his chest, he stretched his back and marveled at what he'd built.

"Your mom usually saves bonfires for the New Year." Bill came down the patio steps toward Adam, one hand on the railing and the other wrapped around a coffee mug. He moved carefully, and Adam was reminded of the fact that he was getting older—not in the time loop, but in general. He'd noticed small markers of his dad's age on occasion—more forgetfulness, a slower pace to his movements—but it was still jarring. Maybe if there was one silver lining to being stuck, it was that his parents ages were, too. "A new year can mean new goals. New intentions to set," Bill added.

For all of Adam's logic, his dad could be whimsical, like the hidden squirrel art Carly had noticed on the walls of Rhodes Funeral Home.

"Maybe it's time you had a new start and leave some of the past behind." Bill's honey eyes, the same ones Adam had, were surrounded by the crinkles of age. "Shireen might be a good one to say goodbye to."

"Yeah, I kind of got that suggestion without you having to spell it out," Adam chimed back. He'd never be able to fully say goodbye to Shireen, not when he had to see her every single loop. But he also knew his dad wasn't happy with this part of Adam's life—his failed marriage—and wanted him to move on. Bill had never been cheated on, though, never watched his own life dissolve in front of his eyes. What right did he have to dictate how Adam navigated these things?

“Think about it,” Bill simply said. Then he clapped a hand on Adam’s shoulder and made his way up the steps to the house.

His mom wanted Adam to move on. His dad wanted that, too, apparently. But what really didn’t make sense to Adam was move on to *what*? Adam had spent his adulthood trying to build a life—just as they had. He’d found and married Shireen, they’d been on their way to buying a home, he’d studied mortuary science in college all so he could take over the family business and keep his dad’s legacy alive.

He’d done everything he was supposed to, but still they wanted more. And there it was, the thing Adam kept dancing around but knew in his gut: All of his decisions had been based around the basic need to make his parents happy. It wasn’t Shireen holding him back; it was his own innate fear of disappointing everyone around him.

In that moment, Adam thought of Carly. She was his opposite in this respect. She’d gone after her dream of writing for a living and taken a risk he never could. While she had no fear, Adam still needed to let go of his. He hoped that even though the loop would reset his world, it wouldn’t undo the hope he had to change. That was a hope that Carly had unexpectedly given him.

Adam’s entire body was heavy from the discussion with his dad. Bill wasn’t an emotionally revealing man, but he had forced Adam to examine himself.

When the eclipse came, Adam timed it from the yard. Unlike the day before, it stayed at 4:02—no change.

Carly’s theory—however nonsensical—had for now been proven right. Maybe a coincidence, or maybe she was on to something. Adam wasn’t banking on her theory, though, and he was certain the time would shift on the next loop.

So when he reset in the funeral home, he planned to more or less count down the hours until the eclipse. Carly snuck out before they could see each other again, and Adam went back to his parents’ house. He timed the eclipse from the tree house and waited for the revelation that everything was *not* the result of their interactions.

Imagine his utter shock, then, when he checked his watch and saw that for the second loop in a row, there had been absolutely no change.

Chapter 13

Carly

Day 245

Carly reset in the funeral home, which would've been just like any other reset, except for the fact that she started this one off smug.

So smug that she felt entitled to dictate that she and Adam go eat a fancy, celebratory lunch in her honor. Yeah, that was right. She—the underdog in the plot of her own movie—had come up with a theory that, lo and behold, had legs. Killer legs, if she could say so. Not the rocket scientist guy, but the gal who had barely squeaked by most science classes with a passing grade.

If Carly had been a big drinker, she'd have opened champagne or a good whiskey, but she liked cheese. And this was an occasion that called for a visit to Le Petit Coeur, a small French bistro just off Main Street with a blue-and-white motif.

Carly held a cheese croissant at eye level and said, “Cheers to me being right.” She waited for Adam to clink his chocolate croissant to hers, but he just took a big bite instead. She shrugged and bit into the layered bread, letting the melted cheese remind her what winning felt like.

It felt *fantastic*, for the record.

The timer stopped at 4:02 for the previous two loops, which meant her theory was correct. Something about them being together had changed the eclipse.

Carly smiled through her chew. “I keep waiting for you to congratulate me,” she said. “But it’s okay. The pastry is a close second.”

She watched, waiting for acknowledgment, but Adam was doing his far-off gaze thing. She snapped her fingers and he gave her a bewildered look. God, he was cute.

“The thing is,” Adam said, “we don’t know if you’re right yet, because we have to see if there’s a change in the eclipse *today* now that we’re back together.”

She rolled her eyes. “Okay, Adam, you’re a sore loser.”

Adam sipped his bottled water and leaned back in his chair. Admittedly, as she took in the way his lean muscles popped under his shirt, he didn’t *look* like a sore loser. He looked attractive. She readjusted her glasses, as if that would fix her problem of finding his face, throat and forearms handsome.

“We still have evidence to collect,” he said.

“Okay, well, it’s like a few more hours until the eclipse, and there are only so many cheese sandwiches I can eat.” Then she got a brilliant idea. “Unless that’s how you want to spend the time—eating cheese sandwiches—like a competition? In which case I *think* I could probably eat two to three sandwiches per hour without exploding.”

Adam’s mouth opened, then closed. Carly more than enjoyed the moments where she rendered him speechless, this one included.

But eventually, he said, “You haven’t asked about my theory. For all you know, I’m right, too.”

Carly wiped her mouth with a napkin, leaned forward, elbows on the table, and said, “Are you right, then?”

“I’m making strides.” He crossed his arms. “You have your . . . Together Theory, let’s call it.”

“I prefer ‘Carly’s Theory Is the Correct Theory’ Theory, but go on.” She managed to get a tight smile from him with that one.

“Rick has his Pop the Bubble Theory. I have the shadow bands, but I also think it’s worth timing things like the sunset, the length of the day, maybe even the shooting star that crosses the sky every night. What if we’re so focused on the eclipse that we miss a bigger, more telling change?”

Carly found herself agreeing with Adam. What if there was more to discover? What if the eclipse ended up being a dead end, but there was something else shifting at a faster rate?

“There’s a shooting star?” Carly asked. “Never seen one.”

“Yes. Every night at 11:23. I’ll show you sometime.”

He actually sounded excited about that last bit, which was sort of cute. The guy had really grown on her. “All right, so today we will time all of the things, and when the eclipse shortens—because I’m definitely right—then we can keep pursuing my theory,” she said.

“I agree with most of what you’re saying,” Adam admitted. “But still, we need to follow the evidence.”

Unfortunately, the evidence was pointing to the fact that she found him cuter when he spoke in science. Carly shoved the rest of the croissant into her mouth to stop her thoughts.

“Want to take a drive?” Adam asked.

As Adam drove them up a winding path into the mountains, Carly kept one hand on the door handle to steady herself. Whatever was going on between them was confusing at best, and the first sign of early onset dementia, at worst.

This was a man she’d had murderous thoughts about. There was one particularly fulfilling fantasy that involved him being taken out with a wrecking ball. But now? As they breezed past tall pine trees and endless stretches of wooded mountainside, she sat next to him and felt like she was exactly where she was meant to be.

What the hell was wrong with her? Was she such a broken human that the only person she found attractive was someone who’d gone out of his way to make her feel inferior on more than one occasion?

“I have a problem,” she told herself.

“What problem?” Adam asked.

“Oh my God, did I say that out loud?” She covered her mouth with her hands. Great, so on top of having a crush, she was now talking to herself, but out loud and in front of him.

Oh fuck, a crush? Carly checked to make sure she hadn’t said that one out loud, too, but Adam hadn’t reacted. Shit. She had a crush on Adam. It’s not just that she found him hot—no, she liked this guy. She had *feelings*, emphasis on the desire to feel him up.

“You okay?” he tried again.

“No,” she said without thinking. Then winced, but added, “Hungry.”

“The place we’re going has snacks,” he said.

“Hmmm . . .” They drove past a big blue sign for the Julian Planetarium. “Where could the astronomer be taking me? Maybe to a gas station so we can raid the candy section? An elementary school cafeteria? An abandoned church so we can eat the unblessed wafers?”

“You are rather strange,” Adam said as he pulled into the empty parking lot.

The planetarium had a big round dome in the middle, and floor-to-ceiling glass windows. There were lights on inside, but Carly didn’t see evidence of any people.

“You *really* like stargazing,” she said as she got out of the car.

“I used to volunteer here occasionally,” he said by way of explanation. They walked toward the entrance door.

Which is when Carly saw the opportunity for a good deed. She dashed ahead, reached for the door handle and pulled it open with a flourish. “Look at me, holding the door open for you, because I’m a kind person and because I need to prove my theory.”

“I recognize you’re being a bit sarcastic, but it does feel nice to have the door held open.” Adam gave a tight smile as he breezed through, then turned back to tell her, “Usually the other way around, considering my height and gender norms.”

“Call me Saint Carly, because I just made your day.” She walked inside the wide atrium where the tiled floor was covered in painted stars, and the glass ceiling opened up to the sky above them. “Well, this is cool.”

“Perhaps best of all, there are no cows here.” Adam led her across the floor and toward the café, which was stocked with grab-and-go lunch boxes, packaged cookies and a cooler of cold drinks. Carly grabbed the cheese plate, and Adam took an oatmeal raisin cookie.

“You understand that you chose the grandma of cookies, right?” She pulled out a metal chair and took a seat at a bistro table. “When presented with plenty of other, more reasonable options, you made the decision to go for oatmeal and raisins?”

“And you understand that cheese comes from cows?” He noisily unwrapped the cookie from the plastic packaging.

“Not always.” Carly popped a cheese cube into her mouth. “You’re annoying, by the way.”

“I’m starting to think my destiny on this earth is specifically to annoy you.” Adam took a bite of the cookie and chewed. When she’d finished her snack, he said, “Come with me.”

Carly followed Adam down the cavernous hall to an observation deck surrounded by windows that looked out onto the town below. The sun and moon were about to make contact. They were at the top of the mountain with the whole of Julian ahead of them, but Carly was too aware of Adam next to her to notice.

“Here.” He handed her eclipse glasses and, as she took them, the closeness of his fingertips sent a wave of heat through her.

“Thanks.” Her voice came out breathy, and she cleared her throat. “What about the shadow bands?”

“We can’t see them from up here, unfortunately, but we can prioritize them tomorrow.” Adam looked from the eclipse to his watch. “Okay, three, two and one. Let’s see if your Carly Is Correct Theory is, in fact, correct.”

She tipped an imaginary top hat and he seemed to suppress a smile.

They could’ve continued to watch in silence, but she wasn’t good at those. So to distract herself, Carly asked, “What have you told your parents about all this? Aren’t you usually with them?”

“They know about you,” he hedged. “I’m not good at lying. They don’t know about the experiments, just that I’m hanging out with someone new.”

“Someone new . . .” She wasn’t new, though, just rediscovered, she supposed.

“They’re intense,” he said. “I don’t really have close friends. Dean was my best friend, but if my mom and dad met you, they’d want you to come over for dinner. They’d ask you every detail about your life. They’d try and make you part of the family, the way they did with Dean. It’s never simple with them.”

She gaped at him. “Adam, you mean to tell me that all I have to do to get a home-cooked meal is meet your parents, and you denied me that?”

He gave her a surprised look, but she realized that Adam was a guy who seemed to take the small things for granted. Where he saw his parents as a burden, Carly would give anything to still have even just one of hers around. She’d lost her mom at a young age, and now her dad. From what she could tell, these were people who cared for him, and not everyone got to have that. As such, she had no problem being honest.

“All my life I’ve dreamed of having a family where we got to eat dinners together. The way movies tell you families are supposed to be,” she said. “The closest I got was if I visited my dad on set and we both ate from the craft services catering at the same time. What you have? That’s special. I wish I’d been able to have that with my dad.”

She wasn’t trying to make him feel bad, necessarily, but maybe she was.

“Tell me about your dad,” Adam said gently.

Tell me about your dad was a simple request. She’d known the guy her whole life, until recently. He’d raised her. She should be able to talk about him.

But the truth was she didn’t know where to begin. She knew his daily routine: wake at seven, eat oatmeal and drink black coffee, open the movie theater at noon, close at 10 p.m., heat up a frozen meal for dinner, watch an episode of *Jeopardy* before bed. She knew he used a 2-in-1 shampoo. Knew that he liked to weed his garden every Saturday. She knew his favorite kind of beef jerky. She could remember the feel of his hugs, and how his scratchy chin rested on the top of her head. She could hear his voice mail greeting in her head, the hesitant way he said, *If you’re calling for Bruce, leave me a message*, like he hadn’t been sure he was working the recording correctly. She missed hearing his voice.

But those were all super-specific sense memories that kept him alive to Carly. So Adam’s *tell me about your dad* question wasn’t as simple as he might have thought.

“Look, the eclipse.” Carly pointed out the window and hoped this would be a smooth transition away from talking about herself.

“Not quite yet,” Adam said. And she wasn’t sure if he meant the eclipse timing, but then he continued with, “Three, two and one.”

Adam lingered on his watch.

“Well?” she nervously asked.

“Four minutes, two seconds.” He licked his lips and locked eyes with hers. “No change.”

“No change?” Carly stared at him.

He stared back. And as she studied him, something in her gut told her not to give up on this wild theory of hers. But now that the evidence was stacking against her favor, how would she convince Adam?

Chapter 14

Adam

Day 246

Adam reset in the office. Shireen pulled away from him. They exchanged a resigned look, and then she left the room. Business as usual, really.

Except today would be Adam's chance to shine. He felt bad for Carly, seeing as the evidence hadn't favored her wild idea. But still, how would the two of them cause a shift in time and space? Her notion had no logic. His theory that the shadow bands had caused a perfect ripple in time and trapped them all still had potential. Heck, depending on the data he collected throughout the day, there might even be a new option to consider.

As such, Adam walked out of the office and into the hallway with vigor. Today would be a fact-seeking mission, and he knew just the place to start.

"Oh, Carly." He singsonged her name. "I have an idea of how to pursue the 'Adam Knows Best' Theory. That's a working title, of course. Open to suggestions," he said.

Carly cautiously walked out of the funeral service room and into the hallway. She stood to face him, almost squarely. Her fists balled at her sides. "You can do this, Carly," she said to herself.

He watched her closely. As was the case with most of his Carly interactions, this one was baffling.

Then she took a deep breath and began to march toward him. "Carly?" he asked with some alarm as she showed no signs of slowing.

She stopped mere inches from him, so close he could see the constellation of freckles dotting the bridge of her nose. Carly looked up and he looked down at her.

“Ummm,” Adam tried again.

“I need to do something, for science, and I need you to trust me.” Her hands reached up and landed on the sides of his face, squeezing onto him like he was a basketball.

“Okay,” he nervously replied.

“The kiss will be brief, and it won’t mean anything. I just need to try this.” Her eyes widened, and he was certain his had, too.

“A kiss?” he asked.

“A small one. Okay?” She waited for him to agree, but he was stunned into silence. Maybe he nodded. He wasn’t sure, but before he had much time to protest, she said, “Three, two, one, blastoff.”

Carly hopped onto her tiptoes, pulled Adam toward her and kissed him. The kiss was painful, in that she pressed way too hard against his lips, and he gasped in shock, which somehow caused her to bite down on his lower lip. And then she released him, and he reeled backward, nearly tripping over his own feet. His hand instinctively went to his lips and pressed against them.

“What was that?” he said, rubbing at the bitten part. Unlike the fake kiss they’d done in front of Shireen, there was no thumb and no audience.

“I figured out *why* my theory didn’t work the last loop.” She adjusted her glasses, which drew his attention to her eyes.

He momentarily got lost in them. His focus returned, though. “Because it’s not based in scientific fact?”

“It is based in evidence, though, which is a kind of fact?”

“Fair.” He had to give her that one.

She started to walk toward the front door and motioned for him to follow. “I realized that one of the key things that happened with the loops that shortened was physical connection—touch—of some kind between us. The last loop, no touching and no change.”

“So you’re suggesting that the loop is changing only when you and I touch each other?” Adam held the door open for her and she walked through. “You’re really grasping at straws. You see that, right?”

“I do, yes,” she said.

“And why not just hold my hand?” he pressed on. “Why a full kiss?”

“The first time we—the stage kiss—when that happened, I experienced this kind of jolt. I don’t know how to describe it. But like, a little flurry, and I just think that was a signal of like, a charge or something, that caused the change, if that makes sense?” Her hands fidgeted at her sides, and he wondered if talking about this made her nervous. That was . . . interesting.

But he didn’t say that out loud because, well, he’d felt a little flutter, too. Though, he was mostly sure the flutter came from someone attractive touching him.

Attractive, hot, cute and irrational. These were all words to describe Carly.

“Anyways, we’ll see if I’m right in a few hours. It’s all in the name of ending the loop, right? And in the meantime, we can go do whatever science stuff you want.” She had the nerve to smile.

“Whatever science stuff I want?” he parroted back. “You just kissed me, and now you think we can just pivot to me?”

“Why not?” she asked.

He rubbed his temple with a knuckle in annoyance. “You don’t even know what I want to do to test my theory. Maybe what you just did compromised any results I might have today.”

“Oh,” she said through a cringe. “Did I compromise them?”

“No,” he admitted. “But you could’ve.”

Carly rolled her eyes.

“Going forward, we need to discuss these things. No more surprise . . . anythings.” His eyes flitted over the length of her, and he realized that while the kiss had been jarring and eye-opening for him, maybe it wasn’t for Carly, who simply stood as if nothing had happened. That could only be because the kiss was platonic.

“That’s fair.” She wiped her mouth with the back of her hand and erased any trace of his lips.

Right, it was just a fake kiss to test a bogus theory. He needed to get himself together. He tried for sarcasm as he said, “Don’t sound too excited about my science stuff.”

“I can’t help it. Science makes me extremely excited,” she said in a flat, deadpan voice.

He could do this. He could move on from the fact that he’d just been kissed and go about the day normally. He was pursuing facts.

“We have what we need for timekeeping.” Adam lifted his wrist and gestured to the watch. “But what I want to do is record the shadow bands on a camera so we can measure the length of them. My theory is that the shadow bands had an unexpected nuance that caused a ripple in time itself. Therefore, if I can find a way to stop the shadow bands—which occur right before the eclipse—then the loop will stop as well.”

“I mean, I have to admit that what you’ve just said is a little confusing but also sounds very legit. How do we measure these things?” Carly asked.

She was funny, which didn’t help his finding her hot thing. He cleared his throat, and the thought, as he said, “My dad has a super-fancy camera from when he went through his photography stage. I can grab that for the eclipse this evening.”

“Your dad?” she hedged. “Does that mean I get to meet the man who made this vision?”

Adam shook his head. “There will be no meeting. We will park the car, I’ll get the camera and then we’ll be off.”

“Okay.” She smiled and he noticed the hint of a dimple in one cheek. Had that always been there?

Before Adam could get his wits back, Carly turned and walked ahead of him toward the hearse. There was something about her chipper mood that made him ill at ease, but he pushed that all down, because today was the day he was going to prove himself right.

As he parked in front of his parents’ house, his dad’s voice sailed across the air, and Adam sensed that all was not going to go according to plan.

“Adam, honey?” his dad tried again.

Apparently, instincts were a thing that mattered. He’d always relied more on the evidence in front of him, but now his gut clenched in dread.

“Oh my God, was that your dad?” Carly grabbed Adam’s arm. “I love it when old men use the word *honey*. It’s just somehow sweeter, don’t you think?”

Then Bill rounded the corner from where the herb garden was, and Adam could already see exactly how this would go: Bill would introduce himself, Sheila would hear the commotion and come outside and invite Carly in. Within moments, Carly would be offered a room in their home, his dad would paint her into the family portrait and she’d be written into his parents’ living wills.

Adam abruptly started the car again. “We’re out of here,” he said.

“What? Are we seriously not even going to say hi? Your dad looks worried now.” Carly gestured to where Bill stood, gardening hat in his hands and scratching his head in confusion.

Adam gritted his teeth. “No hellos, no waves, not even a distant nod.”

Carly didn’t like that answer, apparently, because she rolled down the car window and loudly shouted, “Hi, Mr. Rhodes!”

“Uh, Adam’s friend?” Bill asked back.

“That’s me!” Carly’s voice oozed with an overly sweet tone. “Nice to meet you!”

“Nice to meet you, too!” his dad hollered back.

“We’ll be back later,” Adam sharply called out. Then, in a lower voice only meant for Carly, he said, “Stop being so naughty.”

As the words left his mouth, his soul also left his body. Had he just called Carly *naughty*? And had she noticed? He chanced a glance in her direction, but she seemed to be avoiding his gaze entirely.

Then she turned to him, grabbed his hand and looked him right in the eyes as she said, “I’m going to be extra obnoxious, just because you said that,” which confirmed she had, in fact, noticed.

Adam felt his whole face burn with embarrassment. What should he have to be so humiliated about, though? All he’d done was suggest she was *naughty*. Okay, yeah, he was embarrassed.

Even thinking the word sent a jolt to his dick, which he wrestled back as she got out of the car. He watched her approach Bill, offer a handshake and instead be met with a hug. Her eyes bulged then eased as she hugged his dad back.

Now it was only a matter of time before—

“Sheila!” Bill loudly shouted out. “Carly is here!”

As if ferried in by magic, Sheila appeared and hugged Carly, too. He almost felt like he was watching a happy family reconnect after years of being apart. Then all three of them turned to eye the hearse, and he knew his time was up.

Adam let out a long-suffering sigh, killed the engine and got out of the car.

While Adam had intended for this to be a swift errand to get a camera, his parents made quick work of getting to know Carly. They gave her a tour of the house, made her a tea, got her snacks and sat her down at the breakfast nook.

Adam, however, was not treating this as a social visit, and instead scoured through his dad's hobby closet to find the camera. He'd hear slivers of conversations and feel the unmistakable urge to pluck his own ears off.

We're just so glad that Adam is making friends—it's not right for someone his age to be so isolated. This is a time loop, not the pandemic!

The snippet that ultimately led him to increase his efforts and find the damn camera was a question from his dad.

And your mother . . . ?

She had an aggressive form of cancer and died when I was a baby.

Carly had never mentioned what happened to her mother, but the words made his body clench. She shouldn't have to bleed out all of her personal details to his parents just so he could find a camera. At that moment, the black camera bag came into view and he snatched it off the shelf. Adam hurried through the hall and toward Carly before his parents could cause any more emotional damage.

"Carly." His voice came out breathless as he skidded to a halt in the kitchen.

Carly and Sheila were at the kitchen island, adding cheese to a charcuterie board. Carly looked up and gave him a faint smile.

Uh-oh, cheese had been introduced. Now they'd never leave the house.

"Here." Sheila handed Adam the cheese board, and he had to put the camera bag under his arm to manage it. "You two go eat and we'll get some wine."

Adam didn't argue with his mom. Time alone with Carly meant he could check in and make sure his parents hadn't pushed her too far. Adam closed the sliding glass door behind them and let out a shaky exhale.

"I'm sorry," he apologized at the same time that Carly said, "I was so nervous to meet your parents."

"Really?" He couldn't imagine anyone being intimidated by Sheila and Bill.

"Yeah." She laughed. "I figured if they were anything like you, I'd have to call the scowl police."

Carly popped a grape from the plate into her mouth and chewed. She seemed . . . okay. Not traumatized, but still.

"They can be really nosy," he hedged.

"They asked a *lot* of questions," she said. "But sometimes it feels like there was no life before the loop. It's kind of nice to be reminded of the

past.”

“Mm.” Adam had spent most of the loop trying to forget the past.

“Tell me about the duck,” Carly said.

“The duck?” He glanced at the woods, as if searching for one.

“You know what I’m talking about. The duck in the window by the fireplace.” She studied her hands. “It has a corkscrew for a penis.”

Ah, *that duck*. “It does.” He pursed his lips.

“Why?” Carly held a hand out, as if expecting him to place the answer into her palm.

“Well.” His gaze turned skyward. “The thing about male ducks, is that they *do* have corkscrew-shaped penises. And my dad was going through a woodworking phase and thought this was quite funny. So he made a wine opener, using a corkscrew, and molding a duck around it.”

Carly pursed her lips and stared at a hummingbird flitting between overflowing planters. Eventually, she looked at him. “Cute, fluffy ducks that swim in ponds have penises shaped like corkscrews?”

“Yup.”

Carly smacked her palm against her thigh. “Okay, I regret asking about that.”

Adam tried to mask his smile.

“Everything is just . . . not what I expected. I mean, this is a *home*. The kind of cozy ones you see in movies. Like, your house is so cutesy. I’ve never seen so much squirrel art.” She tapped her index finger against her chin. “Oh my God, the acorns! In the funeral home!”

“My dad made all of those, and these.” Adam waved a hand to the tiny ceramic squirrel family and the colorful nuts they chased after. His dad had placed this set on a corner of the porch.

Carly bent to inspect the squirrel figurines. “This squirrel is wearing glasses and a little bow tie!”

“That’s Smarty Squirrel.”

Carly raised an eyebrow. “They have names?”

“And backstories.” Adam clasped his hands together and rocked a bit.

“I feel like your dad could really be a working artist. I mean, that corkscrew duck would sell out in LA.”

He laughed. “I’m not sure he ever even thought it was an option.”

Adam’s parents weren’t risk takers. Unlike Carly’s dad, who’d pursued not only a dream of working on movies, but also opening his own theater,

Adam's parents had grown up in Julian, met in high school and never thought to pursue careers that weren't the ones their parents had wanted for them.

And then, like swallowing a stone, the realization that Adam was *just* like them hit. A nauseating wave at the fact that he hadn't taken a risk with what he wanted to do, either. Maybe that was why he'd never even applied to Caltech.

Adam believed his parents were very much in love and happy with their lives, but maybe Carly was right. Why hadn't his dad ever tried to sell his art? Was there a world where he could've pursued his passion and kept his job?

His thoughts were interrupted by the alarm on his watch. Carly stood and nodded to where the eclipse was about to make its debut. "It's getting close."

Adam reached for the camera bag. He unzipped the thing and pulled on the lens of the camera to bring it out. Which is when Carly swooped in with a "Woah, woah, woah." She took the bag from Adam and swatted his hands away.

"You don't grab a camera lens-first. Are you trying to break it?" she asked accusingly.

"Oh, right, your dad—the cameraman." Adam felt more than a little foolish.

She smirked. "My dad, sure, but I majored in screenwriting and minored in video production. I can hit a power and record button just as well as anyone else."

Carly held the case and took out the camera by grabbing the side of it. She uncapped the lens, looked through the viewfinder and gave a thumbs-up.

Something about the ease and authority she had while doing those steps had made Adam move closer. That peppermint smell was faint, but present, and had the interesting effect of sending a bump of energy through him.

"Which area of the ground should I be capturing?"

He enjoyed this dynamic of them working together. Adam leaned in and pointed at a spot. "Right around those oak trees, you'll see the bands appear in about fifteen seconds."

"Gotcha," Carly said. "Hitting Record starting now."

He didn't mind how close they were. She didn't seem to mind, either. At one point, her body swayed and touched his.

"Wow, there they are," she said with all the reverence you'd reserve for something beautiful.

Adam usually thought they were beautiful, too, but he also realized *Carly* was beautiful: dark hair falling in a curtain across the side of the camera, her excited half grin and the faint dimple in her cheek. Her skin was cool against his forearm and he itched to drape his jacket over her shoulders. But there was no time. "Ready, set, go," Adam said as the sun vanished. He glanced at the time on his watch to keep track.

"They're gone," Carly said.

"Keep recording to see the shadow bands reemerge," he said. "They'll pop again just after the eclipse ends."

And they waited, with Adam's forearm touching Carly's. When Adam stopped the time on the watch, a cool breeze kicked up.

"There are the shadow bands again, those sneaky minxes," she joked.

But his attention was elsewhere.

And Carly must've clocked this, as she asked, "What's happened?"

"Three minutes and forty-seven seconds," he said. He couldn't believe what he was seeing.

She smiled. "Fifteen seconds shorter."

The shortening made no sense. What could've possibly made the time reduce even more? He already knew that Carly would chalk this up to their kiss. She might even suggest they up the ante and make out.

He gave her a sideways glance, briefly imagining his hands in her long, dark hair, her hips pressing into him, and her soft lips parting for him. He hardened and had to adjust his stance to hide the evidence of his thoughts.

"Okay, shadow bands have officially vanished." Carly ended the recording, put the cap back on the camera lens and stored it in the bag. "I'm not going to gloat. I would like to, but I won't. Because, as you said, maybe you're on to something with your theory, too."

"Thanks," Adam said. He clenched his jaw. It's not that he didn't want Carly to be right. He just still sensed her theory wasn't wholly correct. "Let's review the footage while we can, then we can time the sunset, and the shooting star and the end of the loop, and tomorrow we can regroup on a strategy."

“Okay.” Carly had a warm look that told him she really wasn’t gloating. “We can still pursue multiple angles, in my opinion. Especially considering mine takes very little time.”

Her angle was touching him, and he wasn’t sure “very little time” was how he wanted to approach that one, but kept the thought to himself.

“As long as our goal is ending this loop, it doesn’t matter how we get there, right?” She asked.

And he supposed she was right. They should pursue all the angles. He swallowed down his concern that maybe he was just going along with her theory to feel her lips against his again, and said, “Yeah.”

So they watched the footage. Adam took a tape measure to the actual area where the bands appeared, then compared them to the screen and was able to parse out the size of the bands compared to the ground. When the bands reversed just after the eclipse ended, they were smaller in size, more frenetic in movement and lasted half as long. He wrote the facts down in his notebook, hoping to commit them to memory.

They stayed at his parents’ house to watch and time the sunset, then the shooting star. When the day was nearly done, there were no other significant changes Adam could see. The only change, really, was that he didn’t want this loop to end, because he was, despite himself, enjoying being with Carly.

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Chapter 15

Carly

Day 247

Carly smelled worn books and dust immediately upon entering the sliding doors of the Julian Public Library, the kind of comforting scent that brought her back to childhood trips with her dad to their local Buena Vista Library in Burbank. The little blip of nostalgia distracted her just enough that she tripped over the olive green carpet. Adam, to his credit, caught her elbow before she fully fell. And she managed to utter a muffled “thank you” as she righted herself.

“What was that?” Adam’s red hair had fallen over his eyes and he watched Carly through the fiery curtain. “I couldn’t hear you. Was that a *thank you*?”

“It’s about to turn into a *fuck you* if you keep that up.” She gave him her widest, most insincere smile and was delighted when he laughed.

The loop reset had been fairly normal. But Adam had insisted they take a trip to the library to do research.

Which was fine. She could focus on Adam’s shadow bands, and that would buy her time to figure out an organic, non-embarrassing way to ask Adam if he was all right with yet another awkward kiss. Awkward because, apparently, she had no idea how to kiss someone, as evidenced by the way she’d planted her face onto his and nearly bitten his lower lip off in the last loop.

“Haven’t been here in ages,” Adam said as he scanned an aisle of books. “This library was basically the school library, too.”

He leaned against a desk and crossed his arms. Annoyingly, Carly couldn’t help noticing the toned muscles straining against the thin fabric of his button-down. It didn’t seem fair that he was smart enough to know all the constellations on top of how to attractively lean. “The only time I’ve seen you sit still is when you eat. Maybe I should’ve brought a snack with us.”

“Well, I *am* neurodivergent. ADHD, remember?” She didn’t mind the excuse to make him feel a little bad. “Sitting still isn’t always easy for me.”

She was giving him a hard time, but Adam’s observation that she was in constant motion wasn’t incorrect. She’d always prioritized work above all else. And now that she was stuck in this loop, she felt that if she stopped moving, even for a moment, she had too much time to focus on what she’d lost. Moving meant that she was going forward, not back into her old memories of how things had been.

“I’m just wondering if the library is going to inspire or stifle you,” he continued. “Because I need your creative brain to help me figure out how to block out the eclipse.”

Carly stopped tapping her foot and eyed him. “You *need* me?” she said. Obviously, she knew they were working together, but she’d always felt that Adam more or less tolerated her presence versus required it.

“I have facts.” He sighed. “And while I’d like to think that’s enough to get us out of this loop, so far it hasn’t. You, on the other hand, have the kind of creativity that will lead us to a breakthrough. That’s what all great scientific discoveries have in common—someone smart enough to think beyond the science.”

Carly got the kind of wicked grin reserved for Disney villains. “So, you admit it. I’m smarter than you.”

Adam rolled his eyes. “Do you want out of this loop or not?”

She did want out. She’d wanted out from the beginning. Only now, the days hadn’t felt nearly as long or lonely as they used to. If she admitted that, though, she’d never hear the end of it. So instead, she said, “Okay, let’s give the library a shot, and if it’s not working, we can move on.”

“Sounds like a plan.” He pushed off from the desk and started toward the book stacks.

Carly followed. “What plan? There’s a plan? Do we just pick up a book and quietly read in a cozy nook?”

Actually, now that she’d said that out loud, it didn’t sound so terrible. She couldn’t remember the last time she’d done something like that. She was used to reading scripts for work, but a book?

“We measured the shadow bands yesterday. There’s a working theory that they’re caused by a sliver of light that escapes the eclipse, which I happen to agree with. I’m just wondering if we can research a way to effectively block that light.”

Adam traced a finger down the spine of a book, and Carly had to look away, because it made her wonder what his finger would feel like trailing down the length of her. “You want to block out even more of the sun?” she tried to clarify.

“We’d need to block out all of it to eliminate the shadow bands, yes.” Adam took a sharp left down a row of books whose spines were all worn cloth and gold lettering.

“This looks like the fancy section!” she said, then spotted one with an almost plum jacket cover, slightly worn, but a little painted rose danced up the spine. What was *that* one? She got on her tiptoes to reach for it.

She wasn’t tall enough, though, so turned to Adam. She was surprised to see his eyes not on the books, but on the hem of her dress, which had ridden up slightly from her reach. “Rhodes?” she asked.

His eyes snapped up to hers, and he cleared his throat. It was only then that Carly considered the possibility that Adam had been checking her out. She furrowed her brows as she processed this information.

Adam wasted no time in grabbing the book she couldn’t reach and handing it to her. The cover read *Romping Through Mathematics*. Scientists were funny.

“The eclipse has changed four times,” he said as she thumbed through the pages. “It’s shorter by forty-five seconds. But nothing else that we’ve noticed so far has changed. There’s still fourteen hours in a loop day. Sunset still occurs at 7:29 p.m. The question, then, is *why* the eclipse and why four times?”

“But why not the eclipse?” she hedged. “It’s this super-special and rare thing that only happens once, maybe twice for a person in their lifetime. It’s what everyone in this town has to stop and take notice of each day. If the universe is trying to tell us something, wouldn’t it use the most obvious

thing? It's like that rule of eating berries in the wild. If they're orange or red—bright colors—you should avoid them. Nature almost makes them stand out as a warning.”

Adam leaned a shoulder into the bookshelf and studied her. And *this* was why Carly really liked him: She could almost never tell exactly what he was thinking. He looked just as likely to try to devour her as he looked ready to turn and walk away. A mix of disbelief and desire that put her on edge.

“You’re right. Why *not* the eclipse? I like where you’re headed. The eclipse is a warning—something we *have* to pay attention to—and the change that’s occurring is telling us information.”

“I feel a *but* coming,” Carly said.

“But what I’ve told you is the extent of my knowledge. I own a telescope and have dabbled in scientific hobbies, but I’m not an *actual* scientist.”

Adam pursed his lips. “Which is why we need to read up.”

Adam walked down an aisle, and Carly followed closely behind. “Here’s the math and science section. That should help narrow it down.”

“What should I look for?” Carly asked.

“Kip Thorne is one of these scientists who’s kind of cornered the market on gravitational physics. There might be something in those pages around light sources. He teaches at Caltech. That’s where I wanted to go to college.”

Carly watched Adam almost stutter over the last words.

“Did you not get in or something?” She found that hard to believe, considering Adam prided himself on being better than everyone else.

“No. I mean, I didn’t even apply. My dad talked me out of it.” Adam avoided meeting Carly’s gaze and studied the spine of a book.

She was confused, though. “Talked you out of it? Isn’t it, like, one of the best schools in the world?” Caltech was a thirty-minute drive from her place in Burbank, and a school she’d never considered because it was specifically for geniuses.

“It’s the hardest school to get into in America,” Adam confirmed.

“And your dad didn’t want you to apply?” She simply wasn’t following.

Adam sighed. “It’s complicated. It’s not that he didn’t want me to apply, but he asked a lot of questions. Like, what would I do in astronomy? And how competitive was the school? And how many jobs are there for people who study the stars?”

Carly inwardly cringed; she hadn't considered that she might be stepping on an emotional land mine.

"And then there was the family business, of course." Adam cracked his neck, as if just discussing this had built up tension in his body. "If I wanted to take over the funeral home, I needed a specific degree. The business was solvent, lucrative and would allow me to have an easy go of it, job-wise. And with me dating Shireen, she didn't want to leave Julian. I guess I just thought the easier route would be to stay here, too."

Easier wasn't always a bad thing. Lots of great things could come when something felt easy. Like for Carly, it was easier to sit down and write a scene of a script than do anything else. But she got the sense from Adam's resigned tone that while he'd chosen the path he was on, he'd questioned whether it was the right one.

"What about you?" she asked. "What do you want?"

His gaze briefly met hers, before he looked away and pretended to study the books. "Whatever's best for everyone."

"So altruistic," she said. She watched him out of the corner of her eye. His jaw twitched, but there was otherwise no tell of how he genuinely felt. Carly knew he was quite good at hiding things, though, so she decided to poke. "Right before the loop began, I got the biggest break of my career. There's this screenwriter who is a total legend, and I adore her writing. Marilyn Montgomery?"

Adam shrugged in response.

"She read a script I wrote and apparently thinks there's *promise* to it. I got the email from her on April twenty-third. The *first* April twenty-third." Carly felt the ghost of a smile on her lips as she remembered the email.

"So when we get out of this loop, you're going to get your big break. That's amazing." He gave her a look like he was happy for her.

"It is amazing," Carly acknowledged. "There's this myth that if you just pursue your dreams, they'll come true. I've been pursuing this one for over a decade. I work as a bartender full-time and write on the side. Maybe you can do what's best for everyone while still doing what's best for you."

"That's true," Adam said while focusing on the floor.

Carly sensed Adam wanted to move on, so she tried to change the subject. "Thorne, you said?"

"Kip Thorne, yeah."

She scanned a shelf, bent down and followed the letters until the last names began with T. She eventually saw the last name Thorne, and the book title, *Black Holes & Time Warps* stared back at her. “This is what we might call a bull’s-eye,” she said as she held the book out for Adam’s inspection.

“Nice.” His elbows skimmed the side of her as he bent down to the shelf. She was aware of his breathing, and the smell of him, and then her breathing became shallow.

He picked out a different Thorne book. “Let’s get to reading,” he said and found a desk with a hard seat and an overhead lamp.

Carly, however, didn’t feel like a rod was in her spine, so she gravitated toward an indoor bench with a long cushion and pillows flanked by windows. The benefit of this spot, too, was that it was removed from Adam and the bizarre reaction her body was having to him. She stretched her legs out, tucked a pillow behind her and leaned back against the wall.

Maybe it would be good for her to have a basic understanding of physics so that when Adam spoke, she didn’t morph into a blinking goldfish. She cracked open the book and began to read. At one point, she realized that she’d have to grab paper and jot down notes if she wanted to be able to retain anything. After a few hours, Adam brought her a to-go box of apple pie and a turkey sandwich. She ate and she wrote.

Things can be trapped forever.

Inside a loop, cause and effect may be hard to untangle.

Black holes, neutron stars, gravitational waves, time warps and time machines.

Carly put the book down, took off her glasses and wiped the lenses with the cloth she kept in her pocket. She’d been making good on her agreement to sit with her thoughts. But she wasn’t sure what to think of her notes.

She sighed. Maybe she wasn’t smart enough to solve this puzzle. Adam was bent over his book, and a heavy worry line creased his forehead. He seemed to think Carly would have all the answers, but she certainly didn’t feel any closer to the truth of what was going on.

Adam was the one who understood the world around them in a way she never could. Scientific theories weren’t the thing that fueled her, though Adam obviously lived for them. It was hard to imagine Sheila and Bill seeing that enthusiasm and not encouraging it. Her dad would’ve helped her apply to Caltech, if that was what she’d wanted. How had Adam’s parents not provided the same support?

But then again, not everyone was lucky enough to have Bruce Hart as their dad. A tear trailed its way down her cheek at the thought of him, and Carly wiped it away with the back of her hand.

Adam watched as she stood up. “Something wrong?”

“I just need a little fresh air.”

But she could tell by the way he cocked his head that he saw through her. And while she normally hid this topic under lock and key, maybe it was time to tell someone what happened.

“The other loop, you asked about my dad. I was thinking about him just now.” Carly swallowed the lump in her throat. “He was the person I called first. If something bad or good happened, he was the person I wanted to talk to. We talked every day, actually. I’d call in the morning, when he was up, and I was finishing my coffee. We’d talk about mundane things—the weather, my latest script, plans for the weekend, upcoming movies. It was like this anchor that made me feel loved and important. And now . . .”

Her throat dried up. Out of everything, the fact that she didn’t get to hear his voice was the hardest to accept. Not getting to hug him was a close second. But who was going to be her daily call? Who would keep her rooted? Burbank was what she called home, but it really wasn’t. Her dad was home. His voice was her comfort. And now she’d have to figure out how to exist without him.

“You know,” Adam said, “just because your dad isn’t here, doesn’t mean he isn’t listening.”

That was the thing about Adam—he didn’t always talk a lot, but when he did it was meaningful.

“I’m sorry he passed,” he added.

Carly bit the inside of her cheek. She was sorry he’d had a fatal heart attack, too. “It’s the last conversation I had with him that haunts me,” she said. “The way I spoke to him. The things I said . . . I wonder if he’ll ever forgive me for those.”

She closed her eyes. What would Adam think if he knew what a piece of shit she’d been to her dad? Would he still want her help? Adam’s steady hand reached for hers, and he squeezed her for reassurance. Which is when she started to tell him the truth of what happened.

Carly remembered her phone ringing in her purse, and a feeling of dread at the incoming FaceTime call from Bruce.

“Carly girl!” Bruce’s voice had boomed through the phone.

She missed him, but she was also pissed off. Beyond pissed, really. Because that day was the year anniversary of Bruce’s leaving Burbank for Julian. She’d thought for sure he would’ve come back, but he was still *there*. And her most effective way of showing that she didn’t approve of that decision was by icing him out. So she fought to keep her expression neutral as she replied with a casual, “Hey, Dad.”

“It’s so good to see you. I miss you, kiddo.” The vulnerability in his voice was clear. Which was why it was almost impossible not to break stoic obstinance as his eyes crinkled at the corners, waiting for her to say the sentiments back.

And she did miss him. Seeing his face was like slipping under a warm and cozy blanket. But she wasn’t ready to forgive him for leaving her behind. “Why don’t you come home, then?” she asked.

If he loved her so much, then why had he moved two hours away to start a new life? Why hadn’t he come to visit her in the year he’d been gone? And what about the life he’d had in Burbank with Carly was so bad? He was supposed to stay in her childhood home and grow old there. They were a small and mighty family of two. Carly already lost her mom, and now it felt like her dad had willingly abandoned her as well.

“Have you thought about taking time off for a visit?” he volleyed back.

Carly’s jaw twitched. Her dad wanted her to come to Julian. He’d said the town was gorgeous—the trip would inspire her to write something—and didn’t she want to see the movie theater?

When she pursed her lips to deliver the blow, Carly felt a pang of guilt. But also? Maybe this would be the thing to get him to move back. Maybe he’d finally understand that Carly didn’t want to be part of his new life; she wanted their old life back. “I don’t want to come.”

“Oh,” Bruce said. “I thought we could watch our favorites on the big screen. Don’t you want to—”

Carly cut him off. “We can watch movies from Burbank that were made here.”

“Right,” he said.

“I have to go.”

“Carly.”

“What?” Her tone was sharp and annoyed. She wasn’t sure how she’d wanted the conversation to end. How was he supposed to respond to what she’d said? Had she really just expected him to agree to move home?

“Just think about it, okay? I love you.”

She’d ended the call without saying goodbye and practically thrown the phone. She’d held her tears back until then, wanting to play the role of disappointed daughter until the very end. And *that* was the last time she’d spoken to her dad.

Adam’s palm rubbed slow circles between Carly’s shoulder blades as she wiped at her eyes with the back of her hand. She hadn’t told anyone else about that final conversation with Bruce. She’d been too ashamed to ever admit how ridiculously stubborn she’d been.

“Something I want you to know is that relationships aren’t defined by the last thing you told someone. Time is both long and short, as evidenced by this loop. And your dad would one hundred percent not dwell on that conversation. He’d be thinking about the moments that defined his life—having you, for example.”

The day you were born was the start of my life, Bruce often said.

“Can I ask you something?” Carly looked at Adam. “How can you be *such* an asshole sometimes, but so kind now?”

Adam laughed, and a small smile broke across her face, too. Carly shook her head as she wiped away a final tear.

“I know we bicker a lot, in a sort of joking way, I think?” Adam gave her a look, as if to gauge whether or not she actually disliked him.

“Joking, yes,” she admitted.

“But if I can be honest for a moment, no joking in sight, you actually inspired me the other day.”

“Do tell.” Carly crossed her arms, guarding herself against a potential blow.

“My dad told me that it might be time to move on . . . from Shireen.” Adam’s eyes flicked to Carly’s. “And I thought of you, and how you have to be quite brave to do what you’re doing—betting on yourself with writing. And that sort of inspired me to acknowledge that it’s time I start looking forward.”

Carly's lips parted. She'd inspired Adam to do something? He'd thought of her in a moment when she wasn't even there? That might be the nicest thing she'd heard in a long time.

"I've rendered you speechless—not easy to do," Adam said. "But if it's helpful, maybe it's time for you to look forward, too, and let go of what happened with your dad."

Carly was ready to embrace that this was her life, if that was all she had. She'd just have to move forward—or as forward as possible in a time loop. She closed her eyes and told herself to just let go of the regret for not visiting her dad sooner.

And maybe it worked, because she felt lighter. Carly let out a breath and looked back to Adam. His honey eyes had little flecks of gold in them, she realized.

She wanted Adam to kiss her. She wanted him to reach down and press his lips to hers and pull her body close. She wanted to know what the man who showed her shooting stars tasted like.

Carly watched as Adam's breathing changed and he took a step closer. Maybe this thing she had for him wasn't as one-sided as she'd imagined. He placed a palm on the desk next to her. He was so much bigger and broader that all she could see was *him*. His eyes studied hers, as if seeking permission.

"We haven't tested your theory today," he said.

Whatever was happening between them was completely unexpected, yet so natural that she couldn't help but arch her hips toward him. *Do it*, she tried to tell him.

"Maybe this is a good time . . ." Carly began to say.

Adam's mouth opened, then closed. She wondered what he was holding back. But then he pressed his forehead to hers, and their noses touched. He rubbed his big thumb across the line of her cheekbone, and his breaths came out hot against her lips, almost teasing her with the idea of what it would be like to get even closer.

Who was this steady man with the shadow of a beard and the sleeves of his button-up shirt rolled to reveal his forearms? Adam's hand reached behind Carly's head to tilt her mouth up to his. His eyes once again searched hers, waiting to see if she'd pull away, but she didn't want to.

"For the theory," Adam said.

She gave a small nod. "Science is important."

Then, without any further hesitation, Adam pressed his lips to hers. His mouth was full and firm. Carly's hands found their way around his shoulders and pulled his body in tight.

There was Adam's tongue in her mouth, and his lips massaging hers and his fingers gently cradling the back of her neck. As his lips traveled across her jaw, they gave a light touch that had her arching into him for more. His breath fanned across her collarbone. She tugged his hair to bring his mouth back. She'd have to give him a new nickname. Adam the Attentive?

Then his palm found her low back and pulled her into him, and she could feel his hardness against the top of her thigh, showing her just how much he was enjoying this, too. Adam the Alert?

As if on cue, the alarm on his watch pinged. Adam groaned. "The eclipse . . ."

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Chapter 16

Adam

Of course they had to time the eclipse. That wasn't a question. After all the fuss over whose theory was the correct one, the only option was to hide his arousal, straighten out Carly's mussed hair and go outside. Which is how they'd ended up on the sidewalk, sweaty from the make-out session and the overhead sun.

Adam had gotten carried away with the kissing—and the kissing, to be fair, had been exceptional. Unlike the fake Hollywood kiss, or the awkward surprise kiss that Carly had planted on him, *this* kiss revealed that Carly had velvety lips and a quick tongue. When she'd pulled back, her glasses were crooked and her hot breath across his chest made goose bumps erupt up his arms.

The whole thing had been impulsive, an adjective he'd never before used to describe himself. But something about opening up to Carly, and her sharing the truth about her dad, had shifted the way Adam saw her. And maybe changed what he was willing to do to get Carly to see him differently, too.

While they timed the shadow bands and the eclipse, Adam kept chancing looks at Carly to get a read on how she'd felt about the whole thing. He anxiously fiddled with his wristwatch to avoid saying something he couldn't take back like, *Do you want to try that kissing thing again?*

"And now," Carly said.

Adam nearly fell sideways at the sound of her voice, then he quickly focused his attention on the watch. He let out a shaky, hopeful breath as he registered the time.

“Two minutes and forty-seven seconds,” Adam said. His eyes flicked to Carly.

She slid the eclipse glasses off and her jaw dropped open in shock.

2:47 meant the eclipse had shortened again—but this time, by a full minute.

Adam was a logical person. He understood that the loop shortening was a good thing. While he’d planned to research ways to block the light from the sun in order to completely end the loop, maybe they didn’t have to. At the rate the loop was changing, they could just wait for the eclipse to end. If it shortened by a minute each loop, that would only be three more times.

Only three more times to see the shadow bands. While he’d wanted this moment to come, he thought he’d have more time. He’d have to use the next three loops wisely if he wanted to actually discover what caused the shadow bands in the first place.

“This is totally bonkers, right?” Carly asked as she bounced from one foot to the other. “I mean, it’s a *minute* shorter? How is that possible? Am I *that* amazing of a kisser?”

Adam laughed. He didn’t mean to, but she was funny. She gave him a little punch in his arm, and that was fair.

“Don’t make fun of me, I’m serious!” she said. “What else could be happening here?”

“Honestly, *plenty* of other things.” Adam fisted a hand through his hair. He wished that he was a more creative person so he could come up with alternative ideas, but he just didn’t have that particular skill set. “But whatever is happening seems to be leading us in the right direction.”

Carly gave him a look, like she was annoyed that he wasn’t completely agreeing with her. And even when she was irritated, she was still so pretty. So damn pretty. He was a sucker for her glasses. He wanted to watch her take them off, put the tip in that pretty little mouth of hers and . . .

“Adam, you’re doing the staring off into the distance thing again,” she said.

He shook the fantasy from his head. “We should head out before the madness sets in.” Adam warily eyed the main road. In the center was a drum circle, and about a dozen people wearing cat masks danced around to

the unmistakable beat of Taylor Swift's "Blank Space." Fairly harmless, really, but he wasn't super interested in seeing what else the night would bring. "Let's get our stuff and go."

He could drive them back to the tree house, or to the lavender field he liked to watch the stars from. And then they could talk through the change in time and spark some ideas for the next few loops. Adam headed for the library, and Carly kept in step.

"Here's an idea," she said. "Why don't we consider kissing again."

Her bluntness nearly caused Adam to trip through the sliding glass doors of the library. Instead, he walked through and kept his eyes trained on the desks where they'd just been. It wasn't that he didn't want to kiss Carly. He *really* did. But the kissing couldn't be what was causing the change—it just couldn't. Yes, the evidence might lean that way, but more likely was that they hadn't found the real cause, and the timing was coincidental. So he didn't want to pretend otherwise just to get the chance to kiss her again. That would be taking advantage of the situation, and of her, and he really wasn't interested in either of those things.

"The kissing isn't the direction we should be pursuing," Adam firmly said as he shoved keys and a notebook into his tote bag. "The kissing is coincidental to the loop ending."

"How can you say that?" She planted her hands on the desk, as if in a challenge. "I had a theory, we looked for evidence and found it. We're on the right track."

Adam slung the tote bag onto his shoulder. He gathered all his strength because, really, turning down a perfectly good offer to make out with Carly was not easy. "I'm not about to pretend that your Together Theory has any kind of logic—*why* us? Why physical contact? It makes zero sense."

She gritted her teeth. "Plenty of things happen in the world that can't be explained. People are powerful. What's that phenomenon called, where the moms push cars off of their kids?"

"Hysterical strength," Adam said. "Caused by a massive rush of adrenaline, which is something *science* explains."

"Ah, but what about the magic of a hot dog-eating contest? How do you explain one person eating seventy-three hot dogs?" She put her hands on her hips in triumph, but he shook his head and looked up to the sky.

So she tried again. "You don't know everything just because you own a telescope."

“Two,” he said.

She narrowed her eyes at him.

“I own two telescopes.” He always leaned into the facts.

She licked her lips, which drew his attention to her sweet little mouth. He was deeply annoyed by the fact that he’d just vowed not to kiss her.

“Despite the fact that you’re a pretentious asshole, I want to kiss you again. I liked kissing you. Fuck the science.”

His breath came out shallow as he processed what she’d just said. Carly wanted to kiss him, even without scientific reasons? No, that wasn’t possible. She barely tolerated him. Then the gears in his brain clicked together and he finally understood her motivation.

“I know what this is.” He crossed his arms. “You’re trying to trick me into kissing you so you can once again chalk changes in the time up to us. Am I right?”

“I mean, me being right would be awesome.” Carly pursed her lips. “But also? It’s been a long time for me with anyone else. I know a lot of people in the loop just hook up with someone new every day, but that kind of scares me. So it’s just . . . again, a long time. I haven’t had a lot of options here.”

Carly finally took a breath, locked eyes with him and added, “If you don’t want to kiss me, I totally understand. But I’d be more than okay with it.”

Adam swallowed. So Carly was lonely. He was lonely, too. They both had already kissed each other. What was once more?

“Fuck it,” he said. He dropped the bag and his hand reached for her. His knuckles brushed against the line of her jaw as he tilted her face up to admire her full pout.

“Is this okay?” he asked. Unlike the other times, this wasn’t strictly in the name of science. And, well, maybe earlier wasn’t for science, either, he supposed. But if he was getting the opportunity to kiss Carly properly, then he was going to make sure they both enjoyed every second of it.

Carly’s breaths came out quick and she nodded her head. Adam pushed her against the library wall and boxed her in with his arms. She bit her lower lip and he let out a moan in her mouth as she rocked her body into his hardness. He moved against her, and she whimpered as his thumb found her nipple and flick, flick, flicked it.

“Still okay?” Adam asked.

“I don’t think you need to ask anymore.” Carly laughed. “Never been more okay.”

He was exactly where he wanted to be, too. Having Carly’s nails scratch down his back suddenly made the library his favorite place in the world.

“Is this what I have to do to get you to be nice to me?” His fingertips trailed down the curve of her hip and she shivered. “Touch you here?”

“Is this what you think being nice is?” Her teeth sank into his bottom lip.

One of his knees slipped between her legs to spread them apart, then gently maneuvered to her center and skimmed the outside of her panties. He longed to know if she was wet.

He pinched her nipple. “Your mouth tastes like peppermint, but what does the rest of you taste like?”

“Woah.” Carly laughed. “How long did it take you to come up with that line? Not complaining, just impressed.”

She didn’t protest when he began to lift the hem of her dress, a slow rise of the fabric up her skin. His lashes fluttered wildly at the sight of her full thighs, and eventually her panties. “You told me not to ask, but is *this* okay?”

“Please just find out if I taste like peppermint everywhere,” she practically begged.

Who was he to deny her?

Adam tried to hide his grin as he hooked his thumbs into the top of her panties and brought them down until they were fully off. And then there was Carly, open and ready. Her chest rose and fell with deep, anticipatory breaths.

This was a lot, all at once, but just seeing her in this state of wanting scrambled any sensible thoughts he might have had. Thoughts like . . .

You barely know this person.

It’s getting dark and you should head home.

This is a public library and anyone could walk in.

Instead, his only thought was what to do to make Carly come. He dragged the back of his knuckles up, up, up her leg and across her thigh. Then he brushed over her clit with the pad of his thumb. Again. Again. Again. She twitched against his touch, letting out surprised gasps.

He hadn’t even revealed what he could do with his tongue. Adam got on his knees to show exactly how excited he was. Carly’s eyes fluttered as he licked her inner thigh, slowly making his way closer until she took a sharp

inhale as he reached the center of her. She knocked her knee to the side to let him inch in. He held her hips steady with a hand and sucked the bud of her clit into his mouth.

He pulled back only to blow a cool breath against her warmth, and he watched her shiver. He was playing with her now. She was a toy he was batting around, seeing how far she'd let him go, and he was really enjoying the game. His hand palmed her ass as he licked inside her.

"Oh, God," she said.

She did not taste like peppermint; she was salty and deliciously soft. He circled her clit with his tongue and she moaned. The hand that had been on her ass moved to put a finger inside her. Adam gently found his way in, pulled out, then in again. He licked and sucked at her bud as he found the very deepest part of her. Carly let out a groan as he brought her closer to the edge. Just as he'd played with her before, he was also playing with her now. As each time she got close, he pulled her back and then ramped her up again only to stop before she was too far gone.

Carly's body began to tighten. "I'm going to . . ." she started to say.

His thumb rubbed slow circles on her as wave after wave of an orgasm rolled through. At some point, her body relaxed. Adam gave a mischievous kind of smile.

"I hope that was okay," he said.

She narrowed her eyes at him. "You're cocky about this," she deduced. "You *know* when you're good at something, and because you're so damn competitive, you're *loving* how more than *okay* that was."

"I'm not competitive." He handed her the panties he'd so deftly removed.

She did a laugh-cough of surprise. "Okay, you're *not* competitive and I'm *not* wearing glasses." She reached up to feel her glasses, but they weren't there. Adam spotted them on the floor, where they must've fallen off during the encounter, and handed them over. "As I said . . ." She cleared her throat as she placed them back on her face. "I am not wearing glasses."

Adam finally stood up. He could still taste the salt of her and had to readjust himself. "That escalated quickly."

"I have to send the Dewey Decimal system a thank-you card," she said. "Speaking of which . . ."

Carly stepped into Adam's space and traced a line with her nail across the side of his neck. His head instinctively leaned in the direction of her hand.

They'd gone from kissing, to making out, to him eating her out. And now she seemed about ready to—

“Adam?” a loud voice called out. “Adam Rhodes, shadow band guy, are you in here?”

Carly gave Adam a curious look. “Your reputation precedes you, sir.”

He frowned. *Shadow band guy?* Who the hell would be calling him that? The only people he'd spoken to about shadow bands were Carly, Shireen and—

Dr. Song came into the room and zeroed in on him. “Adam? I spotted that hearse you drive at the top of the street. I've been going into every store in town to find you.”

Adam adjusted his button-down shirt, reminded that only moments ago he'd been on his knees in front of Carly.

“Let me formally introduce myself. I'm Dr. Heather Song, Director of Astronomy at Caltech.” She held out a hand, as if he didn't know who she was, but he shook it nonetheless.

Why was she here? What could she possibly want that would require her searching the entire town for him?

“Adam?” Carly's curiosity had turned to worry, it seemed.

“I met Dr. Song two loops ago,” he told Carly. “I thought maybe she could help put some of the missing pieces together for the shadow band theory.”

“Forget the shadow bands,” Dr. Song quickly said. “You were right about the eclipse, and the time shortening. It was a minute shorter this loop, I'm sure you're aware.”

“Yes,” Adam said with a gulp. There was something to be said for vibes, and the vibes coming off this woman were not great.

“I flagged the time change to my colleagues.” Dr. Song shoved her hands in the pockets of her cargo pants and rocked back on her heels. “Their concern, which is also mine, frankly, is that while any change is exciting, in theory, we have to consider all of the options.”

“Right,” Adam responded, not totally clear where she was going.

“I think this could very well be a wormhole we're in the presence of,” Dr. Song said with the kind of gravity he'd become accustomed to using at his role in the funeral home.

A wormhole? Adam's skin cooled.

She sighed. “Are you familiar with wormholes?”

Oh, yes, Adam was familiar with the idea of what a wormhole was. Some scientists thought that wormholes didn't exist at all, while others believed wormholes could potentially be manmade.

He could've said that, if Carly ever allowed him a moment to think before speaking. Instead, she began with, "I've seen them in sci-fi movies. They're kind of like a teleportation through space. Helps you get somewhere faster?"

"In sci-fi movies, yes, that's what a wormhole does." Dr. Song seemed to be fighting an eyeroll, which really annoyed Adam. Not everyone was a scientist, and besides—Carly wasn't wrong. The potential side effect of a wormhole could be the ability to bend time.

"Scientists have never found one," Adam said to Carly. "But it's more that they *think* it's very possible they exist."

It was at this moment that Dr. Song chose to say what Adam knew, but didn't necessarily want to voice. "More urgently, if they do exist, they eventually collapse on themselves."

Maybe it was all in Adam's head, but the air seemed to be sucked right out of the room. Carly, though, didn't immediately notice the lack of oxygen.

"Collapse?" Carly's brows furrowed as she looked back to Adam. "Like, the time loop ending, right?"

"Ending, yes," she said again, in that grave tone.

"Isn't that a good thing?" Carly asked.

"It could be," Adam said, trying to be hopeful.

Dr. Song chimed in. "If you consider falling into a black void a *good thing*."

Carly looked nauseated. "A void?"

"What we know is that being in the loop is keeping us alive," Dr. Song said. "If it collapses, who knows what's on the other side."

Of course, the loop ending didn't necessarily mean the people in Julian would be saved. In fact, it could very well mean the opposite. Adam had been so blinded by Carly's optimism that he hadn't even considered the idea.

Carly's hand reached out and grabbed on to his, which caused Adam's doomsday thoughts to slow. He squeezed back, relieved to have her to hold on to. And he realized that they both were likely experiencing the same kind of lopsided feeling.

What if the loop ended, and their world did, too?

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Chapter 17

Carly

Day 248

One minute, Carly had been squeezing Adam's hand so tightly that her own had started to cramp, and the next she found herself surrounded by the harsh overhead lighting of the funeral home.

She stared at the coffin. What if she only got to be in the same room with her dad a handful more times? If she'd understood what Dr. Song and Adam were saying, then the loop ending could mean that they just disappeared. Was that possible?

Carly pushed out of the chair and placed her hands on the casket. "Dad?" She looked down to where he rested. "There's some really scary shit going on. Scarier than a time loop. If you're watching over me, could you . . . I don't know, send a sign of what to do?"

She waited, hoping for a signal, when a creak in the floorboard sounded. Carly turned to see a flame-haired giant. She glanced back to where her dad was. "You're hilarious," she said to the casket.

"What was that?" Adam's deep voice ricocheted around the space.

"Nothing." Carly's cheeks flushed as she turned back to him. There he was—rumpled hair, tie slightly askew, long arms dangling at his sides—same as always, but also different. She'd kissed this version of Adam. He'd . . . tasted her, made her come. She'd felt how hard he'd grown when she moaned . . .

“How are you feeling about everything?” he asked.

Carly shook off her desire and started down the aisle of chairs.

“Overwhelmed,” she said. “My ADHD brain isn’t helping. I just keep pinging between all these thoughts. Not sure where to even begin, really.”

“I think fresh air is supposed to be good, in general.” Adam cocked his head to the side, then said, “Come on, let me take you somewhere.”

Carly found that she couldn’t say no to that offer if she tried. She followed Adam outside and imagined he’d lead her down a quiet little country road, as Julian was chock full of those. But no, Adam didn’t take her somewhere serene. Instead, he walked her to the graveyard across from the funeral home.

“Gee, for a funeral director you sure are morbid,” Carly said.

“For a writer, you’re very astute.” He gave her a sideways glance.

“Shireen used to call this place *spooky*. I’ve always thought it was kind of peaceful.”

Then, to prove his point, a mother deer and fawn grazed on an empty patch of grass on the side of one hill.

“Don’t they have any respect for the dead?” Carly nodded to the deer.

“They buck tradition,” he said back.

“Hear that, everybody? The man makes jokes!” Carly called out. Then quieter, she said, “I didn’t hear anyone laugh, but I thought it was funny.”

For a moment, this felt normal. Like they were just flirting—*flirting*? Yes, she supposed that was what this banter was—and not about to be sucked into a *void*, as Dr. Song had so delicately put it. Adam led them to an open clearing with five plots, each with elaborate headstones that featured multiple family photos behind glass.

“This family is from Italy,” he said. “Apparently, a lot of Italians feature photos of the person throughout their life on the tombstones. I always thought that was nice, to remember someone as they were in life, versus where they were buried.”

“Hard to forget where someone is buried when you start every day looking at their coffin,” Carly said, going for sarcasm. “Sorry, I have to have my jokes or things get dark real fast.”

Adam sat on the grass and patted a spot next to him, which she took.

“We didn’t get to talk about this wormhole thing without Dr. Song,” Carly said. “And by the way, what the hell is her deal—to not even ease

into the ‘We all might be about to die!’ subject with something a little lighter? I mean, she kind of scared the fuck out of me.”

Carly looked to Adam. This was the part where he was going to reassure her that Dr. Song was being a catastrophist, and they really had nothing to worry about. He was going to say that a wormhole meant they’d return to normal in a few short loops.

“You’re right, we didn’t.” Adam let out a sigh as he picked at a long blade of grass. “I know you’re like this goth optimist—”

She cut him off. “Excuse me, *goth optimist*?”

Adam ignored her and carried on. “I can’t paint you a pretty picture, because we just really don’t know if what’s coming is bad or good. I wish I could tell you different.”

She wanted to scoot closer, but now she was getting scared, too. “Do you think she’s right about the loop being a wormhole?”

He looked out across the field, then said, “*If* wormholes exist, they would appear round, like a black hole, much like our eclipse. Einstein said that space and time work together, and space is elastic. So maybe, somehow, a kind of wormhole opened up in Julian and trapped us here. It’s possible.”

A wormhole. The idea of that felt so absurd, and not only because the word *wormhole* was mildly funny. But how could something that scientists didn’t even fully believe in just suddenly happen in this random town?

“Okay, so let’s say that this scientific theory *is* real and it happened here. My question is, how?” Carly splayed her fingers in front of her for a little extra oomph.

Adam gave her a weak smile. “From what I’ve read, wormholes are caused by exotic matter—which just means a substance science hasn’t yet encountered. That exotic matter has something called negative mass, which makes antigravity. And *that* is what keeps a wormhole open. So, basically some exotic matter had to have entered Julian to cause a wormhole to pop up here. The negative mass is what’s keeping the loop going.”

“But the loop is shortening.” Carly felt like she was following but needed Adam to confirm.

“Yes. If this is a wormhole, it’s closing because gravity works to pinch wormholes closed. Basically, there’s not enough negative mass to keep it open. So, now it’s closing.”

Okay, that all made sense. Maybe she was better at science than she originally thought. “But how do we get out before it closes on us? Or how

do we keep it open?” she asked.

“To keep it open, we’d need to add more negative mass—but finding that exotic matter in time would be impossible at the rate we’re going.” Adam pursed his lips.

“But it might not be a wormhole.”

“It might not be.” He scratched at the scruff on his beard.

Carly erred on the hopeful side and offered, “Maybe a plot twist will come in act three to save us all.”

Adam pointed to her knee, which she hadn’t realized had been bouncing from anxiety. He gently placed a hand on top of it.

She muttered, “So what do we do now?”

“I don’t think there’s much to do. If the pace keeps up, then we only have a handful of loops left. We just have to make the most of that time.”

“You’re giving up?” Carly went on bouncing her knee again. “What about the rest of the town? Shouldn’t we tell them what’s happening?”

“Maybe? But I don’t feel great about any of this. It’s sort of like going to a psychic and she tells you when you’re going to die, and then you have to pretend like everything’s normal.”

“There’s a lot to unpack there. First, you said the word *psychic*, as if you’ve been to one, but more importantly, you think we’re going to die?” Carly could feel her brows pinching themselves together from the disbelief of this conversation. She and Adam had been a team only a few hours ago—working tirelessly, and sexily, to stop the loop. But now he was suggesting they enjoy their last moments and give up?

“I . . .” He licked his lips, started again. “I honestly don’t know. Anything is possible.”

Carly chewed on her lip so hard she was afraid she might draw blood. They sat there for a long time and said nothing. Her thoughts jostled from one thing to the next.

Maybe Adam and Dr. Song are wrong.

Maybe we can find more exotic matter.

Maybe it’s time to go eat alllllll the cheese wedges.

“I need to tell my parents about this.” Adam hugged his knees to his chest. “I’m not even sure they’ll believe me. But it feels like I should let them know what’s happening. Maybe Shireen, too.”

“Do you want me to come? We can tell them and then get back to work on the loop.” Carly wasn’t going to let Adam give up. *She* wasn’t giving up,

so he didn't get to, either.

But then he said, "I think I should do this on my own."

And while she shouldn't have been hurt, something about that really stung. "Oh, okay."

Adam stood and extended a hand so she could pull herself up. She ignored it and stood on her own. Carly was close enough to smell that buttery scent of his and, if she'd wanted, reach up and pull him down. But he'd just closed a door. Why had he done that?

"You can't just give up. What about the shadow bands?" But even as the words came out, she knew this wasn't a battle she was going to win. His eyes were set, his jaw clenched, as if he'd made up his mind and Carly was merely in the way.

"My parents deserve to know what's coming. And Shireen . . ." He took in a deep breath. "I feel I owe it to her to at least say something. The shadow bands can wait."

Adam seemed to always be worried about what everyone else thought. He'd skipped a chance at Caltech, all because his parents didn't understand his goals. And something about him going out of his way to help everyone but himself really irked her. "I get that, but what do *you* want, Adam?"

He pursed his lips and looked past her. She sensed this was a moment where he could take a risk or retreat to what he was comfortable with. And as the seconds ticked on, Carly had the sinking feeling that she knew what he'd choose.

"I'm going to tell them," he eventually said.

"I want you to tell them," Carly clarified. "But I don't think you should just assume Dr. Song has all the answers and give up trying. I've met you, Adam. You know so much more than you're giving yourself credit for."

Adam seemed to absorb that. Carly wondered if he'd change his mind and agree to meet up later to work on their theories. But instead, he said, "Can I give you a ride to town?"

She knew he would drive her, but what was the point? The guy had given her what was probably one of the more intense orgasms of her life a short while ago, but was going to be with his parents and his ex . . . still wife. Whatever the hell Shireen was.

"No, I'll walk," Carly said.

Adam began to head toward the parking lot. Something about him just slightly out of reach and leaving felt so much like when her dad revealed

his plans to move to Julian. Now Adam, who Carly *liked* very much, was giving her proof that he was no better.

She knew the comparison wasn't fair—surely Adam wasn't intentionally trying to hurt her—but what else was she to think? Carly was like an exposed nerve that had just been poked; tears formed in her eyes. She didn't want Adam to see her crying over this, over *him*. Maybe in some little corner of his brain he did care for her, but this still didn't feel great.

She wasn't like Adam, though. She wasn't going to just roll over and let a wormhole gobble her up. She was going to go into town and try to *do* something about this situation. She'd do everything she could, and she knew exactly where to go.

The Julian Heritage Museum was in a Victorian home about a mile from the center of town with pink-and-purple trim and a large wraparound porch. The street where the museum stood was suburban, and the sun burned hot and bright in the sky above the home.

Carly had been to the “Dollhouse,” as the party was dubbed, on more than one occasion; she knew to knock on the door twice and wait to be welcomed in. A series of locks undid themselves, and the old lady who ran the Dollhouse answered in an eighteenth-century white dress with a blue ribbon sash at the center. Her look was completed with an intricate lace collar, blue hat with pristine ivory feathers, a dainty lace umbrella, stockings and simple heels.

“May I help you?” the old woman asked.

“I seek revolution.” Carly recited the password she'd been taught.

She sought revolution, all right. She was about to launch an uprising in this town.

The woman nodded, opened the door and Carly walked through. Upon entering, there were nude magicians performing impressive sleight-of-hand tricks without the help of sleeves. At least a dozen overly fluffy cats sunned themselves by the windows and seemed oblivious to the energetic piano music being played on the square grand in the corner.

Carly began to walk down the hall, past a room with a tattoo artist and a line of customers waiting to be inked, another with an in-progress séance, a closed door with a sign on the outside that read *Enter the Galactic G Spot*.

But Carly wasn't in need of sex, ghosts or pain. In that moment, she needed to find a particular someone.

When she stepped through the doors, the grass was littered with beanbag chairs, and against the wood fence were folding tables filled with food. Carly scanned the tables, and then, in tiered perfection, she saw a cheese fountain. Bubbling, flowing cheese so yellow there was no way it wouldn't cause health issues in the future. But according to Adam, she had no future!

Carly smiled as the first wave of joy she'd felt all day flooded through her. The person she needed hadn't arrived, but this cheese would solve her problems. This cheese would want nothing except for her to consume more. This cheese was her god now.

"Come here, you beautiful little dream." She took a tortilla chip and as she was about to slide it into the gooey waterfall, a voice interrupted her.

"Is that you, Carly Sue?"

Carly shielded her eyes with the chip to see Mayor Franco. Carly was pleased. The mayor was just the person she needed for the next stage of her plan.

"My middle name is Florence," Carly said.

"Carly Florence," the mayor said as she tucked into a beanbag. "Nah, Carly Sue has a better ring to it."

Carly gave her an amused look. "I was hoping you'd be here," she said earnestly.

"Yeah, where the hell have you been anyway?" The mayor adjusted her gold bolero and fanned out the sequined jacket so that it more resembled a cape. "Moms doesn't feel as fun without you."

"I've been distracted." She cleared her throat. "I got swept up in trying to find a way out of the loop."

"Rick got to you, huh?" Franco clicked her tongue. "He's got some wild theories, I'll tell you what. He once told me that the reason mice try to come into our homes is because the aliens use them as spies. I mean, that would be smart of the aliens, but I'm pretty sure that's not true." Mayor Franco cocked her head in a way that suggested she was considering the idea again.

Carly hesitated. Rick hadn't gotten to her—Adam had gotten to her. And the sooner Carly told the truth, the sooner she'd find a way out of the loop. "How about we go into the crystal igloo and I'll tell you about it?"

And so, it was inside the makeshift igloo, filled with colorful crystals, that Carly told Mayor Franco about Adam, the eclipse and how they might

be on the verge of being sucked into a wormhole. Adam hadn't wanted to tell anyone else what they'd found, but now Carly had told the person in town who would let everyone know.

Because while Adam might want to keep their information close, Carly didn't want to vanish. She wanted to break out of the loop. Once she did, she'd get back to her old life, and the email from Marilyn Montgomery, and she'd never think of Adam and his wonderfully scratchy shadow of a beard again.

When she'd finished telling the mayor everything she knew, Carly felt safe with the knowledge that she was no longer alone, even if Adam had wanted her to be.

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Chapter 18

Adam

Even in his darkest moments, Adam had an inkling that the loop wouldn't last forever. A hope that came from his understanding of physics and Newton's laws of motion. Because every action had a reaction, and eventually the action of the time loop would have an equal and opposite reaction.

What he couldn't account for, though, was what would happen to all of them once the loop came to its end. He'd *hoped* that much like a scratch on a record, they would simply return to the exact spots where they'd left off and carry on as if nothing had happened. But more than likely, they wouldn't simply be returned the way they were. There would be changes—the reactions—to the loop. If they even survived it . . .

All of these thoughts swirled in an unsteady mix that was hard to silence. But then Adam felt an intense pressure on his hand, which grounded him back to the present. He was at his parents' house. Sheila and Bill sat across from him at the kitchen table. And the pressure he'd felt was Sheila's nails digging into the top of his hand.

"Mom," he said and pried her fingers off.

"What?" Sheila asked, then snapped out of her haze. "Oh, sorry, honey."

Adam hadn't had a conversation of this magnitude with his parents since the day Shireen imploded their marriage. This time, however, wasn't about Adam's life—it was about all of theirs, and the gravity of the situation was not lost on them.

“So,” Bill started to say, “do you actually think we’re all about to vanish? The woman you spoke with—”

“Dr. Song.” Adam sipped the coffee in front of him. The world might be ending, but he still needed caffeine.

“She’s a scientist who believes this is where the loop is headed?” The fear was etched across his dad’s face.

“I mean, it’s where I think the loop is headed.” Adam tried to keep his tone even and calm.

“And she does, too?” his dad asked, like he didn’t buy what Adam was selling.

“Why does her opinion matter more than mine?” Adam was annoyed. “I’m telling you I’ve looked at the evidence.”

“Her opinion comes with a doctorate,” Bill said.

“Can you two knock it off?” Sheila put a hand between them.

Of course it was only natural that his dad would want to know what the scientist thought. When getting a professional opinion, you wanted the doctor to tell you if you were going to live or die, not the guy who buried people for a living. But still, something in Adam was really bothered by all of this. Because if he’d gone to Caltech, then he’d be the doctor in this scenario.

“Sorry.” Adam wasn’t used to fighting with his parents. In fact, he never did. They occasionally bickered, but those quickly resolved. He tried to smooth things over with, “This is all a little stressful for me.”

“Of course it is.” Sheila stood, crossed to the fridge and pulled out the coffee cake. Instead of cutting them slices, she brought the whole thing to the table with three forks. She stabbed a piece with a heavy serving of frosting. “So, we might only have a few more loops, huh?” she said through a bite.

Adam swallowed. Yes, a few more loops might be all the time they had left in the world. He wasn’t the optimist, and he didn’t have Carly to pull him out of his spiral.

Carly. She’d looked almost pained when he said he’d tell his parents on his own. Maybe he should’ve brought her, but he also needed to process his own feelings. He’d hid his deepest fears from Carly, not wanting to scare her. But he didn’t plan to give his parents false hope.

“I think it’s time you painted that mural.” Sheila pointed the cake fork at Bill.

Bill waved her off. "I'm not going to spend my last moments smelling like paint. I want to spend it . . ." Bill raised his brows in a deeply suggestive way.

"Give me a break. You love painting. You've always dreamed of having a mural in town," his mom tried again.

"You have?" Adam looked at his dad, who gave a small shrug. Obviously, he knew his dad's hobby was art. Maybe he'd even call it his passion. But a mural?

"Who doesn't dream of that?" Bill asked.

"I don't," Sheila said as she speared more cake onto her fork. "I dream of a lounge chair on the beach and being massaged, like normal people."

"Why didn't you ever go for that, then?" Adam asked. "We've had all this time in the loop. You could've painted a mural every day."

"I can't just go and paint a mural, Adam." Bill's voice was almost accusatory.

Sheila raised her eyebrows at Adam, almost suggesting she'd had this conversation with his dad before. Then she said to Bill, "Okay, honey."

"I'm sorry. I don't mean to sound upset. There's just a lot to unravel here." Bill's face had gone red. Adam wondered what he was suppressing, and what had held Bill back from accomplishing this one thing.

"I still have to tell Shireen." Adam stood from the table with the sudden need to leave this conversation. He couldn't meet his father's eyes. His dad had a dream that was right in front of him, but he wouldn't even *try* to achieve it. The whole thing filled Adam with a mix of sadness and frustration, and he didn't want to project those onto his family. Not when their time here had an expiration date.

Sheila followed him to the door. "Don't worry about your dad," she said in a whisper. "You know he doesn't like change. For him, the idea of painting a mural is as overwhelming as going to space without a suit. He doesn't even know where to start." Sheila opened the door for Adam, but stood in the frame to suggest they weren't done talking.

"It's sad," Adam said. "Dad has this very attainable dream, and he won't even try?"

"You're right. It is sad. I hope he tries." Sheila rubbed the apple of Adam's cheek with her thumb. "But you should think about what you want, too. You have a handful of loops left. How are you going to spend them?"

A handful of loops left. Those words were as heavy as stones, but when Adam thought about how to spend them, there was Carly, all light and vibrant. His mom had asked him a question, and instead of shielding her from the truth, he decided to be brave, the way Carly had taught him. “I want to show Carly the constellations,” he finally said.

“That sounds really lovely.” Sheila kissed him on his forehead. “I’ve noticed a nice change in you since Carly showed up. You seem . . . I don’t know, more confident, maybe? Kind of like you have some energy again. I’m happy about that. I hope you’re making her feel the same way.”

Was he making her happy? Maybe parts of their day were spent on Carly’s desires, but he worried he’d been steering them more toward what he preferred. The planetarium, the timing of the eclipse. Had he stopped to ask Carly how she’d wanted to spend this time?

“I know you often look to your dad and me for the answers, but I’m glad you’re finding some of your own. And who knows? Maybe this wormhole isn’t an end, but a different path.”

His mom hugged him, and Adam hugged her back. He started to wonder if she was right—maybe he’d looked to his mom and dad for guidance so much that he hadn’t bothered to find himself. If time was running out, that meant he only had so much to try and course correct.

As Adam walked to the hearse, he knew he had to find Shireen. He was done holding on to the anger around the end of their marriage, and he owed her the opportunity to find happiness before the loop ended, too. Adam would always care about Shireen—she’d been part of his life for so long that it was impossible not to—but he was done trying to punish her for what happened.

That was another reason he’d wanted to have these conversations on his own. If he was going to spend more time with Carly, he wanted to do that with a clear conscience. Having a conversation with his ex was the only way forward.

The alarm on his watch signaled the start of the eclipse was near. Adam got into the car, put on his eclipse glasses and waited. He easily spied the shadow bands along the dirt road just off the driveway. If he’d had infinite loops, would he ever be able to solve their origins? He’d never know. The last eclipse had been a full minute shorter, and as the seconds ticked on, he just hoped for more time. He’d had 248 loops to resolve his issues with Shireen, to find who he was, but he’d squandered all that by remaining

firmly lodged in the past. Whatever the outcome, Adam just had to try to embrace what he wanted, and he hoped Carly wanted to be part of that, too.

When the moon slipped off the sun and Adam checked the time, it was 2:37. Ten seconds shorter. He was unsure of what that meant but ferreted the thoughts away because his priority would be finding Shireen so that the next loop, when he had his chance to see Carly, he'd be able to start with a clean slate.

Perhaps the only good thing about Adam's former best friend, Dean, was that finding him was quite easy. His vintage Mustang convertible was painted cherry-red, so Adam's mission was to find that car. He was grateful when it wasn't parked outside the cabin where he and Shireen used to live. The car wasn't outside the duplex where Dean lived, either. When he didn't spot the car around Main Street, Adam gritted his teeth. Julian wasn't a big place, but there was a possibility he could spend all night trying to track Shireen down, only to have to chat with her in the morning, which wasn't his plan. He wanted his morning with Carly to be all about her.

Dean worked as a sommelier at one of the Julian wineries. Set in the hills on over a hundred acres of land, the Lyon Vineyard was owned by a renowned chef who sold the wine exclusively from her Michelin-starred restaurant but also served those who came through the town. As Adam drove up the long, sandy driveway to the top of the hill, Dean's fiery red car practically winked at him.

Adam remembered spending most Saturday nights at the French-inspired winery with Shireen and Dean, feeling so lucky to have a best friend and a wife he loved, and that they all liked to spend time together. He was going to forgive Shireen and wish her the best, yes, but moments like these were still hard to stomach—did the affair begin here?

Adam pulled the dated and dusty hearse next to the timeless and gleaming convertible. The sooner he got this over with, the sooner he could refocus on the next few loops and how to spend them with Carly. So he straightened, marched himself to the front door and let himself in.

French pop music played, and the tasting room smelled like ripe plums. There were booths for seating as well as stools around big wine barrels, but Shireen sat near the pocket windows, which had been pulled open and looked out onto the rolling vineyard. On the table in front of her was an

open bottle of red wine and two full glasses, along with a charcuterie plate loaded with meat and cheese and almonds. Carly might like this place actually, considering all the cheese.

“Babe, you’re about to miss the sunset,” Shireen said. She turned, clocked Adam and froze. “Oh—oh my God, sorry, I thought you were Dean.”

Adam held up his hands. “I come in peace.” He walked to the table and took a seat across from Shireen.

Shireen said quietly, “Dean will be back any second.”

“This won’t take long.” Adam’s palms had begun to sweat. “I know you don’t love when I fixate on astronomy stuff—another one of my rants.”

Shireen had always playfully rolled her eyes when Adam waxed poetic about the stars. It wasn’t that she’d been unsupportive, but she’d grown less and less open to hearing Adam’s observations on the night sky. This, however, he had to share, even if Shireen didn’t believe him.

She took a sip of wine, maybe biting back her words, so Adam quickly started. “I mentioned the eclipse time was shortening?” He waited for her to nod, and when she did, he continued. “It’s over a minute shorter now. I spoke with a Caltech scientist, and she thinks this might mean the loop is about to end.”

“The loop is ending?” Shireen sat forward. “For real?”

“The thing is, we don’t know if the loop ending is good or bad.”

“Why would it be bad?” Shireen’s incredulous expression was one Adam was familiar with—one she’d given him many times in their marriage.

“Well, we don’t know what’s on the other side. We might be fine, but there’s also the possibility we won’t be.” He let those words sit.

“Why are you even telling me this?” Shireen glanced around him, as if trying to see if the real answer would present itself. “How do I know you’re not just messing with me?”

“I realized that if we only have a few loops left, I don’t want to spend them holding on to resentment. Our relationship ended a long time ago, even before the affair. You were right. I wasn’t present.” He wiped a hand across his face. As it turned out, admitting he was wrong was painful. “I just want you to know that I’m sorry for making you feel like you didn’t have a partner. I’m sorry that I took you for granted. And I’m sorry that I latched on to this anger for such a long time.”

“Thank you,” she eventually said. “I’m sorry, too. For everything.”

Adam knew what her *everything* meant—she was sorry for the Dean of it. He'd heard her say this so many times, but now it felt they were meeting at similar emotional places.

"I won't ever fully forgive you and Dean for the choices you both made, but I'm ready to move on with my life, if you are too." Adam stood up from the table, took the untouched glass of wine and held it out to Shireen. "To the end of our marriage, and the beginning of what's next."

Shireen sucked in her lower lip, then held up her glass and they clinked. Adam took a long, hearty gulp of the wine.

He wanted to find Carly. He wanted to bury his face in her thick black hair. He wanted to be with her and experience all the time they had left in the world.

"I hope you're happy, too," Shireen added.

"Thanks." Adam met her gaze and they shared a kind of goodbye. He didn't wish her anything but happiness. And moving to that place felt so much better than the acrimonious planet they'd been orbiting.

Of course, he wasn't above being petty. On his way out, Adam couldn't help kicking one of Dean's tires. Childish, yes. Satisfying? Also yes.

According to his watch, he had four more hours to find Carly before the reset. Unlike Dean, though, she didn't have a cherry-red tracker attached to her. Still, he knew enough about Carly to understand that she wouldn't be in some remote field, where the possibility of a cow encounter was strong. She wouldn't be at her dad's house, which seemed to be an off-limits zone. No, she'd most likely be in town where there were people and activities to disappear into.

Adam drove to town, got out of his car and searched the whole of Main Street. He nearly tripped over a pile of empty shoeboxes that were lined up like an enormous domino set. He was fairly certain he was offered drugs a handful of times—random pills of varying colors. And he paused to watch in wonder as a human s'more was created. One person coated in marshmallow fluff, another squirted with Hershey's chocolate syrup and still another covered in honey and sprinkled with crushed graham crackers. What would happen to the human s'more after was a true mystery he didn't want to get to the bottom of.

Adam walked into every store. He called out her name, *Carly, Carly, Carly*, but wasn't able to compete over the sound of the *Wicked* soundtrack blaring from an outdoor speaker. He went to The Last Showing theater and cupped his hands to look through the glass windows. But she wasn't there, not even a light left on.

Adam slumped against the outside of the theater, barely noticing the chaos around him because his thoughts were on their own kind of overdrive.

Is she okay?

Where the hell could she be?

What if something happened and I wasn't there to help?

He knew that the world would reset, and he'd eventually find her. But it was strange how even a few minutes without Carly felt like the longest of his life. She was a nova explosion, and he was blindsided by the force of her. Adam hadn't felt that kind of intense longing for anyone in years.

And he did long for Carly now. Maybe it was that pining that caused him to turn his head and spot her in the sea of people. Carly stood outside of an enormous pillow fort, holding a couch cushion and propping it against the side of the Sunglass Hut. Around her were a handful of children, popping in and out of the fort. Adam had started to jog toward them without even realizing it.

When he reached her, his hand landed on her shoulder and she turned. The smile fell off her face as she took in the sight of him. "I'm not your mom or Shireen, in case that wasn't obvious."

Carly picked up another pillow and carefully placed it on top of the fort.

"I know that." He wasn't sure what she was getting at. "Are you mad at me?"

"Oh, no, I'm not mad. Not anymore. I got the message that you don't want to work with me loud and clear." She angrily picked up another pillow.

"So now you're collecting pillows?"

"I'm making a pillow castle, Adam. This is my good deed for the day. I'm giving those exhausted parents over there a breather." She hitched a thumb toward the bar, where a handful of adults watched the scene with glasses of wine in their hands.

"That's kind of you," Adam said, happy to be back in their dynamic.

“What do you want? Why are you here?” Carly made it clear there was nothing friendly about them.

“I spoke to my parents and Shireen,” he started, but then, because Carly couldn’t help herself, she cut him off.

“I spoke to the mayor, and I told her everything. You’re not the only one who can speak to people.” Her hands were at her hips now and she was clearly annoyed.

“You told the mayor?” Adam repeated. “You mean about the eclipse?”

“Yeah. You don’t want to work on this anymore, so I found someone who will. Now, if you’ll excuse me, I have a moat to build.” Carly turned and, as she did, “accidentally” whacked him with the pillow.

What was happening here? This wasn’t how the situation was supposed to go. He was supposed to find Carly, tell her his feelings and then they could spend whatever time was left with each other.

“Carly, I know I was closed off earlier, but I want to work with you. More than that, I want to be with you.” He so desperately needed to touch her in that moment—to just reach out and show her how sincere he was. But she’d been on the offensive, and he had some serious defending to do. She didn’t turn around, though she seemed to be listening, so he continued. “I like you. I like you a lot, Carly. If you want to spend the rest of the loop working together, and only working together, that’s fine. I can do that. As long as I can spend my time with you, that’s all I want.”

He waited for any kind of response. But instead of Carly turning to tell him that she wanted to be *more* than colleagues, a tingling crawled up his arms. He glanced at his watch, but before he had time to see if they were about to reset, his vision went dark.

Chapter 19

Carly

Day 249

When Carly restarted in the funeral room, she immediately pushed herself up from the chair. She and Adam had unfinished business. He'd all but fled from her one minute, then acted as if he'd done nothing wrong the next. She wasn't about to let him flip-flop all over the place.

"Dad, I think my good deed for today will be standing up for myself." She tapped the lid of the coffin as a farewell, then hurried down the aisle of chairs.

When she came to the hall, she nearly collided with Shireen. "Oh, sorry," she mumbled.

Shireen gave her a kind look. "Don't stress. We don't have time for all that now, right?"

Carly stilled. Adam really had told Shireen, then. "Right."

Shireen nodded, then headed for the exit. Carly glanced to the office, where Adam emerged, wringing his hands.

"Can I just say something before you let me have it?" he asked her.

"I don't know. Is it going to annoy me?" Carly asked back.

"It's not that I didn't want you with me this last loop."

Adam must think she was truly gullible to use a line like that. She'd let him know where he stood. "That's the thing about leaving someone behind. The someone doesn't feel great afterward. I'm the someone, to be clear."

“I get that.” Adam tucked a strand of red hair behind his ears and she had to stop herself from reaching out to feel the softness of it. “I’m scared, okay? I don’t know what the eclipse changing means for us. I’m scared of just disappearing into nothing, but I’m mostly scared of losing you. When I went to my parents’ place, I didn’t want to sugarcoat anything for them, and I didn’t want you to hear how terrified I am. Because you’re holding it together. You have hope, and I love that about you.”

Carly instantly blushed, which was annoying. He’d said he *loved* something about *her*. She wanted to be annoyed with Adam, but that was sweet.

“I didn’t want to bring you into the mess that is my brain,” he added.

He was proactively apologizing. On the one hand, Carly could milk this situation for a bit. Really let Adam stew in the idea that she was livid. But then again, they might not have much time left. She’d already mucked up the ending with her father; did she really want to spend the rest of wormhole eternity beating herself up for her final words to Adam?

“First of all, that’s maybe the longest you’ve ever spoken without stopping. It was impressive,” she said.

“Thank you.”

“Second, I ate probably the equivalent of two pounds of cheese yesterday. I was a mess. I was miserable, actually. And yes, it’s because you left me behind, and I thought you hated me, basically.” She crossed her arms and gave him an even crosser look. She wouldn’t milk the situation, but she wouldn’t make it easy, either. He should know that he hurt her feelings, at the very least.

“I don’t hate you,” he quickly said.

“Just mildly dislike me, then?” She echoed a conversation they’d had early on.

“Something like that,” he replied with a smile.

He walked toward her, all smooth and confident, slipped his hand behind her head and began to bring her toward him.

But Carly still had the niggling feeling about Shireen. “Wait,” she said. “Did you and Shireen . . . ?”

He rubbed his thumb across her cheek. “I told her that I understood our relationship had been over for a long time. Long before the affair. And that I was moving on with my life.”

“Do you mean that, though?”

“I do. And Shireen told me she hopes I find happiness, too.” Adam inched closer to Carly, then ghosted the words across her lips, “I think I have.”

Carly exhaled a shaky breath and was surprised by how relieved she was by those words.

“There’s another thing,” he said. “The eclipse shortened yesterday, but just by ten seconds.”

“So what do you think this means . . .?” She drifted off. Was the eclipse still shortening because of her Together Theory? Was it tied to the shadow bands, like Adam thought?

“I don’t know, but to be honest, what I realized last loop was that if all we have is the time left, then I want to make the most of it—with you.” He licked his lips. “And more importantly, you should spend these days however you want. So, I will leave you alone if you tell me to. But the last loop really opened my eyes to what I want, and it’s you.”

Adam was choosing her? She’d reset ready to fight, but he’d managed to get right to her big feelings before she’d had time for any of that anger to fester. And maybe Adam’s superpower of knowing how to calm her was why she felt drawn to say, “I want to be with you, too.”

Adam closed the distance between them and kissed her. Carly let out a tiny gasp of excitement as he nipped her lower lip and wove his fingers through her hair to massage her neck.

There was no Shireen. No eclipse. No loop to escape. Just this moment where Carly was Adam’s, and Adam was Carly’s.

“Let’s get out of here,” Adam said as his thumb traced a line across her shoulder.

When they got to his car, Adam opened the door and Carly tucked herself into the seat. This was like so many of the loops she’d spent with him, except now they were together. Dating? Who knew? But they were a thing.

“We’ve spent all this time participating in one giant science experiment, which obviously makes me happy,” Adam said as he started the car engine. “But you mentioned you haven’t been writing. I just wonder if there’s some way to bring that back?”

Carly was sure her entire body had turned red from the heat of this attention squarely on her. “I don’t know that I want to spend the last loops, or hours, we have working. We could be trying to solve the eclipse or doing *anything* else.”

“But writing isn’t work, right? I mean, it *is* in the sense that it’s what you want to be doing long-term. But also, I imagine you have fun when you do it? The way I look to the sky to escape.”

Yes, writing was Carly’s escape. Had been, at least. She could drift in and out of fictitious worlds, characters and scenes. She could transport herself into someone else’s thoughts to avoid her own. She turned to writing to process certain things in her own life. And, to Adam’s point, it didn’t feel like work. Putting together the pieces of a script felt as satisfying as finishing an actual puzzle. Getting to step back and look at the finished product gave her a sense of pride and excitement. Because once a script was done, she was that much closer to having it turned into a movie.

“I haven’t written in a long time.” Not since her dad died. She hadn’t sat down at her laptop since the phone call from the hospital, asking her to confirm that she was Bruce’s next of kin.

“Look, I’m not going to force you to do something that makes you uncomfortable. But I’m just wondering if sitting still with your thoughts might help you reconnect with who you were before the loop,” Adam continued.

“Didn’t we try sitting still at the library?”

“You and I both know scientific research isn’t the same as being creative.”

Maybe she could start slow. “I don’t have a script I’m working on that’s really speaking to me.” Carly drummed her fingers on the armrest.

“Where do the ideas come from?” Adam’s knuckles ran up, then down her arm. “Do they just pop into your head?”

She was having a hard time focusing; his knuckles caused yummy friction across her skin. She cleared her throat and said, “I have these brainstorming exercises I do. They’re kind of ridiculous, actually.”

“I like ridiculous. Specifically seeing you being ridiculous.” Adam gave a side smile. “Should we do one? The incentive being that I don’t have a creative bone in my body and will likely humiliate myself.”

Carly considered her options. She could continue to deflect and hope that Adam moved on to something else. Or she could just embrace that today would be about her. After all, she needed comfort. He needed comfort. The five-senses brainstorm was usually just that.

“Okay,” she acquiesced. “Let’s go find a cozy spot.”

The spot they found was an apple orchard down the road. For all the loops Carly had spent in Julian, she hadn't bothered to spend a day in one of its iconic orchards. She was a city mouse, unsure of what to do in a field. Sure, there was the obvious act of reaching up and eating an apple from a tree. But how many times could a person do that? Twice? 249 times?

"You said you wanted cozy, picturesque." Adam swept his hand to the view around them. "There's a spot just up through the trees that has a great lookout point. We could sit and see the valley below?"

"Yeah, that sounds obnoxiously idyllic. Let's do it." Carly began to follow Adam up the small hill. "You sure do seem to know your way around an apple orchard. Is this what people in Julian do for fun, normally?"

Adam shielded his eyes against the sunlight as he said, "Dean used to work here in the summer when we were in high school. I'd come visit on his lunch break and we'd sit up here and shoot the shit."

This was maybe the first time Carly had heard Dean's name mentioned without hateful vitriol attached. She wondered about that. "Must be weird to not be able to talk to your best friend anymore," she said.

"I still get these urges to text him. Like, if I'm reminded of something from childhood, or even now, being here . . ." He drifted off. "It's just harder with Dean, because so much of my life and my memories involve him."

They got to the clearing, and Adam pointed out to the valley. When Carly looked at the stretch of green hills dotted with trees, and the sun lighting all of it in a glow, it was almost impossible to imagine any of it was real. "This looks like a simulation of a countryside," she said. "Do you think there's a glitch in the matrix? Maybe we're just all looping because someone's video game is faulty? It's a much better option than, you know, the wormhole."

"Can't argue that." Adam sat on the grass, brought his knees up and wrapped his arms around them as he stared out. "So, what do we do now? We have the setting. Do we fantasize about a thriller in an orchard?"

Carly raised her brows. "Not the worst pitch I've ever heard. But no, this is called the five-senses brainstorm. We use sight, smell, taste, touch and what we hear to think of story ideas."

"Gotcha," he said with the kind of tone that conveyed he very much did not get it.

And that was okay, because Carly found she was excited to explain it. "So if we start with sight, we can look out at this view and think, *Who owns*

this farm? What kind of a person might we want to imagine has a view like this? Could be anything, like, maybe this is a hundred-acre estate held by a wealthy family who just spends their summers here. Or maybe it's a farmer who's had this land for generations, and they're trying to make enough money to not have to sell it off."

"Or maybe someone inherited it? After a family member passed away?" Adam suggested.

"Exactly." Carly winced at the reminder of her dad and the theater she'd inherited from him. She changed the subject. "For smell, the apple trees add a kind of sweetness to the air. It reminds me of summer in Los Angeles. The figs fall off the trees and get sticky on the concrete, and the smell is this mix of like, dirt and jam."

Adam let out a huff and she glanced at him. "What, is this too touchy-feely?"

"No, it's just . . ." He trailed off, then shook his head. "This smell reminds me of how Shireen and I started dating, actually."

"How did you?"

"It's too embarrassing to share."

"Well, then you must." Carly grinned.

He rolled his eyes but began to talk. "I was in high school. Senior year. Every fall our school went on a field trip to Crowley's Corner Farms, which is one of the apple orchards here. Part of the field trip is learning about farming and apple production. They have all of these ladders and tractors and things around but tell you not to actually get on them. It's not safe."

"And you always follow the rules," Carly said.

"I do love rules." Adam gave her a small smile. "But Shireen was standing near me and mentioned to her friend that she wished she could reach the apples at the top of the tree. I was trying to impress her. So I decided I would climb this really tall ladder they had to get her some."

"That's sweet." Carly's expression softened. "I'm worried about the *but* that's coming."

"*But* something happened. Maybe a gust of wind. Or the rumbling of the school bus as it came up the path. I'll never really know, but I fell." He used a hand to reenact falling from a great height. "I went through the tree limbs, which shielded my fall considerably. The doctors said I was lucky I didn't break anything. That's when Shireen and I started dating, though."

"Did you get her an apple?" Carly asked.

He chuckled. "I did, actually!"

"An apple hero," she said with a smile. "I might have to borrow that story for a screenplay. I never had a grand romantic gesture like that in high school. I didn't even have a date to the prom. I just stayed home and watched movies."

Sometimes Carly worried that not enough had happened in her own life to be interesting on the page. She'd grown up in Burbank and hadn't moved anywhere else. She'd gone to school at USC, just a quick drive away. She'd lost her mom at a young enough age where she only wondered what could've been. She spent her time bartending, or on her laptop. It wasn't until the loop when she'd finally said "fuck it" and just spent her days doing whatever whim suited her best.

What if she didn't have enough story to ever make a movie? What if all she had was recycling other people's experiences, instead of growing from her own?

They'd both gone quiet. And that quiet made her self-conscious. "I wish I could just climb into your thoughts and hear what you're thinking," she said honestly. "Most of the time I have absolutely no idea if you're here with me or out in the stars. And you're always so damn quiet, Adam."

She waited, and he looked at her with an expression so irritated she worried she'd overstepped.

"I go quiet because I keep getting distracted by that plump little mouth of yours." He bit his own lip, but stared straight at hers.

Carly knew she was breathing, but also . . . was she?

"You think I'm distracting?" She traced a fingertip along the line of his impossibly high cheekbone. When she got close to his lips they parted on instinct, and she drew across the line of them, too. "Guess you better do something about it."

Then he kissed her without any warning. Hard at first, but his lips softened as his tongue found hers.

She held on to his hand. "I'm ready, Adam. I think we should, before . . ."

Before the eclipse vanishes and we do, too, was what she thought but didn't say. Carly didn't want to lose him, or the opportunity to have all of him before their time ran out.

Without asking, Carly slipped her dress up and over her head. Adam's expression was more shocked than anything, which she really enjoyed. So

she decided to unclasp her bra, too, and his breath caught as she let her breasts fall out.

“Carly, you’re cold,” Adam said. His hands traveled up the length of her legs, hips and the sides of her breasts. Her nipples pebbled against his touch.

“This can be the touch part of the brainstorm.” She leaned back to put her body on further display. “What kind of character would feel like this?”

She grabbed his hand and helped him cup her breast.

“The kind of character I want to touch . . . ?” He laughed, but still played with her nipples. “I told you, I’m not creative.”

“Maybe if you explore the taste part of the brainstorm, that might spark something?”

She guided his hand between her legs to show him how wet she already was. Adam let his fingers smooth over the cotton of her panties, then slid them off and down her legs. He let out a deep exhale as he took in the sight of her.

Adam gently eased Carly onto her back, and she felt the cool blades of grass on her skin. Then he positioned himself between her knees and buried his face in her. Her head fell back and she let out a loud, “Oh!”

“You taste so fucking good.” He sucked her clit into his mouth and she whimpered. He dipped back to her pussy and lapped at the opening, making her legs tighten.

“Do you want to come on my face?” he asked. When he looked up for her answer, she pulled him up and brought his lips to hers.

Because while she loved being eaten out just as much as the next girl, Carly was also ready to be filled by him.

Adam took the hint and quickly tried to take off his shirt, but forgot he had a blazer on top and got tangled. Carly laughed as she helped him out of his clothes. When she brought her hands around his back and dug her fingernails into his shoulders, he pressed his chest to hers. His kisses became more intense with the added heat of their bodies. Carly reached down to his pants, fumbled with the button and then slipped the zipper down in one long and loud slide.

She’d fantasized about what Adam’s dick might look like—long and lean, like him? Thick and veined? She’d felt how hard he’d been on several occasions, so she knew whatever she saw would be eager to please. But

when he pushed his pants the rest of the way down, she was absolutely shocked.

“It’s red,” she said without thinking.

“Carpet matches the drapes.” Adam leaned his forehead against hers and said in a lower voice, “Tell me what you want.”

“I want you,” she said into his ear. “If that wasn’t clear.”

His lips were on hers and his hands were in her hair, then on her clit, almost unsure of where to start. But Carly was impatient and she reached for the length of him. Adam let out a groan as she squeezed him in her palm, then released. She did that a few more times to gently pump his shaft as she guided him closer to her entrance. Once there, he teased her by putting his tip over her wet clit and rubbing in light circles.

“We can stop,” he offered.

But she grabbed him and eased the head of him in, then slowly back out. She looked up to make sure he heard her when she said, “We are not stopping until I come all over you.” She squeezed him in her hand for emphasis, and he growled. She positioned him at the edge of her entrance, then eased him in enough to get started.

“I don’t have—” He looked around, as if condoms would fall from the sky. Although, stranger things had happened.

“I’ve been on the pill. We’re in a time loop. And I want this. So while I appreciate the safety precautions, I think we can carry on.”

Adam bit his lower lip as he held Carly’s gaze and eased into her, then slid back out, and in, one inch at a time.

But she wanted all of him. To move as one. To feel consumed. And instinct told Carly to wrap her legs tighter around Adam. When she did, he managed to push even deeper inside until he hit the very edge. Her body shuddered as he hit that spot over and over again.

While he was taking notice of what she liked, she couldn’t help clocking how the gentle scrape of her nails up his thigh made him tighten, too. Adam panted into her shoulder when she reached for his ass, then said, “No, I need the nails again.”

Carly’s eyes flicked to Adam’s as she gently clawed her way up his thigh. Then he rocked into her, slow and deep. She let out a moan as he brought his cock all the way out, then dove back in. He cupped her ass and rocked harder and faster into her.

“You feel so fucking good. So fucking good, Carly.”

Her body began to tense around him. As if sensing her closeness, Adam dipped his mouth to her breast and sucked on her nipple. And then, as he moved into her again his mouth found her ear and he told her, “Come for me.”

Those words, and the friction and his arms surrounding her finally sent an orgasm crashing through. Carly couldn’t manage to tell him she was coming, but as he went farther to touch that most sensitive spot, she knew he understood.

“Holy shit,” she said plainly, with no hang-ups about it. The man had made her toes curl, and he deserved to know.

With her legs still wrapped around him and his hard length inside, he picked her up and flipped them over, positioning them so that he was underneath and she was on top. “I want to see all of you,” he said.

Carly was boneless, but nodded as she rocked back and let Adam’s cock sink into her again. Then she lifted her hips up and down, sliding on him easily. Little aftershocks of pleasure sparked each time he buried himself in her. And when he grabbed her and pulled her down hard on him . . . that nearly sent her over again. But she reached behind and gently tugged on his balls. He groaned, and she felt him tighten in her hand.

When he released, Adam’s eyes briefly pinched closed and the moan he let out seemed to emerge from the depths of him. He shuddered and gave her a half smile. She licked her lips, knowing she’d never get enough, not in this timeline or any other.

Carly curled her body next to Adam’s, and he wrapped his long arm around her shoulder to pull her in close. She listened to his breaths even out, and his heart rate slow. He was sticky with sweat, and so was she. Carly wasn’t sure she’d ever felt so aware of her body, which tingled from all of the places Adam had touched her.

“Sorry for distracting you,” she eventually said.

He laughed a low and deep chuckle that went through her. At some point, his watch beeped, and he frowned as he glanced down at the thing, then toward the sky. “The eclipse,” he muttered as he sat up and rifled through the pockets of his jacket to find their glasses. He handed a pair to Carly and slipped his on, too.

“Is it okay for me to time it?” he belatedly asked.

“Yeah, I want to know.” The unsaid thing was that Carly wanted to know how much time they had left together. Would there be any at all?

“There.” He pointed to the shadow bands flitting across the ground in front of them. “Hard to imagine not seeing them every day.”

What was harder for Carly to imagine was not seeing Adam every loop. As the eclipse started, Carly quietly put on her clothes and Adam buttoned up his shirt. His gaze was trained on the sky, but she couldn’t bear to glance up. She and Adam were just getting to the good parts. Time had not been on her side in so many parts of her life—time with her mom, time with her dad, timing with work—so why would now be any different?

She sensed Adam glancing at his watch, then slipping the glasses off. She looked over at him.

“No change,” he said.

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Chapter 20

Adam

Day 250

Adam's office came into focus as he reset—the too-bright lighting and built-in bookshelves. The desk with the framed photo of his wedding day with Shireen.

His hand on Shireen's shoulder.

But no, there was no shoulder. His hand was suspended in midair. There was no Shireen. She wasn't there. He poked his head out the office door. "Shireen?" he called out.

Maybe he'd somehow missed her leaving? But no, that wasn't possible. He would've felt her leave his grip.

Then there were footsteps as Carly appeared in the doorway of the funeral room. Carly was here, but Shireen wasn't . . .

"Why are you frowning at me?" She adjusted her glasses. "I thought we'd had fun this last loop."

Carly walked toward Adam, straightened the front of his blazer, and then looked up at him with those thick lashes. Which reminded him of all the fun they *did* have—in the orchard, in the booth of Moms while they ate apple pie for dinner and she stroked him through his pants, then in the tree house where she'd removed his belt while he showed her Orion's belt . . .

He began to lean toward her mouth, but then remembered the very troubling fact that Shireen hadn't restarted with him. "Wait, Carly." He took

hold of her hand, which had begun to reach for his belt, once again. “Shireen is gone,” he said.

Carly took a step back. “Okay,” she said in a tone that suggested she wasn’t totally following.

He tried again. “Shireen is *gone*. As in, she isn’t *here*. She didn’t restart with us.” And then the reality punched him in the gut. She hadn’t restarted with them. That was . . . a problem.

“Shireen is gone?” Carly asked.

“Gone,” he repeated.

How was it possible that she’d just vanished? People *didn’t* just stop the loop. Everyone, as far as he knew, restarted in the same spot.

Carly’s eyes widened. “Oh my God,” she said. “What if Shireen somehow got out? Like, maybe she slipped through the wormhole? What if other people are missing, too?”

It stood to reason that if Shireen’s loop had changed, other people’s had as well. That was possible, Adam told himself. He wondered *where* Shireen was if not at the funeral home. Was she in a waiting room somewhere? Was she okay? What if she *had* gone through the wormhole? Could she ever come back?

“Adam,” Carly said.

He managed to break out of his thoughts and look at her.

“You have that same look as when we saw Shireen and Dean in town,” she said. “I know you don’t like to talk about things, but you can talk to me. You can tell me what you’re thinking and, maybe by doing that, I can help. Because my ADHD brain will create well over a hundred different scenarios of what could be behind door number Adam, but chances are none of them will be correct.”

She rubbed her hand up and down his arm and, to his shock, he began to speak.

“Missing,” he said. “That was a scary word to hear. I don’t want to be with Shireen anymore, but I also certainly don’t want her to go missing.”

“Of course you don’t,” Carly said. “Shireen is going to be okay.”

“But what if she isn’t?” He was terrified, because if Shireen was missing . . . who could be next?

“Why don’t we go into town.” Carly grabbed a hold of Adam’s hand and started to lead him toward the front door. “Maybe Shireen just restarted

somewhere else, like at your old house. And we need to see if anyone else is missing, right?”

“Right,” he said. “Missing.”

“Not *missing*.” Carly waved a hand in front of her own face to try to clear the word from the air. “I’m sure she’s fine. Seriously. Let’s just go into town and find out if anyone has seen her, okay?”

When they parked at the top of Main Street, Adam fisted a hand through his hair. He hadn’t pictured spending the day this way. He’d wanted to make the most of his time with Carly, but now they were searching for his ex-wife.

And he was scared of what they might find, because he had a sinking feeling that Shireen hadn’t restarted somewhere else. His loop resets were so intricately tied with Shireen that he felt connected to her, even when they weren’t together. And this reset he couldn’t physically or emotionally feel her—their connection seemed severed.

“We’re going to figure this out,” Carly said as she unbuckled her seat belt. “Trust me.”

And he found that he did. So he got out of the car, too.

They were only an hour into the loop as they walked down Main Street. What were they looking for, exactly? People screaming for help? Missing Persons signs being tacked up? Adam wasn’t sure.

All appeared to be normal as they made their way down the sidewalk. Well, *normal* in that enormous bags of flour were being poured out in the middle of the street and people were making snow angels in the white powder.

“Is it possible that only Shireen is missing?” Carly asked.

“Maybe others are, too, but no one has noticed,” he hedged.

“Totally. But since no one else seems to be ringing the alarm, perhaps we can assume it’s just Shireen. And if it’s just Shireen, maybe she restarted with Dean?”

That would certainly make Adam feel better, if it were true. Though it would be equally confusing to find a reason as to why. “That’s possible,” he acquiesced.

“We could go find Dean so we can rule it out?” She spoke so gently and with such care that it almost broke his heart in half.

“Carly, you don’t have to do this with me.” Even his hands were unsure in this situation as he reached for her, but then pulled back. “I think it’s a lot

to expect you to help find my ex. I wouldn't want to put you in that position."

Carly took Adam's hand, and his fingers instinctively flexed against hers. "I know I don't have to, but this is important. I'm worried about her, too," she said.

"Okay." Adam swallowed down his fear and unease and tried to harness some fortitude. "I know where to find him."

Since the affair and the start of the loop, Adam had driven by Dean's fifties bungalow rental a handful of times. Sometimes he wanted to see if Shireen's car was parked there. Other times, he drove by with the intent of stopping and angrily confronting his former best friend. This time, though, he actually got out and stood in front of the stucco building. Adam walked across the mosaic tiles that led a path through the garden and up to Dean's front door. Shireen had always loved those tiles. So when Adam knocked, he sincerely hoped that affinity had somehow transported her to Dean's place.

It was only Dean who answered, though, in a white T-shirt with the sleeves rolled up and high-waisted trousers, a young Marlon Brando-esque look he'd perfected over the past few years. Adam's jaw clenched as Dean's smile instantly faded. The only great part of seeing Dean was also seeing his mullet—the one he'd insisted was cool and was now stuck with, thanks to the time loop. It was a pure delight to know he might have to spend eternity with that thing. Well, potentially *not* eternity.

"Oh, hey." Dean sucked in his top lip, maybe wisely stopping himself from saying anything further.

Hey? That was all Dean had to say to Adam, just *hey*? Not something more along the lines of *Wow, it was deeply uncool of me to sleep with your wife and destroy over two decades of friendship. Sorry about that, man.*

No, this was Dean, and of course the only thing he wanted to tell Adam was *hey*.

Adam didn't answer. He hadn't spoken to his former friend since the loop began. He fought the warring words in his head—simultaneously telling him to flee while also urging him to throw a verbal punch. He didn't plan to insult Dean, though. Because for the first time in a long time, Adam was in a much better spot than Dean.

“Is Shireen here?” Adam asked.

Dean frowned. “No, she hasn’t shown up yet.”

He looked past Adam, as if searching for her, with an expression that could only result from genuine concern.

“She didn’t reset with us this morning,” Adam said gently.

Dean shifted his weight as he considered that. “What do you mean?”

Which is when Carly decided to come forward. “Hey, I’m Carly. I reset with Shireen and Adam every loop in the funeral home. I can confirm that this loop, Shireen wasn’t there.”

“Where the hell is she?” The edginess in Dean’s voice was jarring.

For the first few weeks after the loop started, Adam had worried daily about whether or not Shireen was okay. Without the help of cell phones, he had no way of reaching her once she left the funeral home. She was ostensibly with Dean, he’d supposed, but they’d never spent twenty-four hours apart before; they’d always managed to see each other within a day. And the look Dean had was the same one Adam had so often seen on himself, at least initially.

“We don’t know.” Adam was suddenly hot, either from the midday sun or Dean’s glare. “We walked through town, but no one seemed to be exhibiting signs that anything was different. There could be others, but we’ll have to wait and see.”

“Wait and see?” Dean reached for keys on a coffee table near the entrance. “I’m not going to just wait for Shireen to come back. I have to find her.” Dean breezed past Adam and Carly to the cherry-red convertible covered by a tarp in the driveway.

Adam followed and helped him take off the tarp. He had at least a dozen memories of the two of them stalled on the side of some road, popping the trunk and the hood to try to troubleshoot whatever was going wrong with this ancient beast of a car that Dean loved. The car went with the whole lifestyle he was going for, though, and Dean had always been big on how his life looked to everyone else.

“I would do the same thing,” Adam said as Dean got into the car. “We’ll keep looking for her, too.”

Dean attempted to turn the engine, which had always been a bit temperamental. “I know you came to the tasting room the other loop. Shireen told me.”

Adam straightened. "I'm glad. Secrets aren't great in a relationship. I would know."

Dean looked away from him then, as if unable to accept that *he* had been the secret. Dean kept his eyes on the steering wheel as he said, "I'm sorry you found out the way you did."

Adam waited for more. Would there be groveling? A promise to give Adam his mullet trimmings if he forgave him? But no, Dean wasn't like Adam in the sense that he, apparently, didn't feel the need to explain himself. Adam had thankfully moved past the point of wanting anything substantial from Dean, and what a lovely shift that was.

"I just wanted to say that I know Shireen will return." Adam had hope—maybe Carly was rubbing off on him. "We're going to find her."

"How do you know that?" Dean looked up, his eyes red rimmed, as if holding something back. Whether it was for their friendship, or Shireen, or both, it wasn't really any of Adam's business.

"It's a feeling," Adam said. Wow, now he was even starting to sound like Carly. *A feeling?* He didn't work on feelings, but he also couldn't deny that he did have a feeling about this situation, and the fact that Shireen wasn't gone.

Dean's grip on the wheel tightened. "I hope you're right," he said.

Adam waited a beat. He'd broken the long silence between them. He'd been the bigger person and had a conversation with Dean, releasing the friendship ghost that had hovered over his head for months. And seeing Dean like this, so lacking in remorse, confirmed what his mom and dad had said: Dean wasn't his friend.

Adam took a big breath in and said words that he very much meant. "Bye, Dean."

When Adam turned, Dean's engine finally kicked in and the wheels sputtered against gravel as the car sped down the road. Adam walked back to Carly, who waited for him at the hearse.

"You okay?" she asked.

He gritted his teeth. He was as okay as could be in a situation like this. "I will be," he said.

Carly gave a subtle nod, like she wasn't going to push him but was listening, which he appreciated.

"Okay, so Shireen's not with Dean, and from what we can tell, no one else is missing." Carly counted the two facts out on her fingers. "You're

going to hate this suggestion.”

“Don’t say we have to tell Rick.” Adam pinched the bridge of his nose.

“We absolutely have to tell Rick, yes, and probably Dr. Song.” Carly patted Adam on the back, and then gently shoved him toward the driver’s-side door. “Look, I know they’re both different sides of a fucked-up coin, but they’re basically the only other people who care about what’s going on in the loop. If anyone will have ideas on how to bring Shireen back, it’s them.”

Adam rolled his eyes and let out a disgruntled sigh, because Carly might just be right. And they didn’t have any better options.

“You know, maybe this is a little blip. She might be back next loop.”

Carly opened the passenger-side door and slid in.

“She might.” Adam got into the car and when he turned the key the cold air-conditioning sent welcome air to his face. “Let’s go find them, but Dr. Song first, please.”

“Sounds good.” Carly buckled herself in. “Shireen will be okay.”

Adam gave a tight nod. Shireen had to be okay, because the alternative was that he’d spent the last 250 loops wishing he didn’t have to see her, and it had finally come true.

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Chapter 21

Carly

For as long as Carly had been in Julian, she realized that she hadn't bothered to explore many areas outside Main Street. Adam drove them across dirt roads bordered by well-maintained farms, quiet streets with little houses and trampolines in the front yard, red barns and ancient trees that guarded the sides of the road.

The town was scenic, as her dad had claimed. Outside of the madness, there were pockets of calm. Maybe Bruce had liked this change of pace; maybe *this* was a kind of retirement for him.

She glanced over to the driver's seat, where Adam had both hands carefully placed at the ten and two positions on the wheel, and said, "This has been an intense morning. You want to talk about it?" Carly was freaked the fuck out about Shireen vanishing, so she couldn't imagine how Adam felt.

But Adam wasn't someone who readily showed their emotions, and his expression remained neutral. "I'm just trying to focus on collecting evidence, and then we can see what this means."

But that didn't really answer her question. Carly supposed he was compartmentalizing his feelings. Maybe that was helping him get through this, and she'd done the same with her dad.

"It's okay to be scared." She almost put a hand on his shoulder, but thought that would be too touchy-feely for him. "I would understand."

Adam's jaw clenched as he turned the car down another side street, driving them around Julian in search of the Caltech van. "There's nothing to be scared of," he said simply. "We don't have all the information."

And she let it go, because it was clear he probably *was* scared and trying his very best to hide that. She refocused on the road, which is when she spotted a white panel van with a blue logo parked in front of a bungalow cottage. "You said Dr. Song drives a panel van? That's our scientist or someone who really loves storage."

"Scientist," Adam said with relief, parking the hearse directly behind it.

When they got out of the car, they walked the steps up to the bungalow and Carly rang the doorbell. "Can't wait to see Dr. Optimism. She's super fun."

Heather didn't answer, though. Instead, two dads and a toddler peered out the door. One held the toddler and the other a bubble machine.

"Can we help you?" one of the men asked.

"Umm, we're looking for Heather," Adam began to say.

"Bore-ING," the toddler said, and the dad holding her laughed.

"Sorry, she tells it like it is."

"Is a woman named Heather here?" Carly tried again.

"The only woman here is this little lady, and she wants bubbles." As if on cue, bubbles began to float out of the machine.

"Good luck?" the dad said as he closed the door and locked it behind them.

Carly scratched her head, but Adam was already heading down the steps and going to the house next door. "Wait up! I have short legs!" she called out as she hurried to catch up.

When Adam knocked at the next house, it wasn't Heather who answered, but Rick. Carly stopped halfway up the pavers in confusion.

Rick, though, didn't so much as pause when he said, "What the hell are you two doing here?"

"We're looking for Dr. Song." Adam's hands found his hips and he rocked back on his heels. "Aren't you supposed to be checking the perimeter?"

"The perimeter comes later." Rick took the worn map from his pocket and slapped it against his thigh. "Heather and I are working on something much bigger. What do you want with her, anyways?"

There was too much to explain. Carly wasn't interested in having this back-and-forth with Rick. "Can we come in? I really need to use the bathroom."

Adam gave her a grateful look, and she offered a small smile in return. She had his back. They would figure this out together.

Rick opened the door and they stepped inside. "This house has a bidet, in case you're into that kind of thing, which I am," Rick said.

Carly ignored the wink he gave her, mouthed a thank-you, walked to the bathroom and locked the door behind her.

For the first time that loop, Carly finally exhaled. She hadn't had a moment to herself since the reset. She'd been excited to spend the day with Adam. Yes, the loop was threatening to potentially kill them all, but she *liked* Adam. He *liked* her. That was something real she wanted to hold on to. And a scene had come to her as they left the orchard—a fall meet-cute at a ranch—that she was itching to put to paper.

But Shireen was still missing, and obviously they had to figure out what had happened. The past few hours were fueled by pure adrenaline, and seeing Adam upset had twisted Carly's stomach into knots. She didn't want him to know how scared she was, though. But alone in this bathroom, she could run the water, shove her face into the hand towel and scream, which is exactly what she did.

When she finished, she washed her hands and the feeling that she was spinning out of control off, then unlocked the door. She had to be strong for Adam. She would do this for him.

"How did you and Dr. Song start working together?" Adam asked.

"Probably the same way you and Movie Girl found each other," Rick said.

Carly rolled her eyes at *Movie Girl*. If she was Movie Girl, Rick was Flamingo Man.

"We want the hell out of this loop," Rick continued.

Then Heather's voice came through. "Adam? I had a feeling we'd reconnect."

When Dr. Song walked into the room she carried coffees, one for her and one for Rick. "I was looking for a clear field to examine the eclipse, and that's when I ran into Rick and his map. We started talking and figured it couldn't hurt to combine efforts. He has a history of Julian that I just don't."

“And she’s blowing my mind with the science stuff, let me tell you,” Rick chuckled.

“I do wonder if Rick’s bubble theory could have legs.” Heather sipped the coffee. “We’re retracing his last few loop steps to see if he possibly punctured something that’s releasing that negative mass we need to keep the wormhole open.”

Carly started to fidget. They’d spent half the day trying to find Dr. Song, and now here she was, but Adam hadn’t said a damn word. She decided to step in and do the heavy lifting for him. “I think it’s great that everyone loves to geek out on the eclipse, but we didn’t come here for that. We came to tell you something.”

Heather gestured toward the living room area, which had a large sectional sofa and two armchairs surrounding a brick fireplace. Carly took a seat, and Adam sat next to her; their legs briefly touching distracted her.

Rick sat in an armchair and said, “Go ahead, then, spit it out.”

Adam’s lips had thinned, and he took a deep breath before launching in. “Okay, so every time I reset, I’m in the funeral home. I’m always standing in my office with Shireen, my ex. When I reset in the room, I am always touching her shoulder. But she just never showed up. We don’t know where she is, actually.”

Dr. Song put the mug down on a side table and squinted at Adam. “She disappeared?”

“It seems so,” Carly said. Her leg anxiously bounced and Adam’s palm landed on her knee to soothe her. Some of the tension left just from his touch.

Rick leaned forward. “You’re sure?”

Adam nodded.

“Fascinating.” Dr. Song twisted the star pendant on a long silver chain around her neck.

“Fascinating?” Adam’s nails flexed against Carly’s knee.

“I think we’re both a bit freaked out, like, if she’s gone . . .” Carly carefully chose her words, fully aware that Adam was listening to all of them. “Does that mean other people can just disappear, too? And when will they come back?”

“If they come back,” Heather corrected her. Carly noted the wince from Adam immediately.

“She’ll come back,” Adam said, though it was clear he was telling himself that more than anything.

“Well, this doesn’t exactly hurt the wormhole theory.” Dr. Song looked to Rick for validation.

“She’s obsessed with this wormhole thing,” Rick said. “I keep telling her we’re all chess pieces, and the game players want us to think we’re in danger. But I’m not worried. Just got to keep poking around for that door.”

Heather rolled her eyes at that.

“Wait, what do you mean it doesn’t hurt the wormhole theory?” Adam crossed his arms, paying close attention.

“There was no time change in the eclipse,” Heather said, “which suggests something about the loop stabilized enough that the wormhole didn’t need to shrink in on itself. It didn’t collapse any further. But perhaps that’s because it gained more exotic matter, more of that negative mass it needs to stay open.”

“Are you suggesting Shireen is the negative mass?” Adam asked.

“It would appear so, yes.”

Carly felt sick. “Are you saying the loop is, like, *eating* people to stay stable? What would stop it from just decimating this whole place?”

“I imagine nothing would.” Heather drummed her fingers along the arm of the chair. “Unless we found a different kind of negative mass to feed it.”

“We came here for help,” Adam said, desperation clawing through his voice. “How do we bring her back?”

Heather and Rick exchanged a look, like they shared some secret apocalyptic language. Then Rick said, “We’ve been talking about this some ourselves—what to do in the event of the unthinkable. I think a person up and vanishing is tipping us into the unthinkable.”

Rick, to his credit, didn’t look excited by this fact; unlike Heather, he seemed sympathetic to Adam’s cause. “It’s like in *Beaches*, when Barbara Hershey finds out she has cancer . . .” Rick began to tear up.

Heather gave Rick a knowing series of pats on the back as she said, “We don’t have a way to bring Shireen back. But someone else might. We have to tell the rest of Julian.”

Chapter 22

Adam

Adam was overwhelmed. He wasn't used to the kind of excitement that comes from trying to solve a time loop, let alone bring someone back from a potential wormhole. Particularly when that someone happened to be his ex-wife.

He very much wanted to get off the roller coaster that was his life. However, he had no choice but to secure his seat belt and hold on to the safety bar at all times. He also had no choice but to follow behind the Caltech van as they headed into town.

"At least we don't have to ride in the panel van." Carly tried to lighten the mood. "The only time I get into vans is if a stranger offers me candy."

He knew she was just trying to keep him calm, but he also sensed *she* was going through a lot. So he joked back, "Who knows? Maybe they do have candy in there."

Carly bit her lip. "We don't have to do this, you know. We could tell Rick and Heather to shove it and keep looking for Shireen on our own."

Adam knew she was right, but he also knew that he was desperate to fix this, since he felt partially responsible for whatever had happened to Shireen. After all, he'd told her about the wormhole. Maybe in doing so, he'd cursed her to be taken by it. "No," he said. "We'll tell the town. We'll see if anyone else is missing, and if there are any new ideas as to what's going on."

Adam parked the hearse, got out of the car and held a hand out for Carly. Her palm was cool and steady, and he was grateful to hold it. When they locked eyes, the world slowed and his breathing calmed, too. They would get out. They would solve this puzzle.

The group began to walk toward Main Street and quickly saw that almost the entire town was out in the middle of the road.

“Mayor Franco?” Carly asked.

Adam gave a low chuckle. “Pretty sure she won’t be able to hear you over all this noise.” The sound from the road was deafening, like being at an indoor concert and standing next to the amplifier. What was the activity today, an impromptu mosh pit?

“No, I mean *Mayor Franco*.” Carly pointed a finger above the crowd, and when Adam looked, there was Mayor Franco in a head-to-toe lemon-yellow suit. She stood on a makeshift stage crafted out of boxes piled on top of each other like pancakes.

“Incredible,” Dr. Song said. “It’s like she’s cosplaying Big Bird.”

“Can’t argue there,” Carly said. “When we escape the loop and I become a famous screenwriter, I’ll miss her outfits the most.”

Carly almost looked hopeful at the mention of escaping. And Adam wanted that for her, too. He wanted Carly to be able to pursue her dreams. But he was certain he wouldn’t be able to get her out until he brought Shireen back—if he could solve that, then there was a chance.

“Hi! Hello!” The mayor said into a megaphone. “You all are being *really* loud right now, so I just need you to, like, chill. Okay?”

To Adam’s surprise, people did quiet down.

“Now, I called this town hall because, as I’ve already explained to most of you, the eclipse is getting shorter!” The mayor’s excitement beamed out through the megaphone.

“Oh shit,” Carly said and clapped a hand over her mouth.

“The mayor figured that out on her own?” Rick asked. “Maybe the aliens got to her.”

“Not on her own,” Carly said through gritted teeth. “I may have told her when I was in my sad cheese-girl era.”

“What exactly did you tell her, again?” Adam wasn’t a dramatic person, but Main Street was beginning to feel like the fiery depths of hell. Not only because Adam was worried about what the mayor knew, but also because

someone had lit multiple trash cans on fire and the flames really did heat up the space in an uncomfortable way.

“I think we should turn back,” Carly whispered into his ear.

But then the mayor said, “Our do-gooder friend, Carly Hart, told me all about how she and the spooky Rhodes kid have been measuring this thing. Come to think of it, probably best if I let them explain. Carly? Adam? Are you here?”

Well, Carly had certainly made telling more people easier. And Adam had learned from life as a tall redhead that hiding wasn’t an option. Sure enough, multiple sets of eyes landed on him. His shoulders hunched at the attention.

The mayor gestured to the piled-up boxes as if they were the steps that would lead them to accept a prestigious award, rather than a march to implode the town.

Carly’s eyes went wide but Adam said, “We’re not going to be able to Irish goodbye at this point. Come on, we’ll get it over with.” When he glanced around, the eyes of people he knew, didn’t know and vaguely remembered, met his. He swallowed way too loudly, and the fact that he could hear himself clued him to the other fact that the space had grown quiet. Everyone truly was waiting for them to provide answers.

Carly took the steps to the “stage” one at a time, and Adam hoisted himself up, too. The base was precarious at best.

“What is happening?” someone shouted from the crowd.

Heather and Rick had also climbed up, and Heather took the megaphone, a professor in her element. Heather looked out to the crowd as she said, “Hello, my name is Dr. Heather Song, and I’ve been helping Carly, Adam and Rick try to understand the changes that have been happening with the eclipse.”

“Isn’t that guy a scientist, too?” Spider-Man asked, pointing to Adam.

Adam wasn’t at all a scientist but found that someone calling him that made a little well of joy form in his chest. What if he got to call himself that every day? What if—

Carly’s loud voice cut him off, “Hey, yeah, common mistake. Adam here may look like the redhead version of Bill Nye, but he’s actually a mortician.”

“A statistician?” Spider-Man asked.

Oh, for fuck's sake. Adam rolled his eyes, then said, "A funeral director, actually! A mortician is different."

"How?" someone called out.

"It's kind of technical!" he shouted. "It involves different licenses, but the same dead people."

"Oh," Spider-Man said. "That's gross, man."

"Thanks for the feedback," Adam replied. And then, because he wanted to get this over with so they could go about finding Shireen, he decided to finally use his voice. "The eclipse is something I've been timing since the loop began. For 238 loops it consistently was four minutes and thirty-two seconds long. Then it shortened by ten seconds, then another ten. It's now clocking in at two minutes and forty-seven seconds. There is really no way to know what this means for any of us in a practical sense."

"The loop is ending!" a loud voice boomed from the crowd and then, like a chant at a football game, the town began to shout, "Ending! Ending! Ending!"

There was a kind of elation in the air that was both exhilarating and unfortunate, because as Adam already knew, a happy ending wasn't guaranteed.

"Maybe we will get out of the loop and go back to normal, or maybe not," Dr. Song said through the megaphone.

"Maybe not?" someone asked.

"Maybe not," Heather said with a tense smile.

"Some of us have already left the loop!" Rick chimed in.

A stone of dread lodged in Adam's stomach. This wasn't how he'd expected this scenario to go, and he sensed that this information dump wouldn't be well received. Adam needed to get control if he had any shot of finding Shireen, so he grabbed the megaphone.

"We do not know what's causing the eclipse to shorten," he said. "We also know that Shireen Jamshidi, who some of you may know—and who I was married to—did not reset today. She appears to be missing."

He had to pause after saying the words out loud. She was missing. He took a breath. But in his pause, panicked mumbling began from the crowd. "We want to understand what's happening, but we need help. If you know of anyone else missing, please tell us. If you have any ideas as to why the eclipse is shortening, we want to hear those, too. We came to ask for help, because we want to bring Shireen back."

“Are we going to die?” A panicked voice rose from the crowd.

Adam looked to Carly. He wasn’t ready to leave this world. He wouldn’t give up looking for Shireen, either. So he knew the answer. “We’re not going anywhere. Not if we work together to solve this.”

And he believed those words; he really did.

Heather, though, stole the megaphone and quickly added, “If we’re just talking probabilities here, anything is possible. Including death.”

Carly angrily yanked the megaphone from Heather and said, “I think what Dr. Song is trying to say is that yes, the eclipse is getting shorter, but it could mean anything! Live life to the fullest! Carpe diem!” She tried to smile, but Adam knew it was fake. She must’ve too, as she abruptly wiped it from her face. “You know what, fuck it. I’m going to be real with you for a minute. Some of you might have met my dad, Bruce Hart? He told me he was going to pursue a lifelong dream of opening his own movie theater just a few years ago. I couldn’t believe it. I mean, he was retirement age. He’d already worked on countless movies. He’d lived *the* dream so many people wanted. But he had more dreams left, and he wanted to try to complete them. He ran The Last Showing theater down the way. If you have a dream, go for it now. If you’ve been holding back, now’s the time to be bold. Let this information change the way you’re spending each loop.”

Rick took the megaphone from Carly’s hands to add, “It’s like C.C. Bloom says in *Beaches*, ‘You’re not dead yet, so stop living as if you are!’”

The murmurs from the crowd suggested they were all deeply concerned. But now that everyone knew the truth, Adam hoped someone or something would surface to shed light on Shireen.

“Right. Thank you, Rick,” Adam said. “Okay, cool, um . . . If you notice any other changes, feel free to let us know! Thank you, as always, Mayor Franco.”

Carly whispered to Adam, “We’ve gotta get the hell out of here.”

“Don’t threaten me with a good time.” Adam got off the box pile and held out his hands to help Carly do the same. As she came next to him, he easily pulled her in close.

Any calm he’d felt quickly left as the mayor smiled brightly and said, “Okay, so Shireen disappeared. That’s spooky! Raise your hand if someone you know has turned into a ghost.”

A few sharp jeers came from the crowd, not loving the tone of the mayor’s speech. Carly exhaled and then pointedly dragged Adam away.

“Nobody else? Wow! Isn’t this fun? Like being detectives in a mystery book or something!” Mayor Franco’s enthusiasm didn’t seem to be shared as Adam and Carly made their way back toward the hearse.

“Starting to think this was a mistake.” Carly cringed as the mayor started to play the *Ghostbusters* movie theme song via the megaphone.

“You think?” he said. “We can just pretend this part of the day didn’t happen. Carry on and—”

Before he could finish his sentence, a petite woman with thick hair and an oversize sweater stopped in front of them.

“My cat, Toonces, disappeared first day of the loop.” Megan Rae, a local aesthetician with glowing skin who Adam remembered from high school, tearfully clutched a tissue to her nose. “Does that mean she’s a ghost now?”

“I don’t really think Toonces is a ghost,” Adam gently said. “I think there’s been a blip in the reset. I’m sure she’ll be back soon.”

“What if she never comes back?” Megan pulled another tissue from her pocket. “What if she’s lost forever and I’m stuck here without her?”

Adam swallowed. He’d had a similar thought about Shireen. What if she was just . . . gone? And never returned?

“Megan,” he softly said. “This is not easy. It’s awful, actually.”

“Yes, it is,” she sniffed. “But it’s like that famous saying goes, ‘the best way to predict the future is to create it.’ That’s why I leave out a bowl with fresh food every morning. Someday, Toonces will come back for dinner.”

The mention of the cat’s name sent Megan into hysterics, and Carly wrapped her in a hug. “Shhh,” Carly said into Megan’s hair. She looked to Adam with a worried expression.

“Megan, I’m so sorry, but keep putting that food out,” Adam said. “Toonces will be back soon.”

“Keep us posted.” Carly gave Megan a helpful nod.

Adam pulled Carly into him as they continued the rest of the way to the car. And tucking her close felt easy. Easier than anything else he’d done the whole loop. “I just realized we haven’t eaten all day, huh? Are you hungry? It’s about dinnertime at the Rhodes house.”

“I *am* hungry, but what about Shireen?” Carly asked, but rubbed her stomach.

“Something Megan said resonated with me. ‘The best way to predict the future is to create it.’ Maybe in order for Shireen to come back, we just have to act like she’ll reset with us tomorrow. Maybe, if I can let go of this

anxiety, it'll make room for her to return to the loop." What Adam was suggesting wasn't scientific, but he still sensed there was something to it.

Carly glanced back to the crowd. "We've kind of done all we can here," she said. "We can keep looking for her tonight, but a home-cooked meal from Bill and Sheila sounds good. We need to eat." Carly craned her neck to look up at him, and he couldn't help but bend down to meet her with a kiss.

How would he have made it through any of this day without her here?

He knew that just outside their bubble of two, an information bomb had been released on the town that would have a ripple effect. But he couldn't control how anyone reacted, or what they all did. What he could control was this moment with Carly, and how he made her feel. And he wanted her to feel like she was home with him.

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Chapter 23

Carly

The sun had set, but the sky retained a warm orange glow as they parked in front of Adam's house. Not quite night, not quite afternoon. Carly loved this point of the day in Julian, when the air cooled but hadn't lost all its light.

Maybe it was the view, her intense hunger, or the blur of the day, but she didn't notice Adam get out of the car until he'd opened the door for her. He held out his hand and she took it.

When Adam unlocked the front door of his parents' house and opened it wide, they were immediately met by a singsong chorus from the kitchen.

"Dinner's ready!" Bill shouted.

"But we finished the wine!" Sheila called out.

"Maybe don't mention Dean, or Shireen, or most of the day," Adam said in a low voice. "I just don't want them to worry any more than they already are."

"Okay." Carly's eyes shifted around to the framed family photos, the squirrel figurines. Adam's parents were welcoming them into their home, offering dinner. Something about lying—even a little white lie—felt off.

"But I thought you were being honest with them?"

Before Adam could respond, Bill came in wearing an apron and brandishing a whisk. "Come, eat!"

And so they did. Adam and Carly joined his parents to eat around the small breakfast nook that overlooked the forest. There were mashed potatoes and a roast chicken and some kind of rosemary bread that smelled

freshly baked. The whole thing felt normal in a way Carly hadn't realized she needed. While time was literally standing still in Julian, here, in a home that time had preserved, maybe there was something to be said for consistency.

"Nice that we're still all here, huh?" Sheila took a sip of wine. "I'm afraid to ask, but anything new with the eclipse?"

Carly's eyes went wide as she looked to Adam. He'd told her not to say anything, but would he be able to look at his parents and lie?

"No, the time stayed the same today," Adam said, which was the truth.

"Oh, well, that's good news, isn't it?" Sheila perked up and looked from Bill to Adam. Adam gave a tight nod and shoved a bite of potato into his mouth. Turns out, he'd found a lie loophole.

"What does your scientist friend think of all this?" Bill waved his fork around the air for emphasis.

Adam stopped chewing, wiped his mouth with the cloth napkin and wouldn't meet his parents' eyes. Something in the room had shifted, but Carly wasn't certain what. There was a tension between Adam and Bill, though, so she tried to ease it.

"Adam and I haven't given up on finding a way out of the loop," she said.

"You've turned my son into an optimist." Bill gave her a weak smile. Then he refocused on Adam. "Your mother and I were talking about this as well. We'd really love the opportunity to speak to this expert you met. We could bounce some ideas off her. Just get a better understanding of what's happening here."

"I think we'd feel better with more information," Sheila said.

Carly understood this need of wanting all the details of a situation. She'd felt that way when Adam first told her the eclipse was shortening. She'd gotten those answers from Adam, though. But she wondered what exactly Adam told them about the eclipse.

"Dr. Song wouldn't be looking at the eclipse at all if it weren't for me," Adam said. "I'm the first person who noticed the changes."

"We know that." Sheila reached a hand for Adam. "But this is all new for us, honey. We're just trying to make sense of it."

"So ask me," he said. "Why are you so fixated on her when I'm the one whose been studying this the whole time?"

“Because you don’t talk to us.” Bill unexpectedly slammed a fist on the tabletop. “All you ever seem to say is everything is fine, when it clearly isn’t. You never open up.”

Carly shouldn’t be here. This was a conversation between Adam and his parents. She began to slide her chair out from the table, but Adam grabbed on to her wrist and gave her a pleading look. “Please don’t go,” he said.

“Okay,” she quickly said and eased back into her seat. If Adam wanted her to stay, she’d do that for him.

“I’m asking Carly to stay because, if anything, she’s the one who’s helped me open up more.”

Carly swallowed down a nervous lump. Now she was being roped into the family drama, and she wasn’t sure that would end well for her. Nevertheless, he carried on talking.

“I don’t talk to you because any time I do, you tend to shut me down,” Adam said.

“What?” Sheila leaned across the table, as if she hadn’t heard him correctly. “You said you needed space to grieve Shireen. We gave that to you. You asked to be left alone all day every day. We allowed it. Your dad and I have been nothing but accommodating.”

“You didn’t give me space to grieve, though.” Adam ran a hand through his hair as he gathered his words and, Carly assumed, courage. “You gave me my old room, yes, but then every other loop you told me it was time to move on. I needed to get on with my life. I needed to forget about Shireen. You never stopped to ask me how I was feeling. You never told me that it was normal to feel like my heart had been ripped out of my body. All you wanted was for me to get over it.”

“That’s not true,” Bill countered. “I’ve asked if you wanted to talk about Shireen.”

“You’ve asked, yes,” Adam admitted. “But historically, I’ve learned that whenever I tell you what’s on my mind, it’s never what you want to hear.”

“What’s that supposed to mean?” Sheila crossed her arms.

Either the room was warm, or all the rage was heating the space up. Carly fought the urge to fan her face with her hand. Instead, she put her palm on Adam’s back as a show of support. She wished she could hit a pause button to hug him.

“I never wanted to go into the family business,” Adam said. “I wanted to go to Caltech, but you made it clear that wouldn’t be acceptable. Carly is

the only person who asked me what I want to do with my life, with my career. I've only known her for a short time, but she's been more supportive of what I actually care about than anyone else."

"You're blaming us for you not going to Caltech?" his dad asked incredulously. "I'm sorry if you feel like we stopped you from that but, Adam, you stopped yourself."

Adam cleared his throat and straightened. "What are you talking about?"

"Yes, I wanted you to take over the family business because it would be a secure job. I told you that so you could have all the information. But we never, not once, told you not to go to Caltech, or to pursue a career you wanted." Bill's voice shook with some emotion he was holding back.

Adam, too, seemed to want to avoid his feelings as he studied his hands. Eventually, he said, "You didn't have to directly discourage me. You made it clear when you repeatedly asked how I'd make money and what I'd do for work."

"Correct, we're your parents and of course we're going to ask you questions," Bill said. "Are you seriously blaming me for where you are right now?"

"Are you seriously saying that your lack of support has nothing to do with where I am?" Adam quickly replied.

Carly had thoughts. The first being that she may not have pursued screenwriting if her father had discouraged her from it. She'd sought his approval for most of her life decisions. But she also knew some of what Bill said was fair—Adam was his own person. An adult. If he wanted to go to Caltech, he could apply.

But that was Adam's nature, wasn't it? He was more cautious. He cared deeply about what his parents thought. He was like his dad, in that sense.

Carly's dad had always charted his own course. Even when Carly disapproved of his moving to Julian, he'd gone ahead and done it anyway.

"I can't listen to any more of this." Bill stood from the table. He gave Adam a hard look. "We've given you everything, Adam. I don't know what more you want."

Bill left the room, and Adam pushed his chair out, maybe ready to follow. But Sheila held up her hand.

"Adam, remember the last loop you were here, and we talked about your dad wanting to paint a mural in town?" Sheila asked.

Adam nodded.

“Caltech is your mural,” she continued. “You and your dad suffer from the same kind of paralyzing fear of failure. You’re right that we were not one hundred percent supportive. We had questions, because we only know what we know. And the world you wanted to explore is one we have no experience with. I’m sorry if our concerns stopped you from pursuing your dreams. But honey, unless you want to end up like your dad, you have to own your choices, too.”

Adam’s chin began to wobble, and Carly instinctively rubbed slow circles across his back. Her heart broke for how hard it must’ve been for him to say any of this to his parents, and for how they’d reacted. What would the right reaction be? She wasn’t sure, but none of this made her feel great.

“All I can say is that I hope you do figure a way out of this loop so you can finally follow those dreams. I’d love to see you happy,” Sheila added. “That’s all we ever wanted for you. And we thought moving on from Shireen might make you happy. That’s why we kept pushing.”

Carly gave Adam a look. This was the moment when he had to finally come clean about everything to his parents. Shireen had been their daughter-in-law, after all. She wasn’t sure if Adam would see this as a good deed, but she decided to force him to be honest.

“Adam,” Carly finally said. “You need to tell your mom about Shireen.”

He looked off into the dark woods as Sheila leaned across the table. “What about Shireen?”

Carly waited in an Adirondack chair on the back patio and stared at Smarty Squirrel. *It’ll all work out, Carly girl, you’ll see*, Bruce had told her about the move to Julian. She tried to channel those words for this, too. But she couldn’t ignore Sheila and Adam’s clutched hands and the worried lines that creased their mouths. Would it all work out?

When Adam eventually came onto the patio, he was quiet. Carly patted the Adirondack chair next to hers and he sat. He handed Carly a glass of red wine and sipped from his own. She wasn’t used to sitting in the quiet, but sensed he needed a moment. So she waited. Carly leaned all the way back in the chair and watched the night sky. There were so many stars—more than she’d ever seen in her life. It was hard to believe that while they were

in Julian, above them was life they'd never see beyond bright specks in the sky.

Eventually, Adam said, "We're not usually like this. We don't fight. We don't talk to each other about these things."

"For what it's worth, I think it's good to talk about the big life stuff while you can. I never got a chance to do that with my dad. I always thought we'd have more time." She hugged herself to fend off the cold. Without asking, Adam took off his blazer and draped it across her shoulders. The fabric smelled buttery, like him. "How do you feel?" she asked.

"Angry. Bitter. Exhausted. I don't know." He sucked in his bottom lip. "I thought being honest would be this big cathartic moment, but I don't feel any resolution. It's like, sure, I've told the truth, but I'm in the same situation with the added bonus of my dad being mad at me."

"He's not mad at you." Carly tucked the blazer around herself. "He thinks he did right by you, and it's hard for him to acknowledge that he should've done anything different. He probably needs time to come to terms with that."

"How do you know Bill's inner monologue?" Adam gave her an amused look.

"I'm a screenwriter. My job is to analyze people's motivations. If I'm doing my job well, then I'm right." She wiggled against the colder air.

"Maybe he's right, you know? It's not like they forced me into the job, or this life." Adam swung his long legs to stretch all the way to the end of the chair.

"No, they didn't," Carly said. "But it's really hard to say no to a sure thing."

"Not for you," Adam said.

Carly knew their situations were not at all similar, but she spelled it out for Adam. "My dad worked in movies. Me making a leap into screenwriting wasn't completely new. I mean, if I'd told my dad I wanted to be a rocket scientist, he'd probably be over the moon, no pun intended. But it seems to me that your dad did the best he could. Your mom, too. You just needed more."

"Yeah, I did," he said softly.

"Your mom is right, by the way. You can still pursue Caltech. Whatever your nerdy heart desires." She waved a hand toward the sky.

“We have to get out of here first, though.” Adam gave her an almost hopeful look. “What about you? What are you going to do if we get out?”

“*When we get out,*” Carly said, “I’m going to do a lot of things. Never eat apple pie again, for one. Maybe never leave my apartment. Never come back here.” She cringed. She didn’t mean that she didn’t want to see Adam again, just not the town. “You know what I mean,” she added.

“Trust me, I’d like to drive out of here, too. I’ll probably have to come back, though, considering the parents thing. And the fact that I still like the apple pie.”

“I knew you were a monster, Adam. I just didn’t realize how deeply.”

That got a laugh out of him, which sent flutters through her belly. Even though the loop was closing and Adam had just fought with his parents, Carly didn’t feel drained. Being here with him made sense, like part of her was lit up because of their closeness. She scooted her chair toward his and reached for him. He wrapped his hand around hers and they both stared up at the sky. The air hummed with crickets and the faint hoot of an owl.

“Look, do you see that big orange star?” Adam pointed above them.

“I . . .” She hesitated, then excitedly said, “Yes! What does it mean?”

He gently reached for her finger and pointed up. “That star is actually the planet Jupiter, which we can see tonight. But if you look at the stars above it, you’ll see a constellation called Leo. It’s the easiest one to see.”

He took her hand and brought her finger from the top of the head, down the neck, along the back, and around to form the constellation.

“I see it.” A delighted smile crossed her lips. “It doesn’t really look like a lion, though. I mean, this could be anything. A lamb. A coat hanger. A futuristic mouse with a very pointy tail.”

He held back a laugh. “The people who named these constellations took liberties.”

“It’s still cool, though. I mean, for all I know, you just made this up. But because you have a telescope, I choose to believe you. That’s power, my guy.”

My guy. She liked the sound of that. They were together, side by side, the universe above them, and inches apart from each other on the earth.

“It’s *two* telescopes,” he said.

“Of course. Two.” She smirked.

“When I look up it feels like I can escape into the unknown,” Adam said.

“But you’re so type-A.” Carly elbowed him playfully. “Doesn’t it drive you crazy to not know what’s out there?”

“It’s the promise that I might be the one to solve what’s out there that excites me,” he said.

“Cheers,” she said and raised her glass. “To solving what’s out there.”

“To being with you,” Adam said. And they locked eyes.

The side of her mouth twitched, and she let out a heavy breath of gratitude. The next loop wasn’t guaranteed, but this moment with the man she *really* liked was. Carly leaned across and told him as much with a kiss.

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Chapter 24

Adam

Day 251

The thing Adam hadn't anticipated about losing someone was the few seconds when you forgot they were missing and life felt normal. Then, inevitably, the yank back to the realization that they were gone.

That jarring juxtaposition came when Adam reset and briefly felt Shireen in the office with him. But then, as his eyes adjusted, he saw that he was alone in the space.

Shireen was still missing.

"Adam?" Carly's voice pierced through the air, and her footsteps pounded down the hallway. When she came to the office door, her face fell. "She's not back."

"No," he replied. They'd tried looking for Shireen, telling the rest of the town, and trying to predict the future by going on as he normally had. Nothing about the last loop had worked to change the current one.

"Well, fuck." Carly stomped her foot and gnawed at her bottom lip.

Adam found his mind and body were at war as of recent. Because while his gut clenched with anxiety over Shireen, he really longed to hold Carly. He stepped toward her and pulled her in, resting his chin on top of her head.

"What are we going to do?" he asked. "I can't even think straight. My mind is going a mile a minute."

“Well, the whole town knows to be on the lookout for Shireen, and we know Dean is going to be scouring Julian for her. We could join the search party, but I do think we just need something to take the edge off. A shot of whiskey?” she hedged.

“A lobotomy?” he countered.

“I don’t know any doctors other than Heather, so I think the easier option would be the whiskey.” Carly cleared her throat. “Seriously, though, I need a drink. Do you need a drink? I’ve never seen you drink, but do you? What about drugs? I just kind of need to release some of these nerves, because my head is about to explode. You probably don’t drink or do drugs or need anything to feel less freaked out, but I do, you know?”

She’d spoken so fast that she was practically panting at the end. Adam had an edible before, and he wasn’t opposed to drinking, especially if there was a local IPA available. His drug of choice had and always would be sugar. Still, a drink sounded nice. Maybe it would keep him from spinning. “Yeah, we need a break.” He grabbed her hand and tugged her in the direction of the front doors.

When they parked the hearse and walked toward the saloon-themed bar off Main Street, Adam shouldn’t have been totally surprised by the people staring at them. After the last town hall loop, a bright spotlight had been aimed their way. Still, the attention was a bit jarring.

“You going to be okay with this?” Carly asked. “I’m used to having attention on me, because I’m a friendly and likable person. But unless you’re in work mode, I know you prefer to hiss and scamper when anyone so much as looks at you.”

His mouth betrayed an amused smile. “You talk so much that I’m worried you’re dehydrated. That’s why we’re getting drinks. I’m sacrificing my own needs for yours.”

“So chivalrous. Come on, the booze won’t drink itself.” Carly blessedly tugged on his hand and led him into the bar.

The saloon-themed bar was a nod to Julian’s history as a gold-mining town, and it leaned heavily into the shtick. Adam pushed on the swinging saloon doors and they walked in to find a wall lined with cowboy hats, and fake gold-plated tables with enormous rocks spraypainted silver as centerpieces. The bar was filled with beers on tap, a selection of hard apple ciders and a stocked liquor display.

“Thank the whiskey gods,” Carly said as she walked behind the bar. “I’ve never been happier to be at a bar. I mean, I work as a bartender, so I don’t usually like to hang out at them. I prefer small gatherings, like a dinner party, or . . . well, yeah, really just those. And that’s when I’ll have a cocktail or something. But I don’t like sticky floors or that kind of moldy smell some bars have, you know?”

“I’ve never met anyone who talks as much as you. Have I mentioned that?” Adam sat at a bar stool.

Carly not so playfully tossed a paper napkin at Adam, which he clutched in mock pain.

“If I didn’t talk we’d exist in pure silence and nothing would get done.” She brushed stray hair off her cheek and leaned across the bar. “I’m going to make myself a whiskey with, like, *lots* of fancy cherries. What do you want?”

“I’ll have a mezcal, neat. Any brand is fine.”

“Don’t worry, just one drink and we’ll get back to looking for Shireen.” Carly smiled at him.

A few drinks later, they were not looking for Shireen, but *were* feeling very good. So good, that Adam draped an arm around Carly and she leaned her head against his shoulder.

“Have you noticed that people look kinda fancy?” Carly picked her head up and glanced around.

While it was true that there was a man with a handlebar mustache and a three-piece suit standing next to a blue-haired woman in a ball gown, plenty of people played dress-up in Julian every loop.

“There’s a big vow renewal happening at the Clio Farmhouse down the road,” a woman on the bar stool next to them said. “Sorry to eavesdrop, but I’m a little nosy.”

“Me, too,” said Carly with a smile. “What’s your name?”

“Elizabeth,” she said and stuck out her hand, which was covered in costume rings and bracelets. “All the old folks got together and decided that if the world is ending, they might as well renew their vows while they can. They’ve been inviting everyone in town. You should come. It’ll be fun.”

“Oh, I don’t know,” Carly said and looked at Adam to gauge his reaction. “We need to look for our friend.”

“The missing one? But the world isn’t actually ending, though, right?” Elizabeth asked them.

Adam hesitated. What was the point in dragging another person into the doomsday vibes that were his own internal thoughts? “No, it’s not ending,” he eventually said.

The relief that crossed Elizabeth’s face was immediate and grateful. Carly leaned into him and whispered, “That was a nice thing that you just did. Should we go look for Shireen?”

Adam knew he *should* look for Shireen, because he’d like to think she’d do the same. But he was a little buzzed, so was Carly, and they were in no state to drive. He also knew that wandering around town wouldn’t bring her back. Maybe once they sobered up, they could hit the library to look for answers, or brainstorm with Dr. Song. But this wasn’t the exact right time.

And maybe it was the way Carly’s body was pressed against his, or the alcohol, but he didn’t want this moment to end. So instead of doing what he should, he said, “Let’s go to this vow renewal.”

The Clio Farm was normally used for events like weddings or school field trips. Bistro lights were already strung across a laminate dance floor with round tables lining the perimeter. A picturesque red barn was in the near distance, and the sun set just behind it.

There had been no change in the eclipse time. Perhaps Dr. Song was right; with Shireen’s disappearance, maybe something had stabilized. Still, that didn’t stop the slightly sick feeling in Adam’s gut at the thought of Shireen, suspended somewhere in limbo so that they could all continue in the loop.

Upbeat pop from the sixties played over a sound system, and a kid with cartoon pajamas and a water gun skidded past, knocking into Carly. She tripped and Adam caught her. He was relieved for the distraction, and as Carly readjusted her glasses, he realized that while there were plenty of things to look at, she was the only person he wanted to see.

“Sorry, it’s *really* packed, huh?” she asked.

Adam’s hand landed on the small of her back, and he was delighted to find that it fit there quite perfectly. He guided them to a high-top table that had yet to be claimed.

“This is nice.” Carly leaned on the table. “Never seen this part of Julian before.”

For a moment he’d forgotten that they were only there because of the time loop, and that whenever it ended—if it ended without them being sucked into a black void of death—Carly would go back to her life in Los Angeles, and he’d still be here.

“Where did you go to just now?” Carly studied his features.

He shook his head, a little annoyed that he was so easy to read. He expected another lie to come out, but instead he said, “I was overthinking things.”

“What things?” Carly gave him a look like she was genuinely curious.

In a moment of weakness, Adam told the truth. “Like, if the loop ends, what happens when you go back to Los Angeles?”

She looked down at the tablecloth. He was suddenly way too aware of the fact that he’d just made himself vulnerable. What the hell was he doing spiraling about a future he didn’t even know if they’d have? Why did he go and ruin the night by bringing up probabilities?

“I haven’t even thought of that.” Carly rubbed her fingers across the white tablecloth, then looked at him. “I like you. We can figure it out.”

I like you, he repeated to himself. And then, because talking to Carly had become so easy, the words slipped out. “I like you, too.”

She gave him a small smile, then reached behind his head and pulled him in. He found the idea of one kiss impossible, though, and moved closer. Adam’s hands found her face and he deepened their connection. How was it that her lips felt so damn good against his? He hardened as she wrapped her arms around his back.

“You two are *together*?” Mayor Franco’s voice was so close that they pulled away. “Or is the impending doom getting your gears going?”

Adam swiped a thumb along his lower lip, where Carly had just been. He looked over at the mayor, who wore a velvet maroon suit and a cowboy hat.

“Ceremony is about to start.” Mayor Franco adjusted her bolo tie. “So either get a room or stop stealing my thunder.”

Adam forced himself to laugh. Carly gave Adam a playful nudge and said, “A room doesn’t sound so bad . . .”

He had to agree with that. But before he could do anything about it, there was a *tap tap tap* on a microphone.

“I know the mic is working, but I wanted to make sure everyone’s paying attention to me.” The mayor waited for laughter, and some came, so she continued. “I’m just joking but also, totally serious.”

On either side of the mayor were couples—all in septuagenarian-plus territory. As the mayor stood in front of them and espoused the joys of lasting love, Adam couldn’t help but think about his own wedding. It hadn’t been at the Clio Farm, but a local winery. They’d been married under a canopy of hanging green vines while a live cellist played softly. Adam’s dad had sobbed through almost the entire ceremony and been so moved that he couldn’t deliver the wedding speech he’d written.

As Adam surveyed the couples, he wondered how many of them had almost called it quits. Or maybe some of them had, and this was a second or even third marriage. If they were all this old and could still find love, then maybe he would, too, someday.

“Here.” Carly handed him a red cloth, then pointed to his eyes. Which is when he realized he’d been crying. When the hell had that happened?

“Thanks,” he mumbled as he dabbed the tears away.

Was Carly able to read his thoughts and see that he’d been thinking of his own wedding and the life he’d lost?

He should try to find clues as to how to bring back Shireen, shouldn’t he? But once again, Mayor Franco interrupted his thoughts. “You may kiss your partners!” the mayor shouted into the microphone, and the couples did exactly that.

As the ceremony ended, the music cranked up, and Carly handed Adam a glass of champagne from a nearby display. He was about to tell her that they should sober up to visit the library, when a woman with teased, dyed blond hair and big hoop earrings pushed her way through the crowd toward Carly and Adam. She held her hand out to Carly for a handshake. “Name’s Ashley. Julian High Class of 1972. Is it true what they’re saying about the eclipse—once it disappears so will we?”

“We’re all high school sweethearts.” A man with a thick gray beard held hands with another man—judging by the suits, they were recently remarried.

“And best friends!” a petite woman with a short-cropped haircut chimed in.

“Best time of our lives was high school,” Ashley said. “And not just because of our dating, though that certainly helped.”

“Technically, Roger and I got together *after* college,” the gray bearded man said.

“I was dating Kelsey.” Roger pointed to a tall, distinguished woman in a pashmina. “Dennis was dating Ashley.”

“I’m the only woman for Dennis.” Ashley reached back and squeezed Dennis’s hand.

“And if we hadn’t broken up, you’d never have gotten together with Kelsey,” Dennis said.

Kelsey stepped up and gave Ashley a kiss on the forehead. “I’m the only one who *didn’t* go to Julian High,” she said. “I went to a private all-girls school in San Diego. But I found my way into this group when I’d come home on the weekends.”

“We’re actually on our way out.” Adam gently guided Carly around the group.

Adam’s head swam with all the interpersonal relationships he’d just been thrown, so he was eager for a break. But before they could properly escape, Dennis and Roger stopped them.

“We just want to know how much time we have left together,” Roger said and gripped Dennis’s hand tighter. “It took us so long to find each other before the loop, and we aren’t ready for our lives to end just yet.”

“I wish I had an answer for you,” Adam said. He couldn’t imagine how hard their lives had been. Julian was a small town; half of the place was liberal and the other conservative. And while marriage for them was legal here, it didn’t mean that everyone supported that. Julian’s politics were part of the reason why Adam’s kiss with Casey had happened under the bleachers, in secret, and only once. He’d venture to guess it was also why Casey had moved to San Francisco, where he could be out and open without as much fear.

So what Adam wanted to be able to tell Dennis and Roger was that they would happily continue in this loop for all eternity with each other. But no one knew what waited on the other side.

Maybe sensing his hesitation, Carly jumped in. “Before the loop, none of us knew how much time we have, right? So maybe it’s best to go back to that way of thinking. If we can all live like there’s no tomorrow, then maybe we won’t have any regrets, no matter what happens.”

No regrets. And what if there really was no tomorrow? He’d spent so much time chasing after the life he’d had, that he hadn’t seen what was

waiting in front of him. And now there was Carly. Was he really about to forgo this opportunity to be with her, on the off chance that they might find some valuable information in the next few hours? He didn't want to waste another moment by not holding her, and tomorrow (if they still had a tomorrow), they could pursue leads on Shireen in earnest.

Adam gestured to the dance floor. Carly hesitated, but Adam decided to push again. "May I have this dance?"

He extended a hand. There was that little flush in her cheeks, but she said, "Okay."

Carly took his hand, and Adam held her steady as they walked onto the laminate floor. The fast song turned into a slow one—"Time After Time" by Cyndi Lauper. The DJ either had a great sense of humor or was trying to torture them. But Adam had always liked this song, how it was about a person who would always be waiting for you. Wasn't that how love should be?

So when Adam got them to the middle of the dance floor, he stopped and turned Carly slowly until she faced him. His free hand moved to her low back, and he brought her in close, never breaking eye contact. He led them in an easy circle, as her hands found his shoulders.

They swayed together. He matched her rhythm. Her fingers tightened as he spun them. His hand fanned across her back to steady her, unwilling to let her go even for a second. He turned her under his arm, but her eyes never left his. And as they came back together, she was pressed firmly to him.

The words to the song were clear and imbued with more meaning now that Carly clung to him. Without thinking, Adam started to sing the lines low and into her ear. "Time after time. Time after time."

She pressed her forehead against his. And this just felt so right—Carly in his arms, her breath against his cheek. He hadn't felt sure of anything in a long time, maybe ever. He reluctantly pulled back as the song ended, taking in her dress, body and full lips. Those lips parted, as if for him.

He was going to kiss her. His eyes scanned her face, and he bent down just as an absolutely thunderous boom sounded behind them. The sky filled with the green and gold of a firework exploding high above them.

"Fireworks!" Carly shouted over the sound.

Adam grabbed her cheek and brought her gaze back to him. Then he kissed her, and she kissed him back. He could hardly help how his thumb

traced a line along her cheekbone, or how he nipped her lower lip in excitement, how his fingers wove through her hair and massaged her neck. Her mouth was a new galaxy he planned to take his time exploring. He wanted all of her. He wanted to be covered in a blanket of her dark, thick hair so all he'd see was her. She curled her fingers around his neck and pulled him in closer.

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Chapter 25

Carly

Fireworks and kissing felt like a bad cliché from a reality dating show and yet, Carly had to admit that making out against the booming backdrop of explosions was weirdly romantic. Maybe it was the imminent threat of gunpowder and fire that made her claw him closer. But either way, her body burned for him. She couldn't stop kissing him, not even if she'd tried.

His bright red hair had turned her into some kind of raging bull, crashing into him over and over again. She would never be satisfied. They'd ventured away from the dance floor and were pressed against the side of a barn just behind it, alone and uninterrupted. He surrounded and pressed her into the wood siding until she arched herself into him like a cat. But he pushed back, too. The thing about wood siding, though . . .

"My back," Carly said, pushing herself away from the barn. Very close to them was a decorative row of hay, and even a saddle for a horse stacked on top of a hay bale. Adam picked her up and she wrapped her legs around his waist, like that was something she did on a routine basis.

"Oh my God, wait, don't hurt *your* back!" she said through a laugh.

"Have you noticed that you're half my height?" Adam said.

She was not. But he kissed her to stop the conversation and carry on with what they were doing, she supposed. And Carly kissed him back as he safely landed her on top of one of the hay bales. The sleeve of her dress fell, or he pushed it off, but either way his mouth found its way to her shoulder, where he nipped as he pushed the hem of her dress up past her knees.

“Adam,” she said and looked around to see if anyone else was nearby.

“We’re alone,” he said. “No one will know we’re back here. They’re all watching the fireworks, and I’d like to make you explode.”

Carly’s mouth fell open and she stifled a laugh. “Adam!” she squealed in surprise. And then his head dipped under her dress, his mouth hovered over her panties and he blew out a cool breath against her. “Adam,” and now his name came out like she was tipsy, only it wasn’t the champagne making her weak.

“I don’t think I’ll ever get sick of you saying my name.” His voice was muffled by the fabric. His big hand came up to her hip and he guided her to lie back into the hay.

“And I don’t think I’ll ever get sick of this view.” She ran her fingers through his red hair and he looked up, a little grin creasing his lips. How had she hated this man for so long? She recalled, at one point, wishing she could watch him walk to the perimeter just so she could see him be swallowed up.

But now Adam was here, and as his nails scratched up her thigh and he lowered his mouth to her, she was just grateful to be with him.

He was about to devour her, but she pulled his head up. “Wait. I want to try something.” She pointed to the saddle on top of the hay bale just next to them. “Can you sit on that? And I’ll . . . sit on you?”

He gave her a side smile. “Happy to get a riding lesson.”

She was on fire. As soon as he swung a leg over the leather, she wasted no time climbing into his lap. While she loved being eaten out, she’d found that dry humping was underrated. Carly settled herself on top of Adam, wrapped her arms behind his neck and brought her mouth to his. They kissed slow and deep, and she began to rock her hips toward him. She brought her body up the length of him, then slid down, treating her clit to enough friction to send little shivers through her. And Adam took the opportunity to cup her breast in his hand and bite her nipple through the fabric. She didn’t want anything in the way of his lips, though. So she shrugged herself out of the top of the dress, leaving her breasts exposed to the cool night air. Her nipples hardened and he moaned as he brought one to his mouth and sucked her in deeply.

Carly’s head fell back as she ground into Adam and he continued to bite and flick her with his tongue. Her body tensed and she knew she was building to something.

“You’re close,” he said as he twisted her nipple between his fingers. “I can feel it.”

“I want to feel you come, too,” she said.

Adam’s pupils went almost black as she unzipped his pants, took out his cock and pushed her panties aside as she slid him in. He pushed and she tightened for him. “You did that for me, didn’t you?” He grunted as he thrust up and into her deepest spot.

“And you did that for me,” she said, grinding herself on top. She kept her gaze fixed on him and something about that sent him to a new edge. Adam’s hand found her lower back and he met her thrusts with his own. He was locked on to her as he said, “You are so fucking beautiful.”

Her body unlocked for him as pleasure began to pour out. Adam’s body tensed as his thrusts slowed, until they were both completely spent.

“You realize we just had a true roll in the hay.” She was breathless but couldn’t help the observation.

“I’m sure we’re not the only ones who got lucky tonight.” Adam leaned back into his palms, his forehead glistened with sweat and his lips parted. The man was so beautiful. He studied the stars, and believed in Carly and *really* loved making her come, and on top of all of that, he had hair the color of lava.

The inky black night had turned gray from the fireworks. How long had they been out there?

“We’re probably about to reset, huh?” Carly asked. She wanted to stay in this place, feeling his lips and the burn of his stubble against her cheeks.

“Yeah,” Adam said as he tucked a strand of hair behind her ear. “But I’ll see you soon.” As he pressed his lips to hers, she felt the familiar tingle in her arms and the world went black.

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Chapter 26

Carly

Day 252

The night sky, Adam's lips and his hands and how she couldn't help rubbing her cheek against his stubble right before everything went black—those were the things Carly clung to as the funeral room came into focus.

She locked on to the photo of Bruce carrying pint-size Carly on his shoulders and wondered what her dad would think of Adam. Would they have gotten along? “Hey, Dad,” she said. “You won't believe this, but I met someone. He's probably the opposite of good on paper. He's technically still married, and his job is . . . Well, it's a *steady* job, but not exactly normal. Actually, you'd probably get a kick out of the fact that he—”

“Adam?” a voice called out down the hallway.

Carly turned toward it. Was that . . .

She hurried down the aisle, tripping over her own feet. But when she turned to Adam's office, she didn't see a tall redhead.

“Shireen?” Carly asked with relief.

Shireen was okay. She hadn't disappeared forever. Here she was, standing in the hall, just like any other day.

“You're back!” Carly said with real enthusiasm.

“Yeah, I do reset here every day.” Shireen seemed annoyed. Which is when Carly realized that she had no idea she'd been out of commission for two loops.

“Well—” Carly started to say, but Shireen interrupted with, “Where’s Adam?”

Carly cocked her head. What did she mean, *where’s Adam*?

“He took off already?” Carly hedged. She didn’t think he actually would, but the alternative wasn’t possible.

“No,” Shireen said. “When I restarted, he wasn’t even in the room. He was never there.”

Shireen had said the words Carly was terrified to hear. There had to be a misunderstanding or something. Even though Shireen had no reason to lie, Carly went into the office to check. She didn’t just observe that he wasn’t in the room, because she also looked behind the curtains, under the desk, in the small closet and at one low point lifted a stack of paper to see if maybe all six foot of him was under there. Then she went from room to room in the funeral home, calling his name like he was just playing a very mean game of hide-and-seek.

It wasn’t until she went out under the piercing sun that she realized if Adam *were* there, he’d be by her side. But Shireen was right.

Adam was gone.

Shireen spoke—something about going to get help—but Carly had a hard time focusing.

What if something in the eclipse changed so drastically that Adam won’t return?

What if I never get to kiss this man again?

Where the hell is he?

Carly’s thoughts came so fast that she couldn’t lock on to any of them. As soon as one came, another zoomed in to distract her. It was almost like her brain was a salad spinner, and the thoughts were strips of lettuce, crashing into each other and flying around in a maddening circle. At some point, she was so overwhelmed that she crouched low to the ground, hung her head between her knees and covered her ears. She couldn’t hear anything except a blaring white noise in her head.

She finally snapped back when Shireen shook her shoulder, shouting, “Carly!”

Carly took her hands from her ears. She sat on the gravel driveway and sucked in one long, steadying breath, then let it out, the same way her therapist had encouraged her to do when her ADHD was in overdrive. She repeated that two more times.

Eventually, Carly swallowed down her own fear, looked up at Shireen and said, “You were gone, too.”

Carly explained the last loops—Shireen’s disappearance and that, as far as they knew, no one else had gone missing. Shireen listened to all of it and tried to hide her reaction when Carly brought up Adam and Dean’s confrontation. She wanted to word vomit the facts as quickly as possible so she could get on with the bigger task of bringing Adam back.

“Do you feel any different after this reset?” Carly asked. As far as they all knew, the time between the eclipse and a reset was just a snap of the fingers. But Shireen had been gone for multiple loops. Had she felt that time pass?

Shireen shook her head. “I kind of don’t believe what you’re telling me. In my mind, I reset and came straight here. I didn’t miss a day, or any time at all. It’s only Adam missing that makes me think you’re telling the truth.”

Carly pushed herself up, feeling lightheaded from the near anxiety attack. If Shireen was able to come back, Adam would, too. But Carly had to channel Adam in that moment—gather the facts and come up with a plan to bring him back. That was doable. She could do *this*.

When they arrived in town, Shireen parked her SUV at the top of Main Street. But when they got out, the first thing Carly saw was a blow-up swimming pool filled with stuffed animals—enormous giraffes, big fat elephants, tiny fuzzy cats, teddy bears with bows, bunnies with fluffy tails—and toddlers jumping onto the pillowy pile with utter glee. Farther down the street was a group of skateboarders moving in time to the beat the drum circle was putting out.

What was going on? Why wasn’t anyone else concerned?

“How do we start this?” Shireen asked.

Carly wasn’t sure. She’d had Adam as her partner, and without him, she felt unsteady. But then she spotted Mayor Franco in a purple cowboy hat and matching boots headed toward Moms Pie House. Mayor Franco had been her lifeline before Adam, and Carly could use her help again today.

Carly jogged to catch up. “Mayor Franco!”

The mayor turned, and when she saw Carly she tipped the front of her hat in a hello. “Good for you to keep up with exercising. And to go for a run in combat boots. You’re hardcore!”

Carly caught her breath but quickly said, "Adam is missing."

"Well, I can *see* that," the mayor said. "Where is he this morning? Playing basketball? Cleaning gutters without the assistance of a ladder? What else do obscenely tall people do?"

She was not getting this at all. "No, I mean, Adam's *missing*. He's vanished, just like Shireen did. He's not in Julian."

"Oh," Mayor Franco said, but still looked bewildered. "I see Shireen is here, though. That's good news, right?"

Talking to Mayor Franco was a bad idea. She shook her head and turned back toward the street. Carly's heart pounded so loudly her ears started to hurt. Could it really *just* be Adam who was gone?

"Shireen!" Dean's voice came from behind them, and Shireen looked from Dean to Carly.

"You go," Carly said quickly. They had a lot to catch up on, and Carly didn't have time to listen to the recap. She had to bring Adam back. "I'll keep looking."

Carly went into every open storefront and spoke to as many people who were willing, but no one had seen Adam. At one point, she spotted red hair through the Main Street crowd and ran toward it with blinding intensity only to find that it was a mannequin someone had pulled from a clothing store.

Carly calmed herself with the knowledge that if Adam was missing, he'd surely come back in the next reset or two. Shireen had returned. Adam would, too. But Carly knew she had to tell Adam's parents before they found out from someone else.

She approached Shireen and Dean on the sidewalk and said, "We have to tell Bill and Sheila."

"Right." Shireen focused on the ground.

Carly's car was parked outside her dad's place. She hadn't been back there since . . . "Can I borrow your car?" Carly quickly asked.

"Oh, of course." Shireen pulled the key ring out of the back pocket of her jeans and tossed them to Carly. "Do you want me to come? I know them very well, obviously."

"Me, too," echoed Dean. "I could come."

"I'll handle this on my own," Carly said. "You both have unsettled business with Adam's family. You know, destroying the marriage and friendship thing?"

Shireen sharply exhaled. "I see your point. Okay, we'll keep checking the storefronts here. See if anyone else is missing or has seen anything."

"Thank you," Carly said. "I know you probably don't want to spend the first day back looking for Adam, but when you went missing, that's pretty much all we did."

"I believe it," Shireen said. "Don't worry, we'll find him."

Carly held on to that sentiment as she drove to Bill and Sheila's house. Maybe, by some loop miracle, Adam would be waiting for her there. Perhaps, unlike Shireen's disappearance, Adam was simply misplaced.

When Carly knocked on the door, though, and Bill and Sheila answered with kind smiles, she understood that she'd be breaking the news to them. They sat in front of the fireplace in the living room and Carly tried to stick to the facts, just as Adam would want.

"Adam didn't show up with the reset this morning." Her heart clenched with each word. "Shireen came back, though. And she and Dean are searching through town to see if anyone has seen Adam, or if others are missing."

Sheila's hands instantly went to her mouth, and Bill's face fell. "Shireen is back," he said. "So Adam will be back, too."

"Of course he will," Sheila said. She grasped onto Bill's hand for support. Carly had grown so used to having Adam by her side that she flexed her fingers for him, then hugged herself as she remembered he wasn't there.

"Shireen was gone for two loops, so we can assume Adam will be back after two as well," Carly offered. "But I wanted you both to know what's happening. I'm going to keep searching until he's back."

"We are, too." Bill stood from the love seat and extended a hand to Sheila, pulling her up. "We can go to the funeral home and search the tree house. We'll look for any clues we can find."

"Great," Carly said, and felt some weight lift off her shoulders. When Shireen had gone missing, Adam wanted to keep the search more contained. But maybe with extra help, he'd return faster than two loops. "How about we meet in town around sundown? Maybe I can convince Mayor Franco to hold another town hall."

"Telling the whole town? Oh, God, that's so serious." Sheila wiped her nose with a tissue; her eyes were red rimmed and she seemed to be holding back her grief.

"I know, it's a lot." Carly leaned forward. "But if we want to find Adam, I don't think it hurts to have everyone looking for clues."

"Absolutely, yes, okay, we'll meet you in town at sunset." Sheila seemed to straighten at the words, a soldier giving herself an order.

And Carly knew she had to break the other news to them. "Just so you know, Shireen and Dean will probably be there, too. I hope that's okay."

"Oh, honey, you know, we didn't tell Adam this, but we said our piece to them early on. We made sure they were okay." Bill's tone was even and measured, like he was just commenting on the weather.

Which made Carly certain that she hadn't heard correctly. "Made sure *they* were okay?"

"We've known them since they were kids," Sheila clarified. "Our families spent holidays together. It's not so easy to just never speak to someone again."

"But they broke Adam's heart." Carly's brows furrowed in confusion. She waited for Bill and Sheila to say something, anything, to make her feel better about the fact that Adam's parents had checked in with his ex-wife and ex-best friend and kept those things from him. But they didn't. And while she knew Adam wouldn't want her to say anything, she couldn't help but stand up for him. "With all due respect, I heard you tell Adam that he doesn't open up, but there seems to be a lot of secrets in this house. Seems unfair to expect him to share his feelings when you can't share yours."

Carly didn't want a big confrontation—that wasn't her goal—she'd spoken on Adam's behalf and defended him, but she didn't want to waste time arguing. Not when she could be doing something to bring him back. Without looking at Bill and Sheila, she stood up and made her way to the door. She was vaguely aware of their murmurs and footsteps but chose to move forward. As she reached for the door handle, though, Bill stopped her.

"I think you're right," he said. "I mean, I *know* you're right. It's just hard to change."

"It is hard to change," Carly said, thinking of how long it had taken her to change. But meeting Adam had opened her up to sharing her story about Bruce. So she knew that change was possible. She hadn't understood that Adam had shifted part of who she was but now she realized he definitely had. "But I hope you try, for Adam's sake."

As Carly walked out the door and headed for the car, she understood that she'd just meddled in Adam's business. But Adam wasn't there to stand up

for himself, and even if he was, Carly wasn't sure he'd speak up on his own behalf. She'd have to tell all of this to Adam when he returned, and she hoped he'd be understanding.

She turned the car on, took a deep breath and decided to go find Dr. Song and Rick. They were the people Adam had asked for help with Shireen's disappearance, so maybe they could focus on bringing Adam back instead.

By the time Carly found the Caltech van outside Rick's airstream, and told Rick and Heather all the details about Adam's vanishing, they were minutes away from the eclipse.

"No change in the time," Heather told Carly when the eclipse ended. "So it's stayed stagnant since Shireen went missing. The only changes being Shireen and Adam's presence here. Stands to reason that as they vanish, the eclipse remains stable."

"Well, the eclipse staying the same is a good thing, maybe?" Carly squinted against the light coming through the trees. "Maybe it's just this thing where one of us vanishes and then pops back up a few days later. That's not so bad, right?"

"Newton's third law," Dr. Song said, almost under her breath. She scratched her head and almost pretended that she didn't say it.

Carly was afraid, but said, "I can tell I'm not going to like this."

"For every action, there's an equal and opposite reaction." Heather kicked a pink flamingo, and it fell with a whomp onto a pile of dry leaves.

"Hey," Rick's worried voice broke through as he rushed to straighten the flamingo.

"So I just kicked that piece of pink plastic, right? As a result, the flamingo fell, hit the leaves and the leaves scattered to the side." Heather bent to help Rick put the flamingo upright again. "So we have to wonder, why did Shireen vanish in the first place? Was her disappearance a reaction to something? And why did she return? We could argue that the action of Adam vanishing caused Shireen to return, but why? What did Adam *do* to bring Shireen back here? And what action will we have to take to bring him back?"

"Fuck," Rick said, removing his prescription goggles. "She keeps hitting scientific home runs."

"Oh, thanks." Dr. Song waved his compliment off, but a blush crossed her cheeks.

Carly was trying to make sense of what Heather had said. *For every action, there's an equal and opposite reaction.* It sounded like something Adam would rattle off. What had Adam done to trade places with Shireen, though?

"I'm telling you what, the aliens would have a field day with this one." Rick angled a proud thumb in Heather's direction.

If Adam had heard that, he'd roll his eyes and bite back a comment. For the first time all that loop, Carly couldn't help smile as she imagined what Adam would say about all of this.

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Chapter 27

Carly

Day 253

There was a saying about how distance makes the heart grow fonder and Carly could, in fact, confirm this. Because as the tingling on her skin vanished and the funeral room came into focus, there was a kind of anticipatory flutter in her stomach.

Was Adam waiting in his office? Would she get to tell the crazy story of how he'd vanished? How long would it take for him to kiss her?

"He's not here!" Shireen shouted down the hallway.

Carly's nails dug into her thighs. *Breathe, breathe, breathe*, she told herself. She sucked in one long, steadying breath, then let it out and repeated it again and again.

Adam hadn't returned.

But that was okay. That was normal! Shireen didn't return until the third loop. For Adam, that meant he'd be back tomorrow.

Carly turned at a knock, and Shireen leaned against the door frame with a sad expression. She came down the aisle of chairs and took a seat next to Carly.

"I'm sorry that I never checked in on you in all these loops." Shireen played with the wedding ring on her finger. "I can't imagine what it's like to see your dad like this every day."

“I’ve sort of gotten used to it. Or numb? It’s hard to tell.” Carly swallowed and studied her hands.

“My dad died when I was five.” Shireen’s gaze met hers, and there was an unspoken kinship.

Carly grimaced. “I’m sorry. I think this is the worst club I’ve ever been part of.”

“Yeah, Dead Dads Club suuuucks.” Shireen elongated the last word, and they both let out an unexpected chuckle. “I always wanted to get married. I was one of those girls who had a box under my bed with pictures printed out of wedding gowns and decor ideas. I think I just wanted to re-create the family I lost, ya know?”

“Do you still love Adam?” Carly asked, though she was afraid of the answer.

“He was my first everything.” Shireen took off the wedding ring and held it in her palm. “And he’s a really, *really* good guy. Part of me will always be in love with the idea of what we could’ve been. But we fell out of love a long time ago.”

Shireen pocketed the ring. “Do *you* love him?”

Carly’s brows shot up from the question. Did she love Adam? Without him, she felt like a piece of her had vanished, too. But she couldn’t love him—it was too soon for that.

“We really like each other.” Carly leaned back in the chair and crossed her arms. She felt like that wasn’t totally true, though, because what she felt was more than like. “A lot. We like each other a lot.”

“A lot is good.” Shireen gave her a small smile. “Like I said, he’s a good guy. And how you’re bringing everyone together to look for him is amazing. Should we do the same today? Split up and do a search party?”

Because of her ADHD, Carly would occasionally get fixated on something—watching all of Gillian Anderson’s performances, making the perfect cup of matcha, hitting ten thousand steps every day. Once she’d mastered the thing, though, her interest waned.

Finding Adam would be her new challenge. If she could focus her energy on bringing him back, maybe all the effort would pay off. And so, channeling Adam, she said, “Insanity is doing the same thing over and over and expecting a different result.”

Shireen gave Carly a knowing look. “Now you’re sounding like him.”

“If that helps bring him back, then I’m all for it.” Carly ran a hand through her hair as she gathered her next thoughts. “I’d like to talk to Rick and Heather. Maybe see if there’s a science angle we can follow. Would you and Dean be willing to check if anyone else is missing?”

“Absolutely, we’ll do that.” Shireen stood from the chair, ready to get going. “Do you need a ride into town?”

“Actually, could you drop me at Bill and Sheila’s?” Carly stood, too. “I’ll check in with them first.”

“Yes, good call.” Shireen started down the aisle, but Carly was still stuck to the spot.

“I’ll be out in a minute,” Carly said. Shireen gave her a nod, then headed out of the room.

Carly turned to face her dad. She’d been so wrapped up with Adam that she hadn’t had a moment to check in with Bruce. She approached the coffin and laid her palms on the lid. “Just when I thought the loop couldn’t get weirder, people have started to go missing,” she said. “And I haven’t done a daily good deed the way I normally do. I spent all of the last loop looking for the guy I told you about, the one I like.”

She sniffled a bit, unexpectedly becoming emotional over Adam. That was normal for her, though; she’d just tried to forget how scared she was that Adam was gone. “What would you do, Dad?”

She waited for Bruce to respond, or to send some kind of sign. Instead, there was just the stretch of silence she’d grown used to. “Okay, see you next loop.” She let out a breath she hadn’t realized she’d been holding and headed out to meet Shireen.

Breaking the news to Adam’s parents that he, once again, had not reset, was a devastating blow. The only solace Carly stressed was that, like Shireen, he’d return the next day.

“What are we supposed to do?” Sheila tearfully asked.

They hadn’t made it past the home’s entryway, and Carly regretted not waiting until they were all seated before telling them about their son. Because Sheila had all but collapsed into Bill’s arms and he held them both firm.

“Before Adam vanished, a woman in town told us, ‘the best way to predict the future is to create it.’” Carly remembered how adamant Adam

had been about this sentiment. “And I know he took that to heart. He tried to act like Shireen was still in the world. I’m not sure if that’s helpful, but maybe preparing as if he’s about to come home at any moment will make it real.”

“Is that what you’re going to do? Just pretend like he’s here?” Bill asked.

“No,” Carly admitted. “My version of that is proactively trying to find answers, so I want to talk to Dr. Song. I think it’s what Adam would want.”

“This is like a living nightmare,” Sheila said through a sob. “To not know where he is. To not know if he’s in pain.”

Carly’s body clenched from the emotions in the room and those words. She’d tried to block out the idea that Adam would be feeling anything, and instead thought of him as being in a kind of holding room.

“Shireen said she felt nothing. When she reset, it was like no time had passed,” Carly offered. “Would you feel better if you came with me?”

“No.” Sheila blew her nose into a tissue. “You go, look for Adam. I just need a moment to gather myself.”

“Thanks for checking in.” Bill gave Carly a grateful smile and continued to rub Sheila’s back as Carly opened the door and headed out on her mission.

Walking all of Julian to find a scientist and a doomsdayer wasn’t an option—not in Carly’s combat boots. As she journeyed back to town, she spotted an abandoned bicycle, tried it on for size and was delighted to find that, while not a perfect fit, it would do the job. She biked to the bungalow, but there was no sign of Heather and Rick. So she biked down the dirt road that led to Rick’s airstream in the woods.

And that was where she found them, amidst the plastic pink flamingo haven, loading up Rick’s golf cart.

“Where’s your man?” Rick called out to her.

“He’s not back yet.” Carly flipped the kickstand on the bike to park it. She was tired from all the pedaling, and her ass had gone numb from the seat. Still, she’d found them. “I wanted to see if either of you had noticed anything that might be helpful.”

“Nothing since we last saw you,” Dr. Song said. “But I’ll be keeping an eye on the sky while Rick tries to pop the bubble.”

“We trade off,” Rick said. “She gets a day to drag me around looking at bullshit shadows, and then I get a day to find the weak spot in the fence.”

Carly thought that their pairing was one of the more jarring parts of the time loop: a doomsday overachiever and a science professor. But nonetheless, they'd found each other, hadn't they? She supposed a screenwriter and a mortician might be an unlikely pairing as well . . .

"You coming or what?" Rick said as he scooted into the golf cart and started the engine.

Carly looked back toward her bike. She couldn't pedal anymore, and where would she even go? She'd been hell-bent on finding Heather to ask her about theories, so she might as well ride along.

Carly came to the golf cart and Rick pointed to the back cab, which she climbed into. "Hold on tight," Rick called out as he turned the key. The engine purred and he shifted the cart into Drive.

Carly held on to the handrail as the golf cart jostled them down the dirt road. "What happens when you reach a new spot on the perimeter? Do you just, drive at it?" Carly ducked to avoid the branch of a nearby tree.

Rick veered off the dirt road and into the woods. "I usually walk. Driving straight at it feels a bit too much like a roller coaster to me."

The terrain they were going over was wildly uneven, and Carly had to grip both sides of the cart to stay inside of it. They reached a spot in the woods, overgrown with blueberry bushes and tall oak trees. Rick parked the cart, then got out. He took the map from Carly and studied it. "We're about a hundred feet from my next target," he said.

"I'm staying back to time the eclipse." Hannah pointed to the sky. "We've got another hour until that happens."

"So there's really nothing new? No theories other than the wormhole at this point?" Carly stepped on a dry, crisp twig and it snapped so loudly in the quiet forest that she jumped.

"Afraid not." Heather pulled her long hair up into a high and tight ponytail. "At this point, watching Rick cross through the perimeter might help reveal some of that exotic matter that we're hoping to find more of. Buy us more time."

"I've never crossed the perimeter," Carly said. There was so much she couldn't control about the eclipse, she didn't want to add another unknown into the mix.

"I can tell you from experience that it doesn't hurt." Rick cracked his neck, then his knuckles—a fighter prepping for a match. "You coming?"

Carly could spend the rest of the day hunting for Adam, or she could step through the bubble and into the next loop, where he'd be resetting, too. What was the point in spending the next few hours in a state of high anxiety when she could skip to the good part?

"Would it help to watch me vanish, too?" Carly asked Heather, figuring that might be a better reason to walk ahead.

"Sure." Heather nodded. "Let Rick go first, and then you can follow after. That way, Rick can test out two points on the map, right?"

"My lord, this woman gets it." Rick proudly puffed out his chest.

Carly couldn't help wonder what their relationship was *exactly*. But before she could dwell too much, Rick began to walk toward the edge.

"Go in about ten feet to my left once I vanish, okay?" Rick asked.

"Will do." Really, Carly shouldn't have been worried. Rick did this same thing almost every loop, as did plenty of other people in town. Still, as she watched Rick vanish, and then began her own steps toward the edge, her anxious ADHD thoughts crept in.

Maybe this time I won't wake up.

What if Adam returns but I don't?

Maybe I don't deserve to come back at all . . .

Carly took in a breath, and an even bigger step, and then there was a weightless snap that made her vision go black.

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Chapter 28

Carly

Day 254

One moment she'd been in the woods, crunching through leaves, and the next there was the feel of the folding chair underneath her. But a folding chair was good, because it meant she'd reset, and so had Adam. Carly stood and spun to face the door of the funeral service room. She ran toward it.

"Adam!" she called out, maybe a little giddy.

Yes, she was anxious, and excited and floating at the idea of seeing him again. She had so much to catch him up on. Where to even start? There was the eclipse staying stagnant, how he'd swapped places with Shireen, the conversations she'd had with his parents—

Carly stopped running as she came to the hallway and saw Shireen. Shireen shook her head.

Carly's mouth opened in shock. "He's not here?"

"Adam didn't reset with me." Shireen crossed her arms and gave an apologetic look. "I'm sorry, Carly."

Carly blinked back tears and took a breath. She'd convinced herself that Adam would reset. The loop returned Shireen in the same amount of time—why not Adam?

Shireen's arms wrapped Carly in an unexpected hug, and that was when the tears came. She'd tried to keep her despair pushed down, but she couldn't any longer.

“Where is he?” Carly asked through a sob.

“I’m sure he’ll be back the next loop.” Shireen hugged her tighter.

But he wasn’t back the next loop, or the one after that. Four more loops passed, and no one had seen Adam. No one else had gone missing, either, from what they could tell. The eclipse remained at 2:47. Everything was normal, except for the most important person in Carly’s world vanishing.

On the eighth loop with Adam missing, Carly had grown tired of waiting for something to happen. She was angry, actually. What the hell was this loop playing at in not giving Adam back? She’d been patient (or tried to be), but she wasn’t willing to spend any more time without him. She remembered what Heather had told them: *Every action has an equal and opposite reaction*.

Carly was going to retrace her steps with Adam to see if something happened that caused him to vanish. Maybe if she replaced the anxiety about Adam with the memories of him she loved most, it could bring him back. Maybe, by living in the places they’d spent time, he’d come back to those spots, too. Equal and opposite reactions.

“Wish me luck, Dad,” Carly told Bruce before leaving the funeral home.

She skipped the pity party with Shireen, too, and quickly started the walk into town, the way she had so many times. The walk was a bit of a balm, in that this was familiar territory. Carly hadn’t realized how much Adam had infiltrated not only her thoughts, but associations as well. As she walked past the pasture where the terrifying cows had been, and Adam had (maybe rightfully) teased her, she was reminded of him. When she got to Main Street and tripped over a crack in the sidewalk, she remembered the spot where she’d stage kissed him.

Her first target was the library—the time when she’d admitted she wanted to kiss him, even without scientific reasons. Carly walked through the sliding glass doors and headed straight for the nonfiction section. She found the aisle with the Kip Thorne books. What would Adam want her to find in these? She took every Kip Thorne book on the shelf and brought them to a long table to start sorting through. As she cracked open a book, though, she got the distinct sense that it wasn’t the words she was meant to consume, but the memories.

Carly walked through the library, past the rows where Adam kissed her, and the desk where he’d sat her down and she’d moaned his name. Instead of allowing her mind to spin out of control with “what-if” scenarios, she

closed her eyes and tried to remember the buttery smell of Adam, the way his fingers scratched her back as he pulled her in, the wicked grin he got before giving her pleasure.

When she left the library and walked to the French bistro they'd spent time in, she admittedly felt calmer. Something about reliving those memories brought him back, if only briefly, and having the memory of Adam was better than no Adam at all.

She ate thick slices of cheese and baguette outside where the bistro string lights dangled above her head. She remembered exchanging barbs with Adam there. What she wouldn't give for him to tease her in that moment. *Cheese comes from cows*, she could almost hear him saying.

When she'd finished, she walked along the sidewalk and found a discarded bike. She pedaled all the way to Adam's house, where she climbed the steps to the tree house and sat in the middle of the floor to time the eclipse. 2:47. No change.

Carly rode the bike up a steep mountain to the observatory, where she watched the sunset and recalled their trip to observe the stars. On the way back to town, she stopped in the orchard, lit by the night sky, and swiped a red apple from a tree. She took a bite of the juicy fruit, and the sweet smell brought back the feel of Adam pressed against her, and how he took her hand in his to trace the constellations.

She watched the stars, just as Adam would've. The air grew cold and she curled herself up to stay warm. In the morning, he might reset. In the morning, her actions might have an equal and opposite reaction. In the morning, the future she wanted might be waiting.

Chapter 29

Carly

Day 260

Carly accepted she might not see Adam. She knew that he'd been gone for eight loops, and this one might not be any different. So she braced herself for disappointment as she pushed up from the folding chair and made her way down the aisle of the funeral room.

Before she could leave, Shireen appeared in the door frame.

"What are your plans today?" Shireen asked. "Dean and I were thinking of going to this creek with a few innertubes. I know it's not searching for Adam, but I think we could all use a break."

Carly was certain that time had stopped. She grasped onto the back of a chair for support and fell to her knees in the middle of the aisle. She began to rock herself, and at some point, she felt Shireen's hand on her shoulder. "Carly . . ."

"I thought he'd be here," Carly croaked out. She'd braced herself and known this was a possibility, but the reality was still impossible. "I thought . . ."

Finishing the sentence was too painful. Because that was exactly what she was—in pain without Adam there.

Shireen sat cross-legged next to Carly. "When I lost my dad, my mom said for years afterward I would say things like, 'Dad's with me,' or 'Dad is

here.' His body had left, but his spirit was still there, watching over us. I don't think Adam is *gone*, because I haven't felt him go away. Have you?"

Carly shook her head. She'd been brought back into their memories but hadn't sensed him there beside her.

Shireen continued, "And with your dad, do you ever kind of get a feeling like he's watching over you?"

Come find me, Carly girl. Bruce's words echoed in her head. She'd sensed him on a few occasions, and whenever she was in a space he'd occupied. "Yes," she eventually said.

"Just hold on to that." Shireen's expression had become concerned. "Are you going to be okay? Do you want to come with me?"

Carly pushed her glasses up so she could swipe a tear from her eye. "I'll be okay."

Shireen pushed to stand and said, "I really loved your dad's movie theater, by the way. I sometimes took a long lunch break, got popcorn and would watch a movie by myself. He created a magical space."

Then Shireen walked down the aisle and out into the hallway. When the sound of the door opening and closing came, Carly stood and approached the coffin.

"I hope you heard that compliment," Carly said. She hadn't spoken to her dad in a real, honest way in some time. And she was relieved to have a reason to do so. "I haven't given up on finding you, either. I haven't forgotten what you told me."

Come find me, Carly girl.

Bruce's voice rang as clear in her head as it had the first time she heard it. She actually looked down, half expecting that he'd spoken. But there was nothing, just the unending hum of the air conditioner. "I'll go to the theater today," she said. "I'll come find you."

The theater was another place where she and Adam had spent time, but Carly had been reluctant to return to. It had proven to be an emotional place, and she was someone who had so many of those.

As she walked down the Main Street sidewalk, Spider-Man skateboarded past and offered her a wave. Goldie rode through the street with a red-and-white-striped bikini, letting everyone know there were twelve hours remaining. And then Carly spotted The Last Showing marquee in big black letters.

Carly stopped in front of the theater doors, hands on her hips, and took a big inhale. She could do this. She reached into the pocket of her dress, pulled out the key ring and unlocked the door. She was met with the scent of popcorn and carpet cleaner. The dangling stars overhead. The framed film posters. Her dad present in every fiber of the place.

“Hey, Dad,” she said to the room. “Never got to tell you that I really like what you built, but I do. It’s incredible.” She walked past the concessions stand and toward the door marked Employees Only. The supply closet was where she and Adam had been, where film canisters sat next to unopened paper products and rolls of red tickets.

Carly followed the line of films on the shelves until she landed on *Jurassic Park*. This was a movie she’d seen with her dad when he’d deemed her old enough—thirteen. The movie had been so epic, so utterly transcendent, that she’d spent the following year convinced she’d become a paleontologist.

If she was going to find her dad, this might be the best way. Carly loaded the film into the projector, hit the start button, then went to grab snacks. She made herself a candy salad and even turned on the popcorn machine for a fresh batch. She dove her hands into the buttery, sweet mixture and shoved a handful into her mouth as the opening credits of the movie began.

For the next two hours, she was engrossed. Completely transported out of Julian, and the loop and the reality that Adam might be truly gone. She lost herself to the orchestral score, visual effects and Jeff Goldblum’s shirtless scene.

When the end came, she almost forgot where she was, but then saw the empty rows of seats and remembered. “I know you’re watching over me, Dad,” she said. “But I don’t think I’ve found you quite yet.”

Bruce had lived in a one-bedroom bungalow close to town with a fenced-in front yard. She hadn’t been back in . . . a long time. And as she opened the gate, she’d forgotten about the lavender lining the walkway and the sign just above the door in the shape of a big movie ticket stub that read Admit One.

Carly let herself into the bungalow, and as she closed the door behind her, she anticipated the dread she’d had whenever she came. There would be the

scent of her dad, his well-worn flannel shirt hanging on a wall peg and knowing he'd never return.

She swallowed down her apprehension as she walked through the space. She stopped to read a note taped to his fridge: Call Carly, it simply said. She didn't know if it was a reminder or about something specific, but her finger traced the letters and his handwriting. She saw her dad all around, but knew he was gone. And maybe for the first time, she accepted that.

Her dad's desk had a stack of loose paper, a notebook and a Best Dad in the Galaxy *Star Wars*-themed coffee mug she'd gotten him one Father's Day. Carly sat in the leather chair, feeling the spots where Bruce had made his lasting imprints, and took a sheet of paper and a pen.

She hadn't written anything in so long, but it felt fitting that what she wanted to write was a tribute to Bruce. Because this time with herself, and her dad, gave Carly room to think. Her mind was clear.

She wrote into the night, late enough that she could hear the nearby chaos on Main Street starting to unfold. She filled two pages with good deeds she'd do for the people in town. She'd host free movie days at The Last Showing every few loops, with special matinee hours for the kids. She'd go to Rick Gaines's airstream and finish *Beaches* with him. She of course put Adam's name in big block letters on a sheet of paper and left it on its own. She still didn't know how to help Adam or bring him back, but she wasn't giving up.

She started to form a plan of what she *could* do. Maybe it wouldn't bring Adam back, but it would bring Bruce forward.

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Chapter 30

Carly

Day 261

When it came to asking for help, Carly certainly wasn't above that. She loved group projects and had no problem with someone else holding a door open. Which is why she knew that in order to make good on the plans she'd written out, she'd need help.

At the reset, she hurried to find Shireen. While Shireen drove them into town, Carly told her about the idea for a free movie day—a way to honor her dad. The help she needed was in getting the word out, which Shireen offered to do, along with the daily drive to visit Adam's parents.

So Carly would spend the day prepping the theater and hoping that someone showed up when they opened. Her high school summer job had been at the movie theater in the Burbank mall. The job was great because she got paid, it was air-conditioned, she ate concession snacks and, most important, she saw new movies. So when it came to reopening her dad's theater, Carly knew the mechanics.

There was the storage closet with movies, but Carly also found boxes of 16mm and 35mm movie film canisters in her dad's office. Mixed in with the newer releases, there was a collection of what her dad considered, "the classics," which he must have regularly screened. Since she wasn't entirely sure who in town would show up to the free movie day, Carly decided to

stick to films that would take the viewer out of the real world and into a fantasy: *Wicked*, *Coco*, and *E.T.*

Holding the copy of *E.T.* in her hands, she remembered when Bruce had taken her to see a re-release in their local theater for her seventh birthday. They'd watched it regularly on Friday nights at home, and they'd driven to watch it screened in the Hollywood Forever Cemetery when she was in high school.

Because of all those things, she had to show the film for her dad. If she was going to introduce the town to who Bruce was, this movie had to be part of that. If her intention was for everyone to meet the man they barely knew, then she had to be vulnerable, too.

Carly carried the three film reels out of storage when a knock at the front door made her stop. There was Hank the janitor, flanked on either side by two people Carly had never met. She set the reels down on the snack counter and unlocked the door.

"Hey there," Hank said with his easy voice. "We heard from Mayor Franco that you were planning to open up the theater for a free movie day and we wanted to help."

A high school-aged girl waved. "I'm Gemma. I worked here with Bruce. He talked about you all the time."

Carly swallowed down her shock. She hadn't considered that her dad might have told anyone about her. Gemma had said something that she probably didn't realize was so profound—or maybe she did.

"Thank you for telling me that, and for coming," Carly managed to say.

"And I'm Maeve," a twenty-something with a short purple mohawk and a vest covered in Pride flag buttons reached out their hand. "Nice to meet you. Bruce was such a cool guy. He used to tell us all these stories about being a cameraman. My favorites were when he'd spill on which celebrities were nice and which weren't."

"Oh my God, yes," Gemma said with a smile. "I told everyone at school about the *Night Avengers* story."

"Ah, and the actress who got bit by a rattlesnake in the middle of nowhere, so *he* had to suck the venom out of her leg!" Maeve bit their lip. "What I wouldn't give to suck poison out of some famous person's leg."

"Oh." Carly laughed, digesting all the information.

While she'd been in Burbank living life as usual, her dad had been here, meeting new people, sharing his history, building this theater and starting a

new life. Carly had been so convinced that he'd made a mistake and isolated himself, that she hadn't considered coming here had given her dad the opportunity to grow new roots. These two sharing stories about him was proof of that.

"The movies won't start for another four hours, though," Carly said.

"We came to help," Hank clarified. "No one knows the theater better than us, and it's the least we can do for Bruce."

"No," Carly said. She needed the help, but wanted to at least offer an out. "You don't have to do that."

"How do you plan to run three movies simultaneously, cover the snacks, take tickets and handle any maintenance issues that come up?" Maeve asked the rhetorical question.

"Okay, help accepted," Carly gratefully replied.

"Also," Gemma said, "we wanted to come to the funeral, but we didn't even know it was happening. It feels weird that we didn't get to say goodbye. This would be a cool way to do that."

The breath Carly didn't realize she'd been holding released, and her body suddenly felt about a hundred times lighter. *They'd wanted to come to the funeral?* News to her. She'd wondered why Hank hadn't attended. Though, had she told anyone about the funeral, other than the people he'd worked with in LA who couldn't make the trip in such a short time? They'd planned to hold a memorial for Bruce later in the month, back in Burbank where he belonged. But maybe what her dad would've wanted was a funeral in Julian, too, where he also, apparently, belonged.

"I'm so sorry," Carly said. "When I came into town, I didn't know anyone, or how to get the word out. It was just me."

No one said anything, but Hank's hand landed on her shoulder and he squeezed to acknowledge that that must've really sucked. And indeed, it had.

"We really want to help," Maeve reiterated. "And we'd love to do this for Bruce. He was the best."

He really was the best. Carly knew she was lucky. Despite becoming a single dad when Carly was a baby, he hadn't sent her to live with a great-aunt in another state. He hadn't impulse-married someone so that she'd have a mother figure in her life. He hadn't forced her to go to the batting cages because *he* liked baseball and needed her to like it, too. Well, he *had* done that once, but Carly had been so scared of the balls careening toward

her that Bruce treated her to an ice cream sundae afterward and promised to never take her back again.

No, Bruce had tried his hardest to fill the mom-size hole they'd both been left with. He only took jobs that filmed in town. He hired an older, reliable nanny to pick Carly up from school if his shoot was going to be running late and, when possible, he brought Carly to set so she could do her homework while he worked. Even though they both knew she spent most of that time watching the actors perform, listening to the scene and taking mental notes for how she'd rewrite something.

And this little team he'd hired was right—Carly was only one person. With three open screening rooms, and the possibility of people actually showing up, she needed help. So they got to work making sure everything was set for when the doors opened at six.

At six o'clock on the dot, when Carly went to the front of the theater, she wasn't surprised that no one was there waiting to be let in. From what she could tell, the theater was sparsely attended when her dad was alive. But then she stepped outside to place the chalkboard sign on the sidewalk, *Free Movies and Snacks!* When she did that, there was a line of people pressed against the side of the building, trailing all the way down the street.

Her gaze stopped on Shireen and Dean, who stepped out of line to meet Carly.

"They're all here for your dad," Shireen said. "Once we told people this was in memory of Bruce, there was no question. People stopped what they were doing to come."

"They came for my dad?" Carly eyed the line. She'd assumed Bruce was barely remembered here, but now . . . "I don't know if we can fit this many people."

"It's okay, we told them if they don't make the first showings, we'll hand out tickets for the next ones and they can come back without having to stand in line," Shireen explained.

"Smart. Wow. I am . . ." Carly was speechless. Bruce hadn't been able to bring the town out like this when he was alive, but now they wanted to show support? There were so many emotions swirling in her gut that she started to feel uneasy on her feet.

Dean grabbed on to Carly's elbow before she even had time to sway. "This is amazing, Carly. Look at what you and your dad were able to do."

Talking about Bruce like he was here felt so much more important than Dean probably even knew. It wasn't that Carly *liked* Dean as a person, but she felt less inclined to kick him in the shin.

This was the kind of moment Bruce had envisioned when he first bought the theater, Carly realized. He'd pictured a space to build community. Where parents could bring their kids to spend quality time together, watching someone else's art (sometimes his). She only wished he was physically present to see it.

"How are you feeling?" Shireen asked, maybe sensing her thoughts.

"I really wish my dad was here." Carly gave a sad smile. "And Adam."

Dean looked off, but Shireen held Carly's gaze as she said, "Don't forget what I told you—Adam will come back."

Movement on the ground caught Carly's eye, and just beside her were shadow bands flitting erratically, as if trying to get her attention. She could almost hear Adam telling her that shadow bands don't exist without the eclipse. But maybe this wasn't a shadow band at all. Maybe what she saw was something else. Before she could tell Shireen to look, they were gone. And she knew it was silly, but she felt like this was a sign telling her to keep going.

Carly unhooked the velvet rope, and one by one, the crowd trickled into the theater. Maeve and Gemma were stationed at the concessions stand. Hank served as a kind of usher, showing people to the screening rooms and directing them to the restrooms. And while Carly should've been helping, too, all she could do was take in the crowd admiring the framed posters and every little whimsical detail her dad had added.

Carly spotted a little girl who couldn't be more than seven staring at the *E.T.* poster. She bent to be eye level with her and asked, "Have you ever seen this one?"

The little girl shook her head.

"I was about your age when my dad took me," Carly said. "I bet you could watch this with some M&Ms, and it would be a pretty good day."

Her parents looked at the girl, then Carly. "Uh-oh, she said the M word," one of them joked. "Come on, let's get in line for the candy and then we'll go see it."

"Theater three!" Carly called out as they walked away.

When the screening rooms were filled, and tickets passed out for the next showings of the day, and the concessions stand so depleted of food and drinks that Hank agreed to go for a grocery run, Carly finally went into the theater showing *E.T.*

She walked down the row of seats, full of so many people she hadn't met. If she *did* stay stuck in Julian forever, she'd try to get to know them. She got to the first row of seats and stood just in front of the audience.

"Hi," Carly said. She tapped the mic in her hand. She'd much rather be in the back, getting ready to watch the film, but she had to give her dad the credit he deserved. "I want to thank all of you for coming today. It means the world to me and my dad to see each and every seat filled. And I'm speaking of him like he's here, because I think if he's anywhere, it's in this place that he was so excited to build.

"Bruce Hart was my dad, and when he told me about Julian, and this theater he'd bought, I thought he'd lost his mind. He took his life savings, his retirement nest egg, and poured it into this place. But the truth is, my dad's favorite moments were always in a movie theater or working on a movie set. Helping to tell stories and create magic. That was what made him happiest. So even though his time here was short, it was probably the most meaningful work he'd ever done.

"He wanted to build a place for people to create memories. So I'm glad you're here today, because right now we're all making a memory I'm sure we won't forget. To get to sit in a packed theater, surrounded by friends and people we love. The movies I picked were some of my dad's favorites. When I watch them, I think of him. And today, as you watch, I hope you get so lost in the story that you're transported by its magic. But after, I just ask that you think of my dad, too."

Carly looked out, and while the seats were full, there wasn't a sound. Which was saying something, considering the fact that there were children present. In a moment, the lights would dim, the movie would start, and maybe she'd get to transport herself somewhere else, too. Carly had missed this shared experience. Her dad had shown her the power of movies, and she was genuinely so happy to be giving that to other people.

She started to head back to her seat, but Hank stood in the aisle, took off his baseball cap and said, "Bruce was my boss here at the theater, but he was also a good friend. I was working here one afternoon when I got a call from my daughter's school. She'd twisted her ankle during PE and needed

to go to the hospital. I must've looked terrified. Bruce told me to take a moment and sit down. He got me water and gave me a bag filled with candy. He told me a story about how Carly had to go to the hospital when she was six after knocking a tooth out while jumping rope. He'd been terrified, too, apparently, but didn't let Carly see that."

Carly remembered the tooth incident. She'd also had to get a stitch on her lip—part of the reason she still had a little scar to show for it. But she didn't realize her dad had been scared. He'd been so calm as he drove them. He'd gotten her a chocolate bar from the vending machine to eat after they put the stitches in. She actually remembered it fondly.

"Bruce told me that I had to stay calm to get my baby through it. 'You can do this, Hank,' he told me." Hank looked down at his hands, and when he looked back up his eyes glistened. "Carly, your dad was a really special man. I'm so sorry he's not here with us today."

Carly's chin began to tremble. She'd lived for a long time in this town, believing her dad had wasted the last year of his life and made no connections. But he'd made a friend in Hank. He'd helped Hank. Knowing that meant something.

As Hank sat down, a woman with a kerchief tied around her neck stood up. She had to be in her fifties, with hair so blond she could be a Lannister. "Bruce used to drop his dry cleaning off at my store. No matter what, he always said something kind to me. One time he told me I was a dead ringer for Olivia Newton John in *Xanadu*!"

Carly couldn't help but laugh, because that sounded so much like her dad. She wiped a rogue tear from her eye.

Then a man with dreadlocks and a blazer stood up. "Bruce came into my bookstore once a week . . ."

The anecdotes went on, and on and on. Carly knew the other movies had started in the theaters next to them, as she could feel the walls rumbling, but no one seemed to mind. Carly listened as people she'd never met shared memories of her dad. Her heart was so full after an hour of hearing anecdotes that she couldn't stay to watch the movie when it began to play. Instead, she walked into the hallway, leaned against the wall and slid down until she was sitting on the carpet. She put her head between her knees and smiled. She'd learned so much about him in that hour, hearing how he treated and interacted with the world around him. And she was so deeply

grateful to be in this town, with people who had unique insights into who her father was.

Bruce had friends. Bruce had a community. Bruce would not be forgotten.

“I found you, Dad,” she said to herself.

There was the unmistakable feel of someone watching her. She lifted her head and glanced around, but no one was there. For a brief moment, she thought that she’d brought her dad back. For an even briefer moment, she’d wondered if Adam was there.

Carly must’ve spent more time in the hallway than she’d realized, because all at once the familiar pins and needles of a reset began to travel up her arms, and she braced herself for the next loop.

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Chapter 31

Adam

April 23

Adam tried to hold on to the warmth of Carly in his arms, but that was quickly replaced by the coolness of his hand on Shireen's shoulder.

Wait, Shireen . . . She'd been gone for two loops, and now she was here. He blinked into the reset and nearly tackled Shireen as soon as she came into focus. "You're back!" he exclaimed at the same time as she said, "You're back!"

Adam pulled away, confused, but sure she was having residual side effects. "Are you all right?" He held her face in his hands and inspected her eyes for signs of distress.

"Adam," she carefully said. "You were gone."

He paused. Could she be suffering a kind of head trauma?

"Shireen, I think you should sit down. I'll explain everything." He started to lead her toward the big leather chair behind his desk, but she grabbed his wrist.

"No, Adam, trust me. I came back many loops ago. I was gone for two of them. Then you vanished. You've been gone for a long time." She gave him a steadying look and he began to understand what she was saying.

"I was gone?" he asked.

"Yes." She sharply exhaled and released her grip on his wrist.

“And Carly?” He asked the question, but had already begun to open the office door. If Shireen had returned and Adam vanished, would Adam’s return mean that Carly had vanished?

He tripped out of the office, unable to keep up with the pace of his own spinning thoughts, and that was when he saw her: combat boots, black dress, glasses and the sweet round face dotted with a lush pout.

Carly. His Carly. She ran to him, and he ran to her, and he scooped her up and spun her around like they were in a damn movie.

“You’re here,” he breathed into her ear.

She pulled back, holding on to his arms and breathing heavily. Her eyes scanned him as she said, “You were gone for so long—ten loops.”

His eyes widened. Ten loops? He hadn’t felt any different. All he’d known was being with Carly after the vow renewal, and then the reset.

“Are you sure?” he asked.

Carly laughed. “I’m not a scientist, but I know how to count.” She tucked a strand of hair behind his ear and added, “I didn’t give up, though. Every loop I tried to bring you here. I didn’t know what it would take, but I knew you’d come back.”

Adam wanted to kiss her. He wanted to kiss her until they forgot that he’d been missing. He bent down to meet her when his phone rang in his jacket pocket.

He stilled. Carly stilled. Shireen came out of the office. “Is that your phone?” Shireen asked.

Adam reached for his cell, pulled it out of his pocket and saw the name Dad flashing on the screen. “Oh my God,” Adam said, swiping to answer the call. “Hello?”

Screaming. Lots of screaming was all Adam heard on the line when he answered. He had to hold it away from his ear and, as he waited for the screams of his parents to end, Carly and Shireen took out their phones, too.

Shireen was on a call with Dean. Carly typed furiously into her iPhone. “Hi, Marilyn,” she mumbled to herself. “Would love to discuss! Thank you so much for the read! I will get back to you with availabilities as soon as possible.”

Adam smiled at Carly, and she smiled back. A shiver ran through at the possibilities of what this could mean. Was the loop . . . over? Did they somehow only have cell service for a moment?

“Adam!” Sheila’s voice screeched from the phone.

“Mom, yes!” he finally answered. “I’m okay, I’m okay. Can you two come to the funeral home? I’ll see you soon.” Adam couldn’t quite understand his parents as they spoke over each other. But he hung up and put the phone away.

While he wanted to get back to kissing Carly, Shireen approached.

“I’ve been wanting to give this back to you for a while.” Shireen placed her wedding and engagement ring into Adam’s hand. Adam took off his wedding band, too. Shireen held his hand, and the place where their rings were. Her skin was cool against his palm, and he was suddenly grateful for this moment with her, where they could have a goodbye that was mutual.

“We both deserve to be happy,” she added. “I hope you find that again.”

Then Shireen gave Carly a nod, and she turned on her heel to head out the front door.

As soon as Shireen was gone, Carly began to sob, and he wasn’t sure if she was happy or sad. Adam led Carly to the sofa in the hallway, wrapped her in his arms and let her curl onto his lap. “What’s going on in there?” he gently asked.

“I just can’t believe that you’re here. Like, a small part of me worried I might not see you again, but now I’m . . . overwhelmed. I’m happy. I’m sad. I have a lot of feelings, okay?” She said all of this through tears. “This is who I am!”

“Don’t cry,” Adam said as he brushed thick tears away with the pad of his thumb. “Let’s figure this out together.”

Carly told him about the loop when he went missing; all of the ways she, Shireen, his parents and even Dean had tried to bring him back. She told him about trying to cause an equal and opposite reaction by reliving memories of him. He heard about the day she went to find her dad and came up with a plan to honor Bruce’s memory. And how, in the theater, she’d felt her dad watching over her.

When Bill and Sheila barged through the front doors, Carly gave Adam space to hug and reassure them. Adam found it hard to believe that he’d been gone, but he sensed the relief from his parents so strongly that it was impossible to deny.

“We’re going to therapy,” Sheila said. She wiped a spot on his cheek and added, “Family therapy, if that’s something you’d be open to. While you were gone, Carly reminded us that secrets have no place when it comes to

the people you love. And honey, we're just so sorry that we haven't been honest with you, and you haven't felt safe to be honest with us."

"We'll try and do better," Bill added. "I mean, as good as two old people can."

Adam chuckled. "Thanks, that means a lot to me."

His mom seemed to be waiting for him to say more, though, and then it occurred to him. "It's probably a two-sided coin? So, I'll make sure to get help, too. I want to be better for all of you." Adam spoke to his parents, but gave Carly a meaningful look at that last part.

"Should we go test the perimeter? See if we can actually drive out of here?" Bill asked.

Adam was still wrapping his head around being gone for so many loops and the cell phones working. He wanted to think before speaking, which meant Carly took the reins.

"I have a feeling there will be a bottleneck heading out of the main road in Julian," Carly said. "But I know someone who can show us a way."

Adam drove Carly, Bill and Sheila over to Rick's airstream. His dad, who had never taken a close look at the place, was fairly impressed by the flamingo motif.

"He's really committed to an aesthetic," Bill commented as he stepped out of the hearse.

"Cheap plastic is an aesthetic?" Sheila poked a flamingo and it immediately tipped over.

"I think Dolly Parton made cheap chic," Carly said. "Come on, let's see if Rick's home."

When they knocked on the door, though, there was no answer, not even the *Beaches* soundtrack playing in the background. Carly scanned the yard for a sign of him. "Maybe he's gone to find Heather? His golf cart is still here, though."

As they walked back to the hearse, the Caltech van rattled down the road and came to a skittering halt, blocking their path out. Dr. Song jumped out of the van and barreled toward them. "Adam, hey! You're here." She gave him a surprise hug, and he almost didn't have time to hug her back before she followed up with, "Rick? Have you seen him?"

“No, he’s not home,” Adam said, but she continued toward his airstream all the same. “His golf cart is here, too. We assumed he was with you.”

“Rick, open up!” Heather banged on the door. Then turned around, fisted her hands through her hair and said, “Last night we were in this orchard, and he told me he was going to grab a flashlight. I was focused on my telescope when I saw this blinding light. I mean, way too bright to be a flashlight. I called out his name and then reset.”

Adam wasn’t sure what to make of that story. He’d only just gotten back himself. Unless . . .

“Oh shit,” Carly said. “Do you think you traded places with Rick somehow?”

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Chapter 32

Carly

Carly sat in the passenger seat of the hearse and held on to Adam's hand while he drove them into town. Now that he'd returned, she'd never let go of that hand.

Well, that was an exaggeration. Much like Adam had pointed out when she'd hurt her back, she'd have to eat, pee and do things without him. But still! She was going to keep an eye on this Rhodes guy so he didn't pull a disappearing act again.

"Do you think Rick really vanished?" Adam asked. "We don't even know if the loop is over."

As they pulled the car up to Main Street, there was once again a stage erected in the middle of the road, and Mayor Franco held court on top of it. She slugged from a bottle of champagne and unlike previous loops, she wore her standard toned done outfit of a muted green pantsuit.

Carly stepped out of the car and a breeze swept through her hair, almost ushering her away from the scene. Indeed, she itched to drive out of town, but she also needed time alone with Adam. They had so many practical details to sort out, logistics and kissing to catch up on. For the time being, though, they had to find Rick.

"We have confirmation that folks are able to leave the Julian limits," Mayor Franco announced into a megaphone. She held up the bottle of champagne and took a long swig as cheers erupted from the crowd.

“I’m not going to enjoy announcing that Rick is missing,” Adam said to Carly. “Everyone’s so happy.”

“It’s the right thing to do.” Carly wrapped her fingers through his. “He helped look for you when you vanished.”

Adam pursed his lips. “So, you kinda missed me, huh?”

She gave his hand a tight grip, and he mouthed an “ow,” as they continued to walk. “I missed you, yes. The way old people can miss a step and fall down the stairs. It was painful and unexpected.”

“I know you’re a screenwriter, but have you considered poetry? That was really something.” He bent down and pressed his lips to hers, and Carly loved how her mouth knew him so well, even after so many loops apart. She was about to reach up and pull on the end of his fiery red hair, when a voice interrupted them.

“Toonces came home!” Megan Rae explained inches from their faces. She held the cat to her chest as evidence. “Poor little gal must’ve escaped the Julian limits right before the loop started. But look!”

Carly gave a genuine smile and reached out to pet the cat. “This is the best news. Other than you returning.” She added the last bit for Adam’s sake.

Then a commotion from the crowd erupted.

“They came!” someone shouted. “They found me!”

Carly searched for the voice, but didn’t have to look far, as Rick took the stage. Her mouth fell open in a gasp. “Oh my God.”

“Good people of Julian,” Rick spoke into the megaphone. “I am here to inform you that last night, while on a mission with my lady friend, I was once again contacted by the aliens. They took me into their ship and told me that I need to run for Mayor of Julian or they’ll return again and plunge us into an even longer loop.”

Carly looked to Adam, who had a frown so deep between his eyes she was sure it would be there permanently.

“Rick!” Heather’s voice came from the crowd and stopped Rick cold. He dropped the megaphone, hopped down from the stage and hurried toward her.

Mayor Franco had no problem picking the megaphone back up. “Aliens? That’s spooky! Maybe we can pass a law where two mayors can preside over Julian, hmm? I’d hate for another loop to start!”

“This loop is really weird.” Adam tightened his grip on Carly’s hand.

“I think we can call it a weird day, since we’re out of the loop,” Carly corrected him.

“Oh, right, where were we?” Adam tilted Carly’s chin up, brought her into him and kissed her again.

She let out a relieved sigh into his mouth. While he’d been gone, she’d all but resigned herself to a life without his hands or his mouth. Now that she was surrounded by his buttery scent, she wanted to clip this moment and keep it in a file in her brain so that whenever she felt lonely, she could reference this point where she was blissfully happy.

“What should we do after the kissing?” Adam muttered into her mouth. “Should we try to leave town?”

Carly wanted to be with Adam. She wanted to continue what they were starting. But before she could leave, she had to say goodbye.

“I have one last thing to do before we go.” She traced her thumb along Adam’s cheekbone and hoped he’d help her.

The space where Bruce was to be laid to rest was in a shaded part of the cemetery, surrounded by willow trees and a babbling brook. Bill lowered Bruce into the ground and Carly took a shuddering breath as the casket disappeared under a blanket of earth.

“Do you want some time with him?” Adam softly asked.

“I do,” Carly said. Adam kissed the top of her head, and when the world around her had gone quiet, she looked at the ground.

“Dad, this is a really beautiful spot. I see why you picked it. I mean, a babbling brook? Can’t find that in LA.” Carly sat next to his plot of earth and dug her hands into the dirt. “I’m sorry I didn’t come sooner. You told me you wanted to build something special—something of your own. I know you really did that here. I wish I’d come to celebrate with you.”

She picked up a handful of cool dirt and sprinkled it over the top of the mound. “The loop ended, by the way. I’m going to try and convince Adam to head back to Burbank so I can show him where I come from. But don’t worry, I’ll be back to visit.”

Carly had spent every loop restarting by her dad’s side. The idea of waking up tomorrow and not being next to him . . . that was hard to think about. She coughed on a sob and allowed tears to roll down her face. This was how she’d wanted to say goodbye to her dad—when she was ready.

And as she stood up, dusted off her dress and kissed her palm then held it to the earth, she felt that he was saying goodbye to her, too.

“Talk to you soon, okay?” she told him before she walked away from the plot and back toward the funeral home.

Packing up her car didn’t take long. Carly had only brought a suitcase with her when she first came to Julian. But she did add some of her dad’s movie memories to her bag. She’d have to come back to grab the rest, but for now—and the purposes of getting out—she had plenty.

“I’ll take that,” Adam said as he grabbed her suitcase and rolled it to the trunk of the car, where he placed it next to his own bag. He wore dark jeans, a blue cotton shirt and a leopard-print cardigan. He looked way cooler than any mortician had the right to be. But then again, if he got into Caltech, he wouldn’t be a mortician for long.

“Apple?” Carly called out, and the puppy appeared in the yard, wagging his tail. She picked up Apple, whom she’d found at the adoption site. She couldn’t leave Julian without him, too. “Time to go home.”

Carly got into the driver’s side and handed Adam their dog as he slipped into the passenger seat. He’d agreed to come with her to Burbank. Carly spent so much time exploring where he was from, and now she was ready to show him her little corner of the world.

“What do you actually think broke the loop?” Adam asked as he buckled his seat belt.

“Oh, God,” Carly said as she started the car. “I was sort of hoping we’d never talk about this again. Like, we tried out a weird sex thing and it’s just never going to be addressed because it didn’t go as planned.”

“We haven’t even explored my weird sexual things.” He raised an eyebrow.

“I don’t know what broke it,” Carly said. “I mean, I’ve been thinking about the wormhole theory. About negative energy. Negative mass? Whatever it is.”

“Well, negative energy makes antigravity, which is the *real* thing that keeps a wormhole open.” Adam sipped from the bottle of water in the cup holder.

“God, you’re cute when you’re nerdy.” She gave him a little cockeyed grin. “I don’t think you and Shireen were the negative mass, but I do think

it's tied to you and to me. You told Shireen you wanted her to move on, and then she vanishes. You confront Dean and your parents, and then Shireen returns, but you vanish. I finally found my dad. I acknowledged he was really gone, and now . . . no more loop."

"Grief is a powerful emotion," Adam acknowledged. "But I think we need to address the elephant in the room, which is the aliens."

Carly cackled as she pulled them out of the driveway of her dad's bungalow and onto the road that would take them out of Julian.

"Seriously, though," Adam said. "When I went to talk to Dean, that conversation was hard for me. I realized we were no longer friends. The loss of that friendship, I think, is almost harder for me to fathom than the end of my marriage."

"Maybe it never was a wormhole, or shadow bands, or aliens, or a hole in the bubble." Carly was spitballing, but that was kind of what she was good at, and what Adam liked about her. "Maybe it was something else, like we needed this time to let go of what was."

"You always said people were powerful." Adam handed Carly a potato chip and she crunched the salty perfection of it. Then he fed one to Apple.

As they drove down the streets of Julian, her heart began to race. "Is this really going to happen?" she asked. "What if we just . . . reset?"

"At least we'll reset together. I hope." Adam grabbed her hand as they came to the Leaving Julian sign, painted sky blue and dotted with red cartoon apples.

Carly was scared, though. She'd just gotten Adam back. What if they reset and she lost him again?

She pulled the car to the side of the road and took deep breaths in and out to try to steady herself. Adam took her face in his hands and stroked little lines across her cheek.

"Hey." His voice was calm. "You are the only thing I see right now. You're the only thing I want to see for the rest of my life. I lost ten days with you, but I'm not going to lose any more time. If we reset, fine. If we get to leave, even better. As long as I'm with you, I'll be happy. But as a very smart woman once said to me, 'What do you want?'"

Her gaze met his honey eyes, and her eager body melted for this man. "I want you," Carly said.

Adam brought his lips to hers and kissed her, slow and deep to show how much he loved that sentiment. He belonged to her, and she to him. And

when they eventually pulled apart, he smoothed his thumb over her cheek and said, "I love you."

And her lip trembled in shock because, she realized, she felt the same way. "I love you, too."

They kissed again, and Adam wrapped her in his arms and pulled her close. She loved him, and he loved her. Was there ever a feeling more sweet and wonderful than this one? She knew that she could loop this moment for the rest of her life and never be done with it. So when she pulled the car back onto the road and drove past the Leaving Julian sign and away from the bubble, they both kissed again with the knowledge that their life was only just beginning.

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Epilogue

Carly

December 31

“**W**hat are you doing?” Carly asked.

Adam and Carly sat on a flannel blanket in front of a bonfire. She burrowed herself into the blankets to keep warm. She’d never experienced a Julian winter, but the place got cold.

The flames of the fire licked the air and sent whooshes of heat toward them. Adam trailed his index finger slowly up her spine and then, when he got to the top, trailed it right back down. Little goose bumps erupted across her.

“I’m getting ready for tonight,” he said and nipped her neck.

“You’re getting ready for the New Year by . . . *touching* me?” Carly’s voice had gone husky from the buttery scent of him.

They’d come back to Julian to celebrate New Year’s Eve. Adam had the time off from Caltech, and no one in Hollywood worked after Thanksgiving. Carly’s screenplay had sold at auction, and would start production in the spring, thanks to Marilyn Montgomery’s mentorship. And she’d just turned in a draft of a new screenplay to her agent. They both had earned a break. She just didn’t expect outdoor sex to be part of that. Not that she was complaining.

“I’m getting ready to watch you come.” He said the words so casually, like he’d just asked if she were warm enough.

And, well, yes, she was *definitely* warm now.

“Watch me come . . . ? Come where? Come to the car so we can go back to our hotel and have sex somewhere that isn’t your childhood backyard?” Her gaze landed on his mouth, though, betraying her words.

Adam’s finger skimmed over her shoulder and down her arm. “We have to keep warm somehow.”

“Your parents—” she started to say.

“Are asleep,” he cut her off. “My dad was wiped from finishing up that mural on the side of the library this afternoon, and they never make it to midnight. Besides, we’re staying up to see the sunrise, right?”

Carly and Adam had gotten into a routine of watching the sunrise at least once a month. They’d taken that for granted before the loop, but they didn’t take much for granted now.

“What about Apple?” she asked.

“You know he’s asleep in the crate.” Adam bit his lower lip and her stomach filled with want. He’d made this same expression often, and it always resulted in her opening to him. She was only human, after all.

Carly leaned back and Adam pushed her knees apart. He put himself between her legs and hovered over her. She wrapped the blanket around them and he skimmed his fingertips over her thigh. Her fingers grabbed the back of his neck and pulled him in close.

They’d been out of the Julian loop for two years, but had visited often. Adam had to sell the family business and wrap up his finances with Shireen. And Carly had to hand the keys of the theater over to Hank, who had been more than excited by the idea of running his own business.

By some kind of magic, no one in the outside world knew about the time loop. As they’d all discovered, once you left the town, the ability to speak of it vanished. If Carly *tried* to talk about it while anywhere other than Julian, what came out was something along the lines of, “Julian is such a great place,” or “You should come visit Julian!” A bit horror movie-esque, but it was their reality. She could talk to Mayor Franco, Mayor Gaines, Sheila, Bill and Adam about the loop, but outsiders? They remained simply that—outsiders.

And Carly was grateful for that strange, twisted magic, because it meant that the memories she and Adam had of their time in the loop remained

theirs and theirs alone. She was interested in creating a fictional story, though: a movie about a fake idyllic town where a fake time loop happened and two fake people fell in real love. That sounded like the kind of thing Rhys Montrose might want to star in, in her humble opinion.

Adam slipped Carly's pants off, then her panties. A shiver ran through her and he trailed his knuckles up her calf as he said, "Let me touch you." He licked his lips, telling her exactly which part would be touching her. "I have to do something to take my mind off work."

On top of being a student at Caltech, Adam also held a part-time job as an associate with the International Dark Sky Community. He'd been promised a full-time role once he graduated, but was easing into the position slowly.

And, it appeared, he was also planning to ease into Carly's orgasm slowly. His fingers walked their way to her clit, and he circled her wetness there.

"Oh, fine." She dug her nails into his back, just the way he liked. "You can touch me, if it's in the name of science."

Adam gave her that mischievous grin; his honey eyes burned almost as brightly as his hair. "Your contributions are always invaluable."

When he dipped under the flannel to reach her, she tilted her head back and gasped as she stared gratefully up at the full moon.

Acknowledgments

This was a hard book to write. Not only because of the parental loss thread that forced me to process what it would be like to lose my own parents, but because time loops have a lot of rules, and science. Neither of which I'm particularly great at!

So I'd like to thank the internet for helping me deeply research wormholes, time loops and physics. I want to thank the movie *Palm Springs* for inspiring me to write a time loop book, but make it hornier. And I really and truly want to thank the team at Canary Street Press for allowing me to write this totally bonkers book. Delivering a book baby into the world is a group project, and I'm deeply grateful for everyone behind-the-scenes who helped make this dream a reality.

In the spirit of Carly and Adam, I'm writing the rest of my acknowledgments as a nod to their journey. In no particular order, I'd spend an endless time loop with the following people, doing the following things:

- Going to open houses with my mom, because we always have a good time at those.
- Cuddling on the couch with Eoghan, watching cozy British shows.
- Bouncing on the trampoline with Gemma.
- Digging through the dirt to look for roly-polies with Maeve.
- Sitting on lounge chairs in spa robes with Elisa.

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- Playing Pumpkins with Tom, Lizzy, Eoghan and Joseph.
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- Meeting and connecting with readers like you. Thank you so much for all of the support and love!

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